TEDDY ROOK BOOK · VOCABULARY LADDER

1,000 Words, Pictured

Volume 2 of 4 · Topics 26–50

Each card gives a word, how to say it (the capital letters are stressed), its meaning, a memory hook with a picture, an example and its Greek or Latin parts. To learn a word: say the hook out loud, picture the scene, then cover the card and try to recall the meaning. Come back to it tomorrow and again next week.

26. Noticing and Understanding
27. How Often
28. Helping Along
29. Who Rules
30. Unusual
31. Speaking and Saying: loqu and dict
32. Proud and Humble
33. Right and Wrong
34. Arguing a Case
35. Calm
36. Comparing and Contrasting
37. Beginnings
38. Getting in the Way
39. Guilt and Innocence
40. Big and Small
41. Turning, Throwing and Pulling: vert, ject and tract
42. Careful and Careless
43. Real and Fake
44. Tricky Twins
45. Fear and Worry
46. Learners and Experts
47. Peaks and Endings
48. Calming Things Down
49. Fighting and Making Peace
50. Everywhere

perceive per-**SEEV** *verb*



MEANING to notice or become aware of, through the senses or the mind

MEMORY HOOK **PEER and reCEIVE.** Sami peers into the night sky and receives a tiny flash of light: a shooting star! To **perceive** is to take in something with your senses.

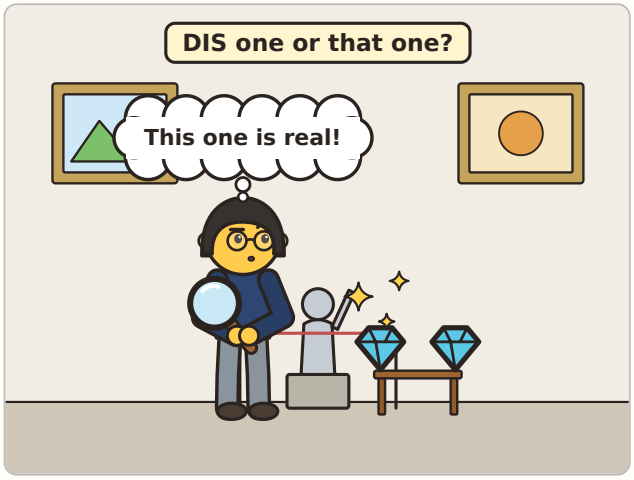
Owls can **perceive** *the tiny rustle of a mouse in the grass.*

PARTS **per** thoroughly + **ceive** take, seize (from Latin capere)

SIMILAR notice, detect, sense, observe

OPPOSITE miss, overlook, ignore

discern dih-**SURN** *verb*



MEANING to notice or tell apart, often with effort

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-CERN: is it DIS one?.** Two gems look exactly alike, but Ada's sharp eye can tell that this one is real and that one is glass. To **discern** is to tell things apart.

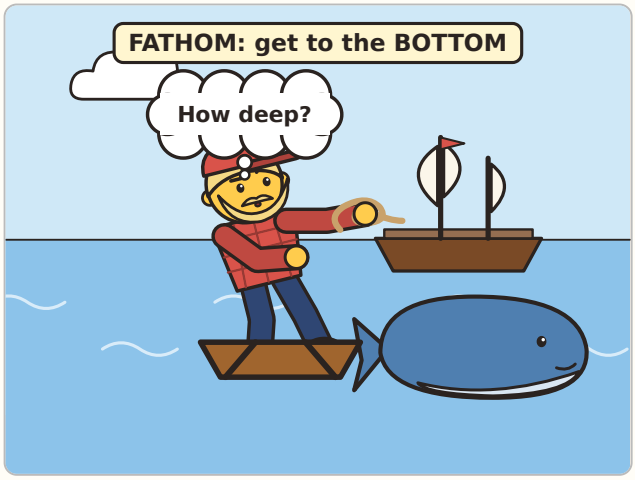
In the fog, Dad could barely **discern** *the outline of the barn.*

PARTS **dis** apart + **cern** separate, sift

SIMILAR distinguish, detect, make out, tell apart

OPPOSITE overlook, confuse

fathom **FATH**-um *verb*



MEANING to understand something fully, after much thought

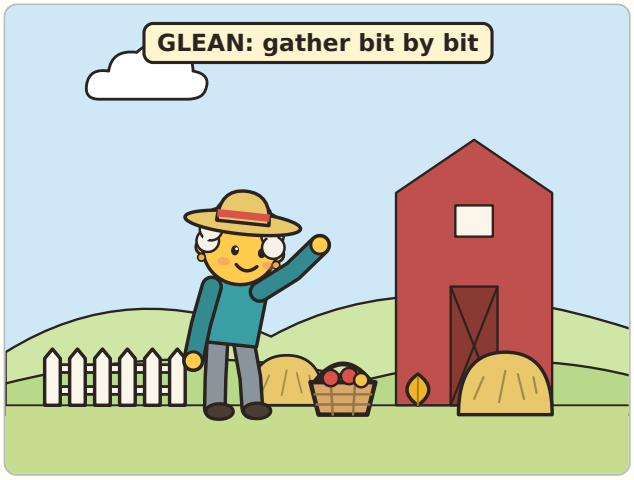
MEMORY HOOK **FATHOM: get to the BOTTOM of it.** Sailors once lowered a weighted rope to find the depth of the sea in fathoms. To **fathom** a mystery is to get all the way to the bottom of it.

Pip could not **fathom** *why anyone would put pineapple on a pancake.*

SIMILAR understand, comprehend, grasp, figure out

OPPOSITE misunderstand

glean **GLEEN** *verb*



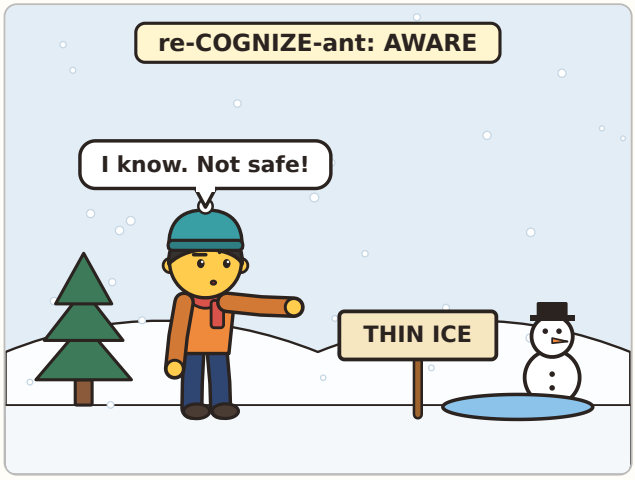
MEANING to gather information bit by bit

MEMORY HOOK **GLEAN = CLEAN UP every last bit.** After the harvest, Nana Lou walks the field and picks up every last stalk the reapers missed. In the same way, a careful reader can **glean** facts bit by bit.

From the muddy paw prints, Lila **gleaned** *that the dog had been in the garden.*

SIMILAR gather, collect, pick up, piece together

cognizant **KOG**-nih-zunt *adjective*



MEANING aware; knowing about something

MEMORY HOOK **reCOGNIZE-ant: you recognize what is going on.** Dev recognizes the cracked ice and the warning sign, so he stays on the shore. He is **cognizant** of the danger.

The hikers were **cognizant** *of the park's bear rules because they had read every sign at the trailhead.*

PARTS **co** thoroughly + **gn** know (from Latin gnoscere)

SIMILAR aware, conscious, informed, mindful
OPPOSITE unaware, ignorant, oblivious

vigilant **VIJ**-uh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING watchful and alert for danger or trouble

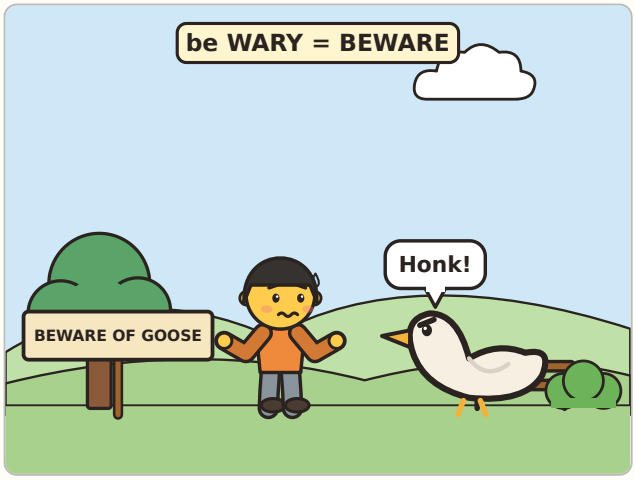
MEMORY HOOK **a VIGIL: awake and watching all night.** All night long the old owl keeps a vigil over the henhouse, eyes wide open, watching for foxes. She is **vigilant**.

The **vigilant** *lifeguard never took her eyes off the water and spotted the struggling swimmer in seconds.*

PARTS **vigil** awake, watchful + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR watchful, alert, attentive, on guard
OPPOSITE careless, heedless, inattentive

wary **WAIR**-ee *adjective*



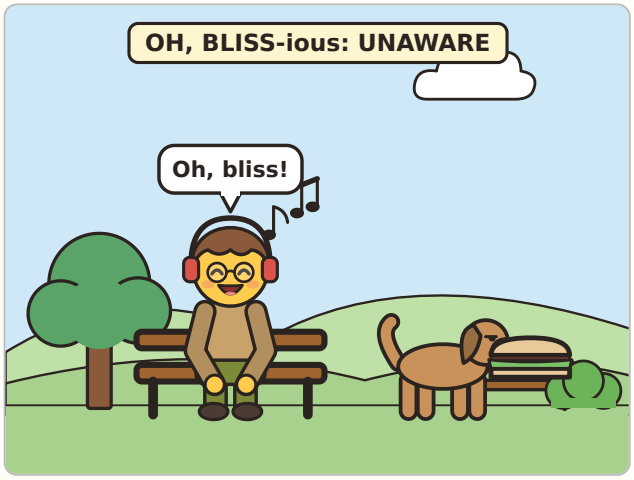
MEANING cautious about possible danger or trickery

MEMORY HOOK **be WARY = BEWARE.** A sign says "Beware of the goose," so Kai tiptoes past the pond, watching the goose every step. He is **wary**.

The stray cat was **wary** *of strangers but loved the girl who fed it.*

SIMILAR cautious, guarded, watchful, suspicious
OPPOSITE trusting, careless, unwary

oblivious uh-**BLIV**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING not aware of what is happening around you

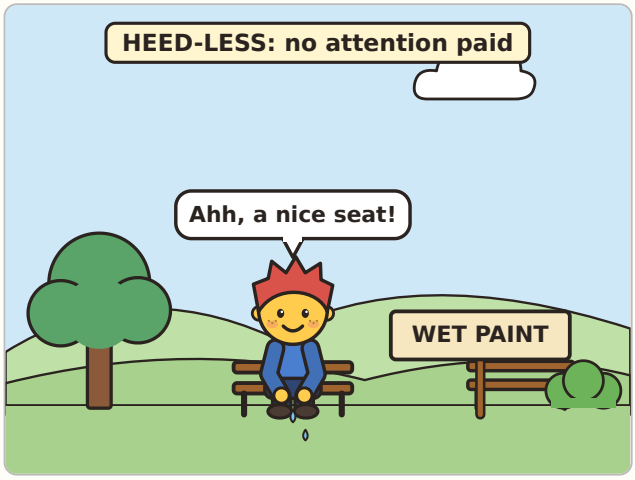
MEMORY HOOK **"OH, BLISS!" lost in his music.** Felix bobs his head to the songs in his headphones, "Oh, bliss!", while the dog trots off with his sandwich. He is **oblivious**.

Lost in her book, Maya was **oblivious** *to the rain soaking her shoes.*

PARTS **oblivi** forgetting (from Latin oblivisci, "to forget") + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR unaware, unmindful, unconscious, inattentive
OPPOSITE aware, cognizant, alert

heedless HEED-lis *adjective*



MEANING paying no attention to warnings or dangers; careless

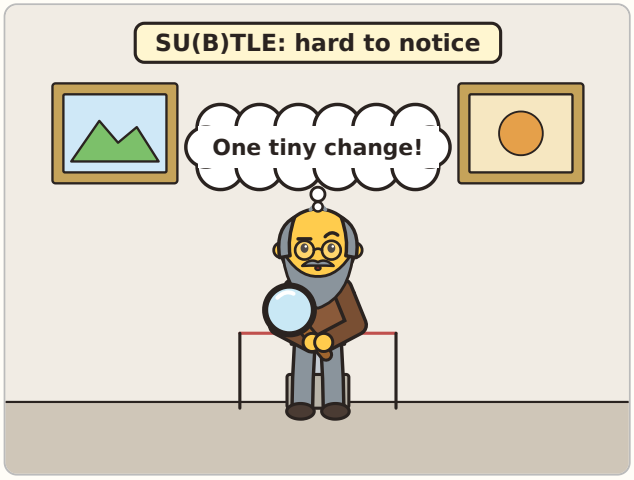
MEMORY HOOK **HEED-LESS: pays no heed.** Pip pays no heed to the "Wet Paint" sign and sits right down on the bench. He is **heedless**.

Heedless *of the wet-paint sign, Pip plopped down on the bench and ruined his shorts.*

PARTS **heed** attention, care + **-less** without

SIMILAR careless, unmindful, reckless, inattentive
OPPOSITE careful, mindful, heedful

subtle SUT-ul *adjective*



MEANING so slight or delicate that it is hard to notice

MEMORY HOOK **the silent B in SUBTLE.** The b in subtle makes no sound at all, so you hardly notice it is there. A difference that slight is **subtle**.

The soup had a **subtle** *hint of lemon.*

SIMILAR slight, faint, delicate, understated
OPPOSITE obvious, blatant, glaring

sporadic spuh-RAD-ik *adjective*



MEANING happening now and then, at irregular times

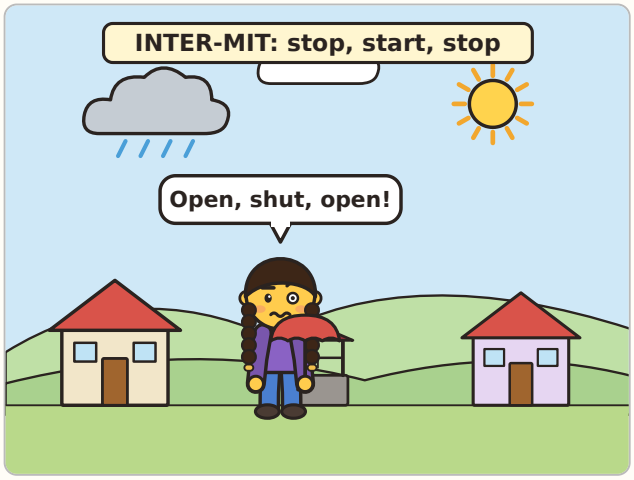
MEMORY HOOK **SPORE-adic: popping up here and there.** After the rain, mushrooms pop up from scattered spores: one here, two there, none over there. They appear at **sporadic** spots and times.

We heard only **sporadic** *birdsong in the cold woods: a chirp here, then nothing for an hour.*

PARTS **spora** scattered, sown (Greek) + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR occasional, irregular, scattered, intermittent
OPPOSITE regular, constant, steady

intermittent in-ter-MIT-unt *adjective*



MEANING stopping and starting again, at irregular times

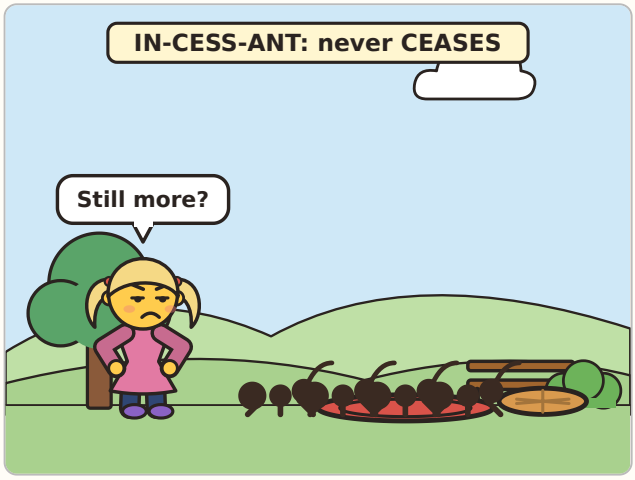
MEMORY HOOK **INTER-MIT: stops IN BETWEEN.** The rain stops, starts and stops again, so Lila opens and shuts her umbrella all afternoon. The rain is **intermittent**.

The forecast called for **intermittent** *showers, stopping and starting all afternoon.*

PARTS **inter** between + **mitt** let go, send + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR on-and-off, irregular, sporadic, fitful
OPPOSITE continuous, constant, steady

incessant in-**SES**-unt *adjective*



MEANING never stopping, often to the point of annoyance

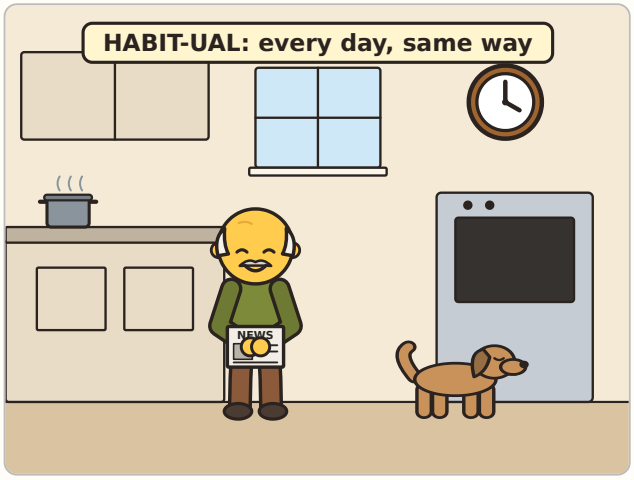
MEMORY HOOK **IN-CESS-ANT: the ANTS never CEASE.** The ants march across the picnic blanket all day long, never stopping for a moment. Their marching is **incessant**.

The puppy's **incessant** *barking went on all night without a single pause.*

PARTS **in-** not + **cess** stop, cease + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR nonstop, constant, unending, ceaseless
OPPOSITE occasional, intermittent, sporadic

habitual huh-**BICH**-oo-ul *adjective*



MEANING done regularly, out of long practice; usual

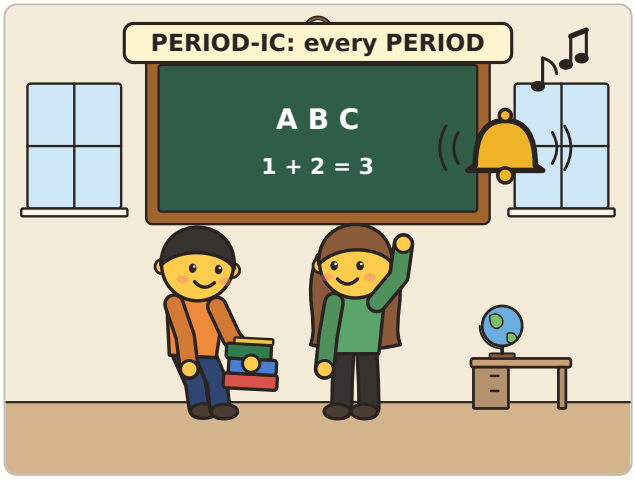
MEMORY HOOK **HABIT-ual: every day, same way.** Every morning at seven, Grandpa Gus walks the dog, reads the paper and drinks one cup of tea, always in that order. It is his **habitual** routine.

Grandpa's **habitual** *morning walk, the same route every day for forty years, always ends at the bakery.*

PARTS **habit** a settled way of acting + **-ual** having to do with

SIMILAR customary, usual, routine, regular
OPPOSITE occasional, rare, unusual

periodic peer-ee-**OD**-ik *adjective*



MEANING happening at regular intervals

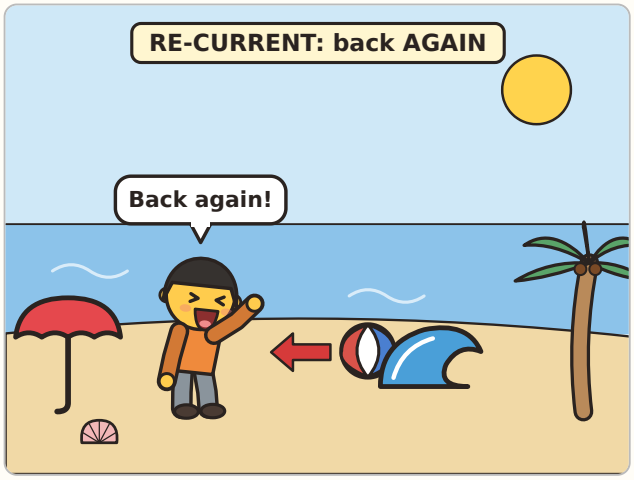
MEMORY HOOK **PERIOD-ic: like the bell every PERIOD.** The school bell rings at the end of every class period, right on schedule. Its ringing is **periodic**.

The car needs **periodic** *oil changes, one every five thousand miles, like clockwork.*

PARTS **peri** around + **od** way, path + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR regular, cyclical, routine, scheduled
OPPOSITE irregular, random

recurrent rih-**KUR**-unt *adjective*



MEANING happening again and again

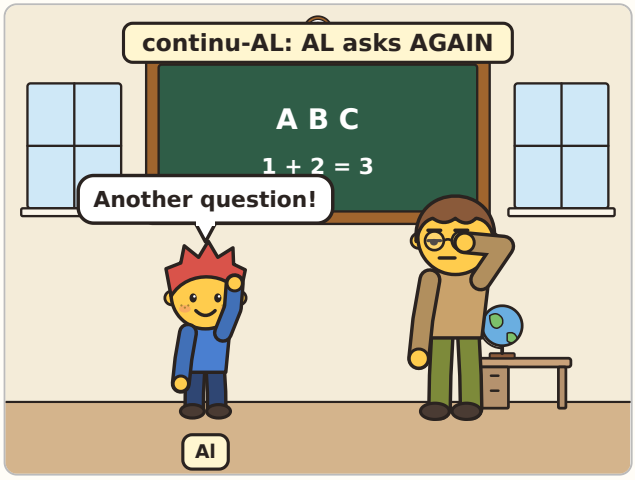
MEMORY HOOK **RE-CURRENT: the current brings it back.** Kai tosses the beach ball out, and the waves carry it back to him, again and again and again. Its return is **recurrent**.

Lost keys are a **recurrent** *problem in our house; they go missing again every few weeks.*

PARTS **re** back, again + **curr** run + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR recurring, repeated, returning, frequent
OPPOSITE one-time, isolated, single

continual kun-**TIN**-yoo-ul *adjective*



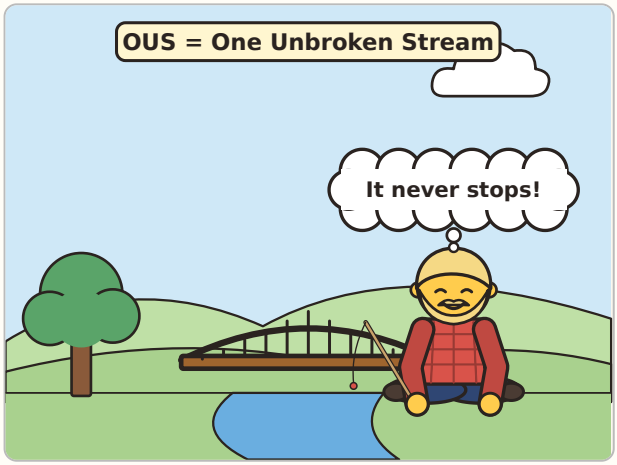
MEANING happening again and again, with short breaks between

MEMORY HOOK **continu-AL: AL asks again, and again.** Al raises his hand, asks a question, waits a minute and asks another, all day long. His questions are **continual**: again and again, with short breaks.

The **continual** *ringing of the phone, a new call every few minutes, made it hard to finish the report.*

SIMILAR repeated, frequent, recurring, on-and-off
OPPOSITE rare, occasional

continuous kun-**TIN**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING going on without any break

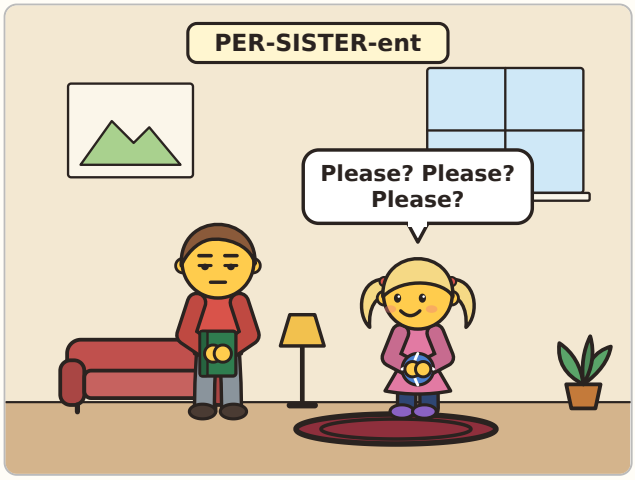
MEMORY HOOK **continu-OUS: One Unbroken Stream.** The river flows past Sven's fishing spot day and night without stopping for even a second: One Unbroken Stream. Its flow is **continuous**.

At rush hour the highway is one **continuous** *line of cars, bumper to bumper with no gaps.*

PARTS **contin** hold together + **-uous** having (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR unbroken, uninterrupted, nonstop, constant
OPPOSITE intermittent, broken, interrupted

persistent per-**SIS**-tunt *adjective*



MEANING refusing to give up; continuing for a long time

MEMORY HOOK **PER-SISTER-ent: little sister never gives up.** Ivy asks her big brother to play catch ten times, twenty times, fifty times, until he finally says yes. Ivy is **persistent**.

The **persistent** *puppy scratched at the door again and again until someone finally let him in.*

PARTS **per** through, thoroughly + **sist** stand + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR determined, tenacious, relentless, constant
OPPOSITE irresolute, fleeting, brief

unremitting un-rih-**MIT**-ing *adjective*



MEANING never letting up or slackening

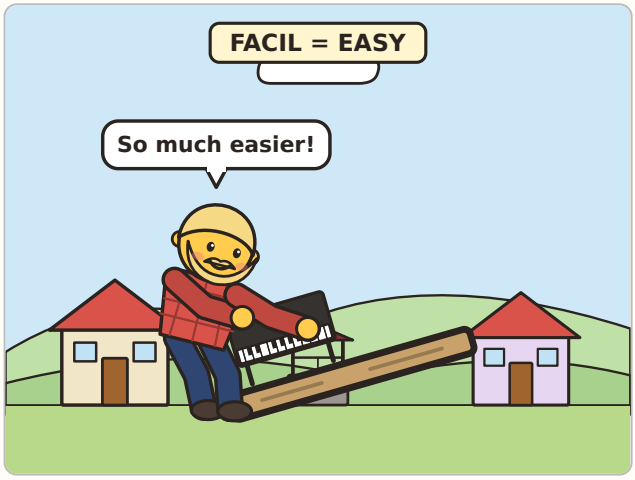
MEMORY HOOK **UN-REMITTING: it never lets up.** Hour after hour, the desert sun blazes down on the travelers, with no cloud and no shade. The heat is **unremitting**.

The hikers trudged on through the **unremitting** *wind, which never eased for a moment.*

PARTS **un-** not + **re** back + **mitt** let go, send

SIMILAR relentless, ceaseless, constant, unrelenting
OPPOSITE intermittent, sporadic, occasional

facilitate fuh-**SIL**-ih-tayt *verb*



MEANING to make an action or process easier

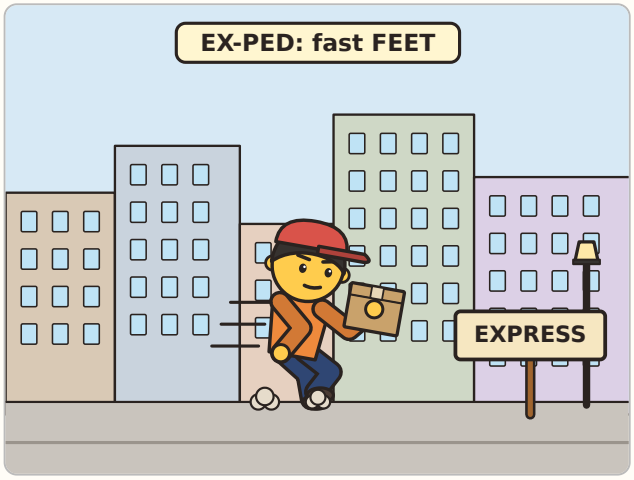
MEMORY HOOK **FACIL-itate: make it FACILE, easy.** Instead of dragging the heavy piano up the steps, the movers roll it up a ramp. The ramp **facilitates** the job: it makes it easier.

A ramp **facilitated** *moving the piano into the house.*

PARTS **facil** easy + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR ease, smooth, simplify, enable
OPPOSITE hinder, hamper, impede

expedite **EK**-spuh-dite *verb*



MEANING to speed up a process

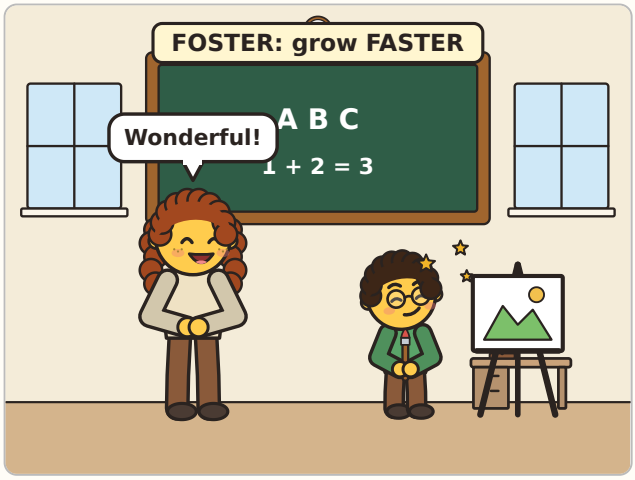
MEMORY HOOK **EX-PED: FEET out and running.** Ped means foot. To get the package there today, the shop sends its fastest runner out the door. It **expedites** the delivery.

Paying extra will **expedite** *the delivery.*

PARTS **ex** out + **ped** foot

SIMILAR speed up, hasten, hurry, accelerate
OPPOSITE delay, slow, hold up

foster **FAW**-ster *verb*



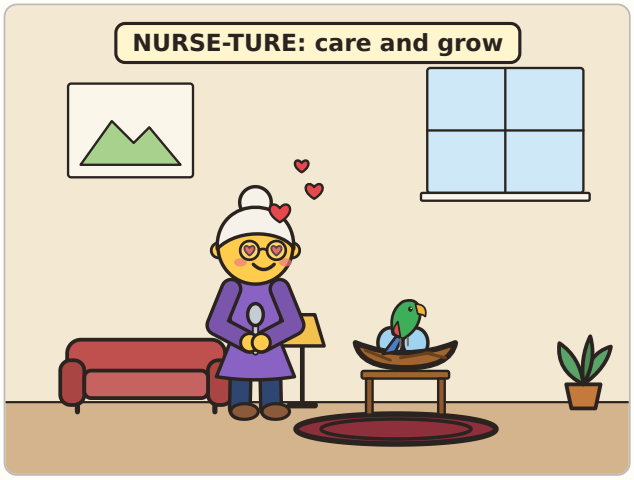
MEANING to encourage the growth or development of

MEMORY HOOK **FOSTER: helps you grow FASTER.** With paint, space and praise, the art teacher helps her students improve faster than they ever could alone. She **fosters** their talent.

The art club **fosters** *young talent with free paint and lots of praise.*

SIMILAR encourage, promote, nurture, cultivate
OPPOSITE discourage, stifle, neglect

nurture **NUR**-cher *verb*



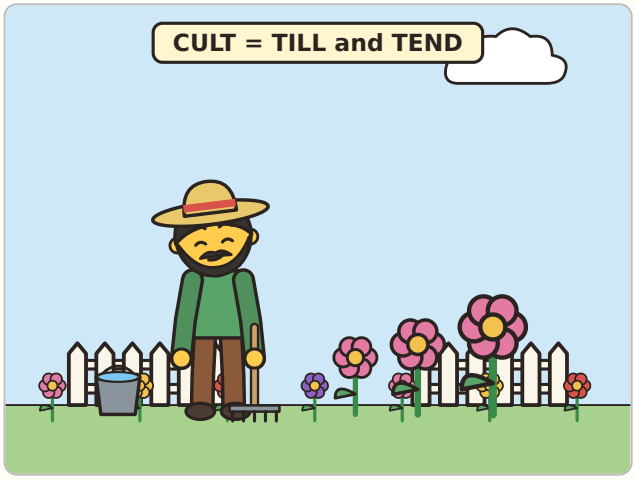
MEANING to care for and help grow

MEMORY HOOK **NURSE-ture: nurse it till it grows.** Granny Mae nurses the baby bird with drops of water until it is strong enough to fly. She **nurtures** it.

Lila **nurtured** *the tiny seedlings with water and sunshine.*

SIMILAR nourish, raise, tend, foster
OPPOSITE neglect, ignore

cultivate KUL-tuh-vayt *verb*



MEANING to develop something by steady care and effort

MEMORY HOOK **agri-CULT-ure: till, plant, tend.** Year after year, Omar tills, plants and weeds his garden until it blooms. In the same way, you can **cultivate** a skill with steady care.

Rosa **cultivated** *a love of poetry by reading one poem every night.*

PARTS **cult** till, tend (from Latin colere) + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR develop, grow, tend, foster
OPPOSITE neglect, abandon

champion CHAM-pee-un *verb*



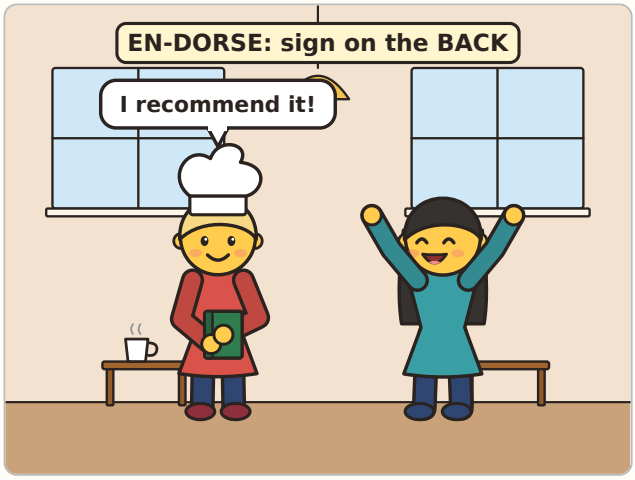
MEANING to fight for or speak up for a cause or person

MEMORY HOOK **a CHAMP who fights FOR a cause.** Tia speaks up for the shelter dogs at every town meeting until the town builds them a new home. She **champions** their cause.

Ms. Ortiz **championed** *the idea of a school garden for years.*

SIMILAR defend, back, support, fight for
OPPOSITE oppose, attack, criticize

endorse en-DORS *verb*



MEANING to publicly approve or support

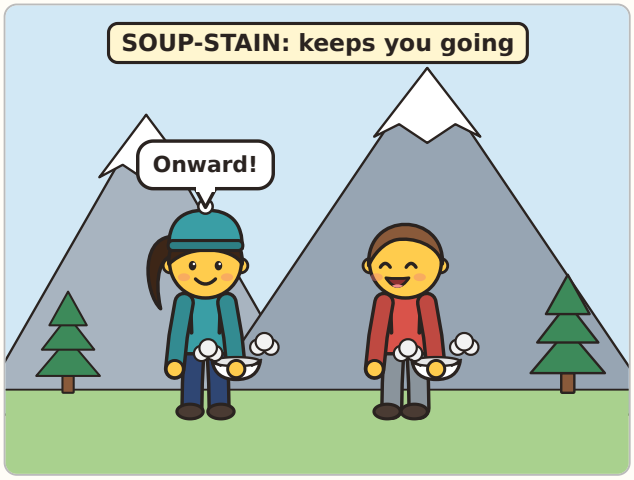
MEMORY HOOK **EN-DORSE: sign your name on the BACK.** The chef signs the back cover of Lin's cookbook and writes, "I recommend it!" She **endorses** it.

Three local chefs **endorsed** *the new cookbook.*

PARTS **en** on + **dors** back

SIMILAR approve, back, support, recommend
OPPOSITE oppose, reject, condemn

sustain suh-STAYN *verb*



MEANING to keep something going; to support it over time

MEMORY HOOK **SOUP-STAIN: the soup keeps them going.** Their jackets have soup stains, but the hot soup keeps the hikers going all the way up the mountain. Food that keeps you going **sustains** you.

Hot soup **sustained** *the hikers on the long, cold climb.*

PARTS **sus** under, from below + **tain** hold

SIMILAR maintain, keep up, prolong, uphold
OPPOSITE abandon, end, halt

abet uh-**BET** *verb*



MEANING to help or encourage someone, usually in doing wrong

MEMORY HOOK **A BET: "I bet no one sees!".** "Go on, I bet no one sees!" Rex whispers, holding the ladder steady while Pip reaches for the cookie jar. Rex **abets** the mischief.

The guard who looked the other way **abetted** *the smugglers.*

SIMILAR assist, aid, egg on, help
OPPOSITE hinder, prevent, foil

galvanize **GAL**-vuh-nize *verb*



MEANING to shock or excite people into action

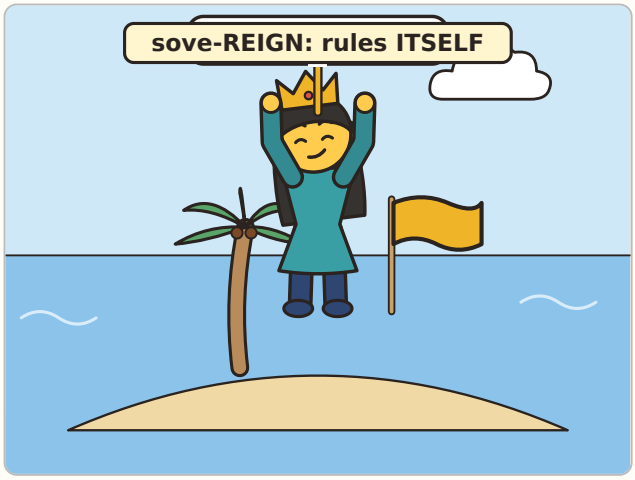
MEMORY HOOK **the GAL in the VAN jolts them awake.** The gal in the van blasts her horn, and the sleepy campers leap out of their tents, ready to go. She **galvanizes** them.

The coach's speech **galvanized** *the tired team.*

PARTS **-ize** to make, to treat as

SIMILAR spur, rouse, energize, jolt
OPPOSITE discourage, dampen, deter

sovereign **SOV**-rin *adjective*



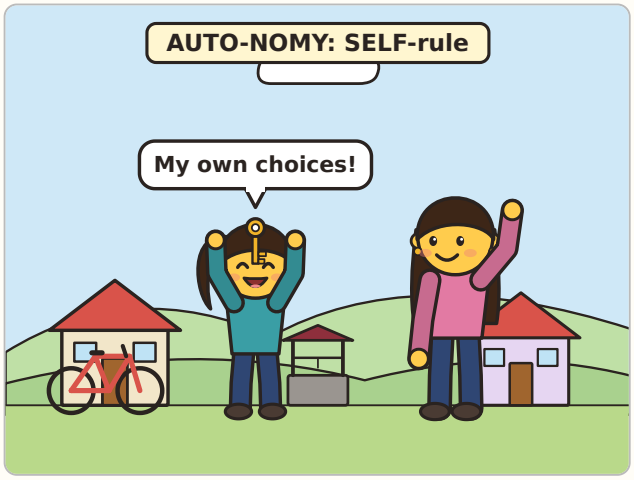
MEANING having supreme power; independent and self-governing

MEMORY HOOK **sove-REIGN: REIGNS over itself.** The little island kingdom reigns over itself and takes orders from no one. It is **sovereign**.

After a long struggle, the island became a **sovereign** *nation with its own flag.*

SIMILAR independent, self-governing, autonomous, supreme
OPPOSITE dependent, subject, subordinate

autonomy aw-**TON**-uh-mee *noun*



MEANING the freedom to govern yourself or make your own choices

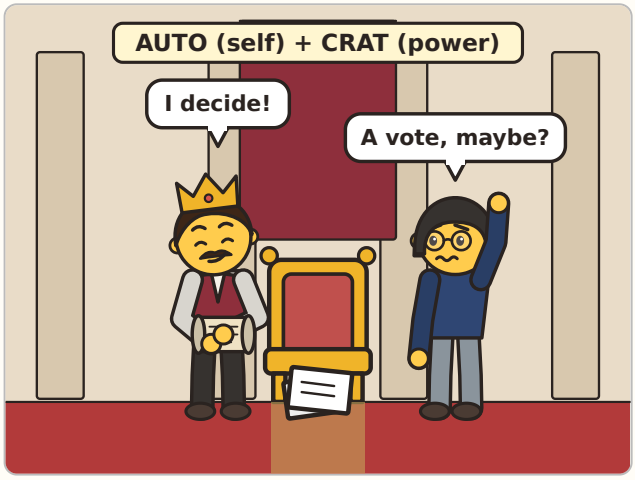
MEMORY HOOK **AUTO = SELF: you set your own rules.** On her birthday, Maya gets her own key and her own schedule: she decides where to go and when. She has **autonomy**.

At college, Maya enjoyed the **autonomy** *of planning her own days.*

PARTS **auto** self + **nomy** law, rule

SIMILAR independence, self-rule, self-government, freedom
OPPOSITE dependence, control, subjection

autocrat **AW**-tuh-krat *noun*



MEANING a ruler who holds total power alone

MEMORY HOOK **AUTO-CRAT: rules all by him-SELF.** King Victor signs every order himself and waves away his advisers: "I decide!" A ruler who holds all the power alone is an **autocrat**.

The old czar was an **autocrat** *who answered to no parliament.*

PARTS **auto** self + **crat** power, rule

SIMILAR dictator, absolute ruler, tyrant, despot

despot **DES**-put *noun*



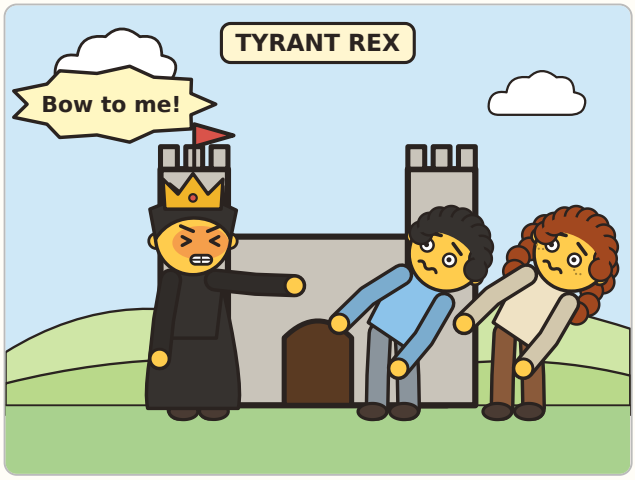
MEANING a ruler who uses total power cruelly

MEMORY HOOK **DES-POT: he takes every POT.** The cruel king marches into the village and takes every pot of soup for himself, leaving the people hungry. He is a **despot**.

In the legend, a **despot** *took half of every farmer's harvest.*

SIMILAR tyrant, dictator, oppressor, autocrat

tyranny **TEER**-uh-nee *noun*



MEANING cruel and unjust use of power

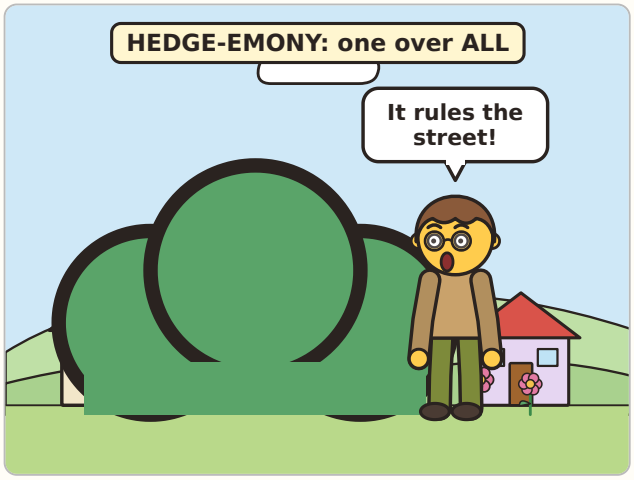
MEMORY HOOK **TYRANT REX.** King Rex makes the townspeople bow every time he passes and punishes anyone who sneezes. His cruel, unjust rule is **tyranny**.

The rebels fought to free their land from **tyranny**.

SIMILAR oppression, cruelty, dictatorship, despotism

OPPOSITE freedom, liberty, justice

hegemony hih-**JEM**-uh-nee *noun*



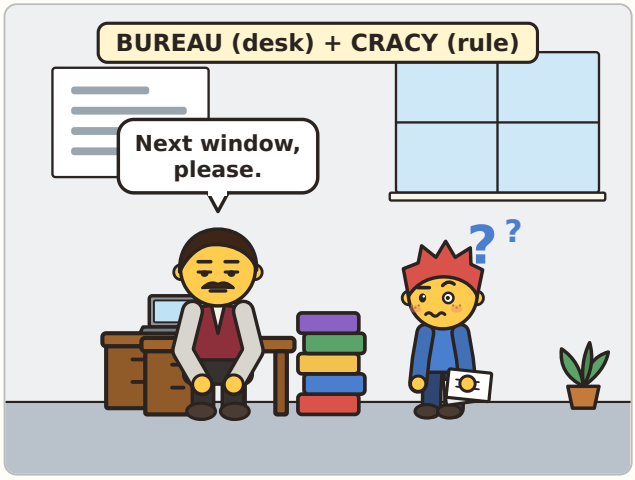
MEANING dominance of one group or nation over others

MEMORY HOOK **HEDGE-EMONY: one hedge takes over.** One giant hedge spreads over the whole street until every garden sits in its shade. That hedge's **hegemony** is complete.

For centuries the city held **hegemony** *over trade on the river.*

SIMILAR dominance, supremacy, control, leadership

bureaucracy byoo-**ROK**-ruh-see *noun*



MEANING a system run by many officials and complicated rules

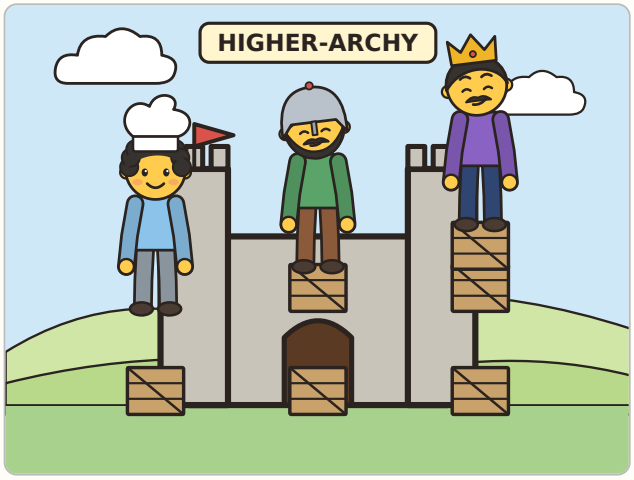
MEMORY HOOK **BUREAU-CRACY: rule by desks and forms.** To get a library card, Pip fills out Form A, gets a stamp at Desk B, waits in Line C and is sent back to Form A. That maze of offices is **bureaucracy**.

Getting a permit meant months of **bureaucracy** *and forms.*

PARTS **bureau** desk, office (French) + **cracy** rule, power

SIMILAR red tape, officialdom, administration, paperwork

hierarchy **HIGH**-er-ar-kee *noun*



MEANING a system that ranks people or things one above another

MEMORY HOOK **HIGHER-ARCHY: who stands HIGHER.** At the castle the king stands highest, then the knight, then the cook. That ranking from higher to lower is a **hierarchy**.

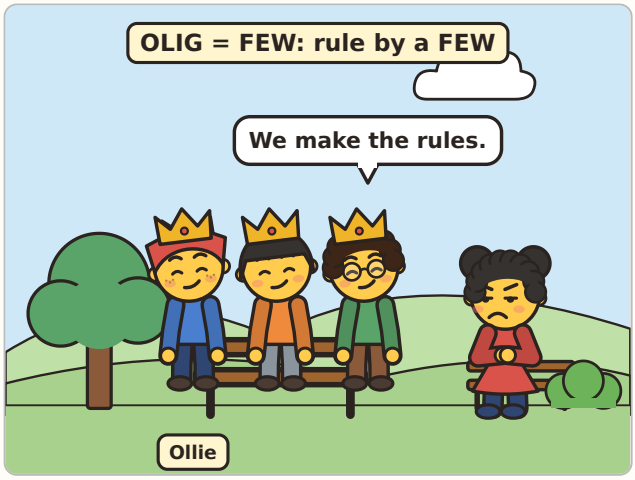
In the army's **hierarchy**, *a general outranks a colonel, and a colonel outranks a captain.*

PARTS **hier** sacred (Greek) + **archy** rule

SIMILAR ranking, pecking order, chain of command, ladder

OPPOSITE equality

oligarchy **OL**-ih-gar-kee *noun*



MEANING rule by a small group of people

MEMORY HOOK **OLLIE'S GANG rules the club.** Ollie and his two best friends make every rule for the whole treehouse club; the other kids get no say. Rule by a few like that is an **oligarchy**.

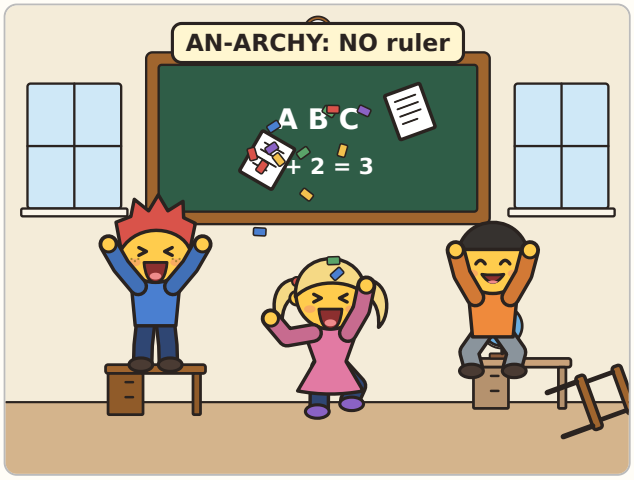
The city was run by an **oligarchy** *of five wealthy merchant families.*

PARTS **olig** few + **archy** rule

SIMILAR rule by a few, ruling clique, elite rule

OPPOSITE democracy

anarchy **AN**-er-kee *noun*



MEANING a lack of government or control; disorder

MEMORY HOOK **AN-ARCHY: NO one in charge.** The teacher steps out for five minutes, and with no one in charge the room turns to chaos: paper planes, spilled paint, kids on desks. That is **anarchy**.

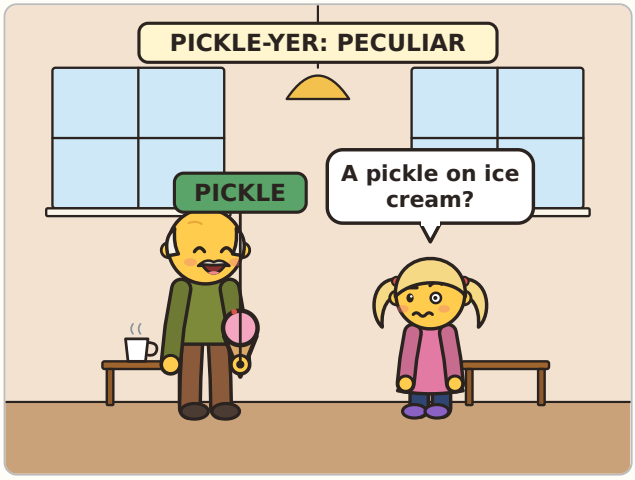
When the referee left, the game dissolved into **anarchy**.

PARTS **an** without + **archy** rule

SIMILAR lawlessness, chaos, disorder, mayhem

OPPOSITE order, law, government

peculiar pih-**KYOOL**-yer *adjective*



MEANING strange or odd; also, belonging only to one person or place

MEMORY HOOK **PICKLE-YER ice cream? PECULIAR!.** Grandpa Gus orders a scoop of vanilla and asks for a pickle on top. Ivy stares. How **peculiar**!

Grandpa has the **peculiar** *habit of putting pickles on his ice cream.*

SIMILAR strange, odd, curious, weird
OPPOSITE normal, ordinary, usual

eccentric ik-**SEN**-trik *adjective*



MEANING odd in behavior in a harmless, quirky way

MEMORY HOOK **EC-CENTRIC: a little OFF-CENTER.** Professor Edwin wears a wizard hat to the park and walks his turtle on a leash. He is a bit off-center but perfectly harmless: **eccentric**.

The **eccentric** *inventor wore one red sock and one green sock every day.*

PARTS **ec** out of + **centr** center + **-ic** having to do with
SIMILAR quirky, odd, offbeat, zany
OPPOSITE conventional, ordinary, normal

bizarre bih-**ZAR** *adjective*



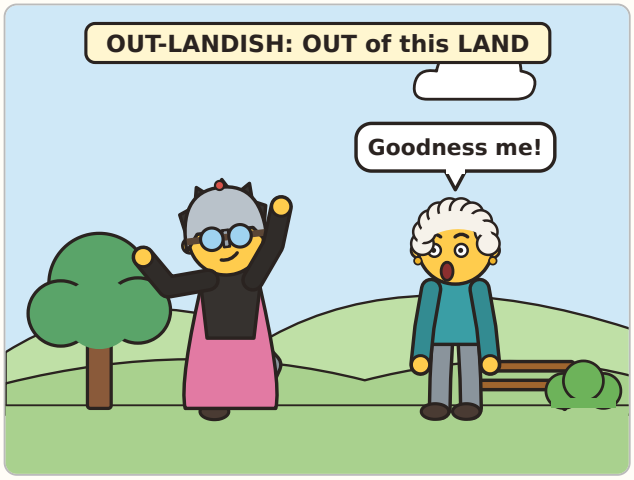
MEANING very strange and surprising

MEMORY HOOK **the BIZARRE BAZAAR.** At the bazaar, one stall sells socks for snakes. It is the most **bizarre** stall in the whole market.

Every morning, the cat performs a **bizarre** *trick: riding the dog like a horse around the yard.*

SIMILAR weird, strange, odd, surreal
OPPOSITE ordinary, normal, everyday

outlandish owt-**LAN**-dish *adjective*



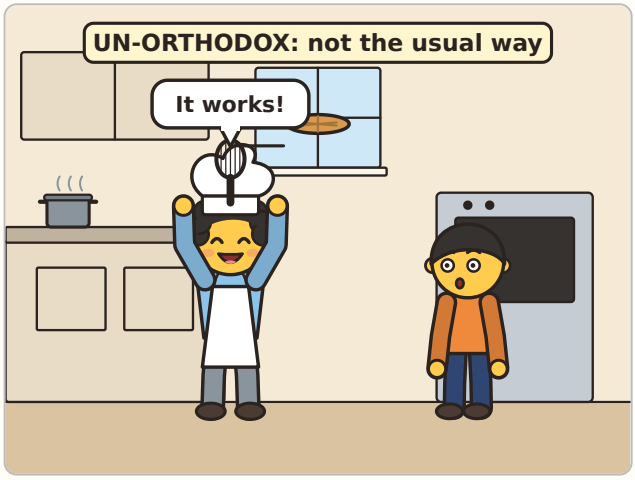
MEANING strikingly odd, almost unbelievable

MEMORY HOOK **OUT-LANDISH: from OUT of this LAND.** Rex strolls into the picnic in a rainbow cape, goggles and a big helmet, an outfit from some faraway land. It is **outlandish**.

As usual, Rex arrived at the picnic in an **outlandish** *outfit: a rainbow cape and swim fins.*

PARTS **out** outside + **land** land + **-ish** like, of
SIMILAR weird, far-fetched, wild, odd
OPPOSITE ordinary, sensible, conventional

unorthodox un-**OR**-thuh-doks *adjective*



MEANING not following the usual ways of doing things

MEMORY HOOK **UN-ORTHO: NOT the usual straight way.** Chef Jamal flips his pancakes with a tennis racket, and every one lands perfectly in the pan. His method is **unorthodox**.

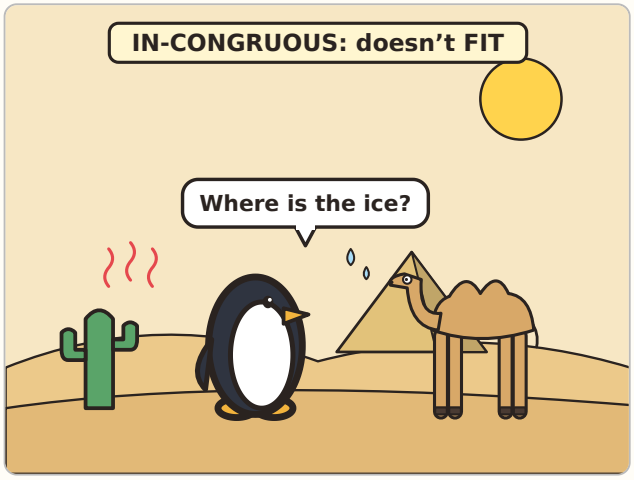
For years the chef has used an **unorthodox** *method: flipping pancakes with a tennis racket.*

PARTS **un-** not + **ortho** straight, correct + **dox** opinion, belief

SIMILAR unconventional, nontraditional, unusual, odd

OPPOSITE orthodox, conventional, traditional

incongruous in-**KONG**-groo-us *adjective*



MEANING out of place; not fitting in with its surroundings

MEMORY HOOK **IN-CONGRUOUS: a penguin in the desert.** A penguin waddles across the hot desert sand past a puzzled camel. It is completely out of place: **incongruous**.

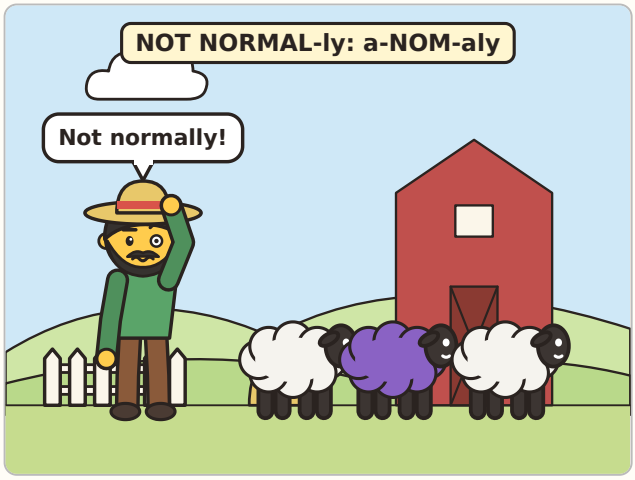
Grandpa's heavy wool coat looked **incongruous** *on the sunny beach among all the swimsuits.*

PARTS **in-** not + **congru** agree, fit together + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR out of place, mismatched, jarring, odd

OPPOSITE fitting, appropriate, harmonious

anomaly uh-**NOM**-uh-lee *noun*



MEANING something that departs from what is normal or expected

MEMORY HOOK **NOT NORMALLY: a-NOM-aly.** Sheep are not normally purple, so the one purple sheep in Omar's flock is an **anomaly**.

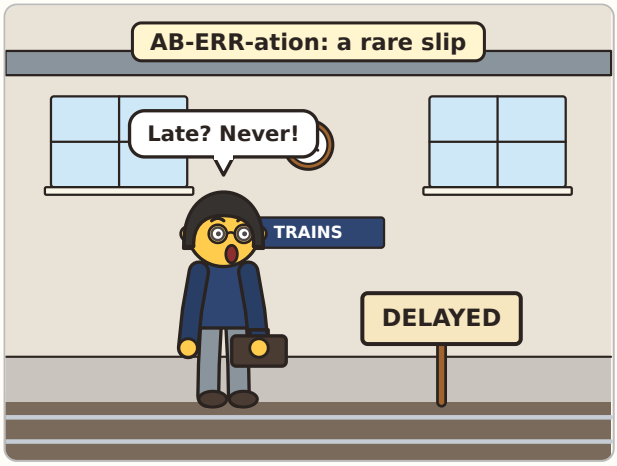
A snowy day in Miami would be an **anomaly**.

PARTS **an** not (Greek) + **omal** even, regular (Greek homalos)

SIMILAR oddity, exception, irregularity, abnormality

OPPOSITE norm, rule, standard

aberration ab-uh-**RAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING a departure from what is normal or right, often a brief one

MEMORY HOOK **AB-ERR: wander away into ERROR.** The train that has arrived at eight o'clock sharp every day for ten years is two hours late today. That one late day is an **aberration**.

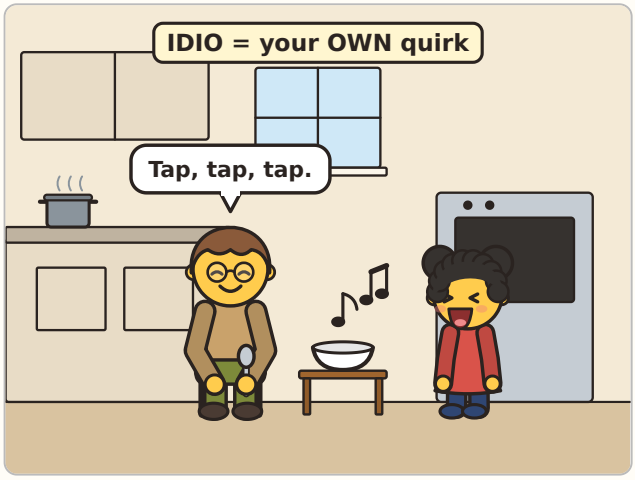
The team's one loss was an **aberration** *in an otherwise perfect season.*

PARTS **ab** away + **err** wander, stray + **-ation** the act or state of

SIMILAR deviation, exception, abnormality, departure

OPPOSITE norm, standard

idiosyncrasy id-ee-oh-**SING**-kruh-see *noun*



MEANING a habit or way of behaving all your own

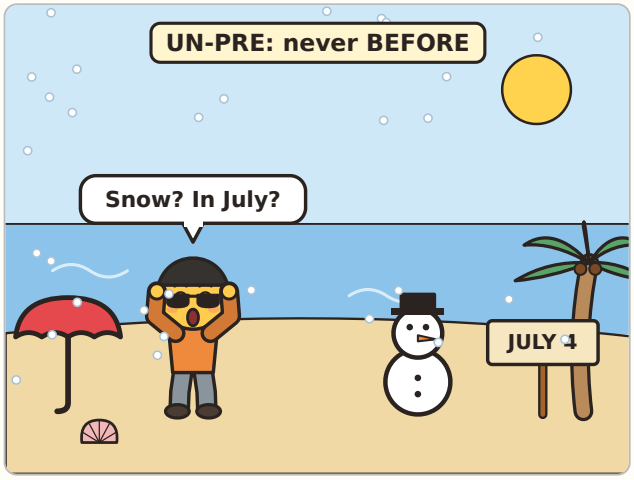
MEMORY HOOK **IDIO = your OWN: a quirk all your own.** Uncle Felix taps his spoon on the bowl exactly three times before every meal: tap, tap, tap. It is his own little **idiosyncrasy**.

One of Uncle Felix's **idiosyncrasies** *is tapping his spoon three times before every meal.*

PARTS **idio** one's own + **syn** together + **crasy** mixture

SIMILAR quirk, peculiarity, oddity, mannerism

unprecedented un-**PRES**-ih-den-tid *adjective*



MEANING never done or known before

MEMORY HOOK **UN-PRE-CEDENTED: nothing like it BEFORE.** Snow falls on the beach in July, something no one in town has ever seen before. The storm is **unprecedented**.

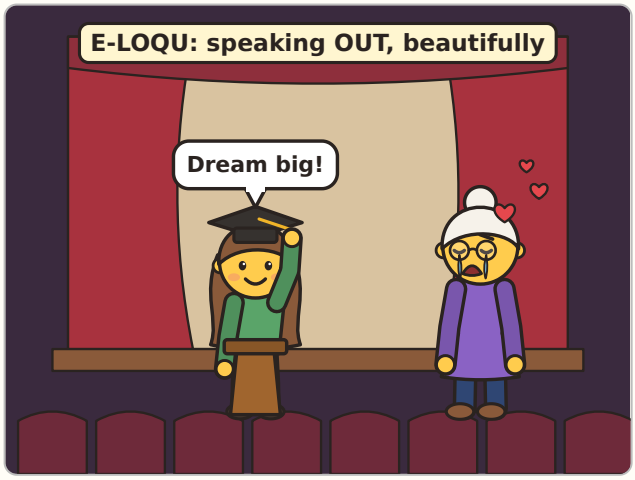
Snow on the beach in July was **unprecedented** *in the town's history.*

PARTS **un-** not + **pre** before + **ced** go

SIMILAR unheard-of, new, first-ever, record-breaking

OPPOSITE common, familiar, routine

eloquent **EL**-uh-kwunt *adjective*



MEANING speaking or writing in a fluent, moving way

MEMORY HOOK **E-LOQU-ENT: speaking OUT beautifully.** At graduation, Rosa's words flow out so gracefully that the grandparents in the front row wipe their eyes. She is **eloquent**.

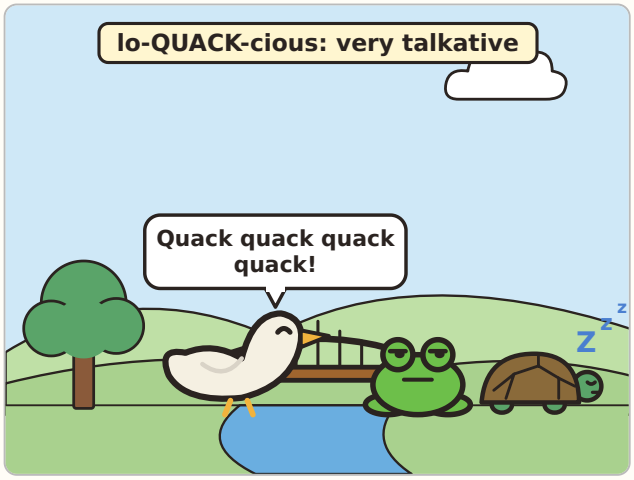
Rosa gave an **eloquent** *speech that left the whole gym in tears.*

PARTS **e** out + **loqu** speak + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR articulate, expressive, persuasive, well-spoken

OPPOSITE inarticulate, tongue-tied, halting

loquacious loh-**KWAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING very talkative

MEMORY HOOK **lo-QUACK-cious: a duck who never stops.** Daisy the duck quacks to everyone she meets, about the weather, the pond, the bread and the weather again. She is **loquacious**.

Our **loquacious** *cab driver told us his whole life story before we reached the hotel.*

PARTS **loqu** speak + **-acious** full of, inclined to

SIMILAR talkative, chatty, garrulous, gabby

OPPOSITE taciturn, quiet, reticent

colloquial kuh-**LOH**-kwee-ul *adjective*



MEANING used in ordinary, informal conversation

MEMORY HOOK **COL-LOQU: talking WITH your friends.** In class Dev says, "Good afternoon, Professor." With his pals at the skate park, it's "Hey, what's up?" That everyday way of talking is **colloquial**.

"Gonna" is a **colloquial** *way of saying "going to."*

PARTS **col** together, with + **loqu** speak + **-ial** having to do with

SIMILAR informal, conversational, everyday, casual

OPPOSITE formal, literary

soliloquy suh-**LIL**-uh-kwee *noun*



MEANING a speech in a play in which a character, alone, speaks thoughts aloud

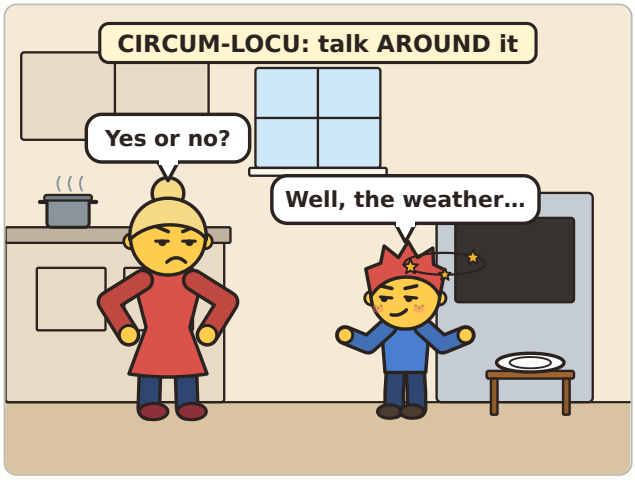
MEMORY HOOK **SOLO + LOQU: talking ALONE on stage.** Alone on the empty stage, the prince speaks his worried thoughts out loud to no one at all. His speech is a **soliloquy**.

In the second act, the prince delivers a long **soliloquy** *about whether to leave home.*

PARTS **soli** alone + **loqu** speak

SIMILAR speech to oneself, thinking aloud

circumlocution sur-kum-loh-**KYOO**-shun *noun*



MEANING using many words to avoid saying something directly

MEMORY HOOK **CIRCUM-LOCU: talking in CIRCLES.** Asked if he ate the last cookie, Pip talks about the weather, his homework and the dog, everything except yes or no. That is **circumlocution**.

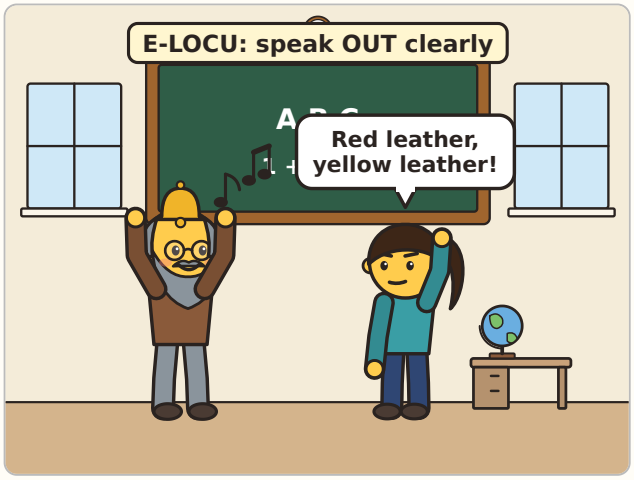
Asked if he ate the last cookie, Pip answered with ten minutes of **circumlocution**.

PARTS **circum** around + **locut** speak + **-ion** the act of

SIMILAR beating around the bush, wordiness, evasion, roundabout talk

OPPOSITE directness, bluntness

elocution el-uh-**KYOO**-shun *noun*



MEANING the skill of pronouncing words clearly when speaking in public

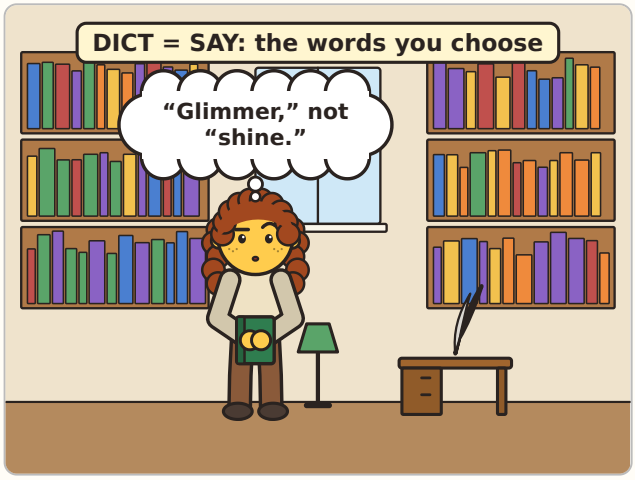
MEMORY HOOK **E-LOCU-TION: speaking OUT, clear as a bell.** Professor Edwin rings a bell, and Maya repeats the tongue twister until every sound rings out clearly. She is practicing **elocution**.

Years of **elocution** *lessons gave the actor a clear, ringing voice.*

PARTS **e** out + **locut** speak + **-ion** the act of

SIMILAR articulation, enunciation, delivery, public speaking

diction DIK-shun *noun*



MEANING the choice of words; also, how clearly words are spoken

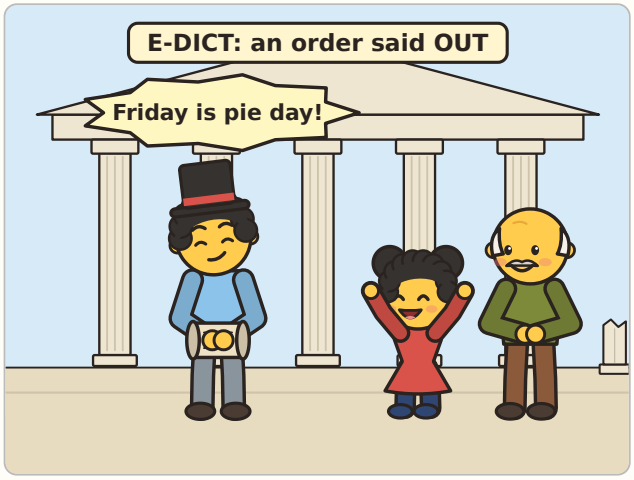
MEMORY HOOK **DICTIONary: choosing the words you SAY.** Nell flips through her dictionary to pick the perfect word: not “shine” but “glimmer.” Her careful choice of words is her **diction**.

The poet’s **diction** *was simple: short, everyday words that hit hard.*

PARTS **dict** say + **-ion** the act or manner of

SIMILAR wording, word choice, phrasing, enunciation

edict EE-dikt *noun*



MEANING an official order from someone in authority

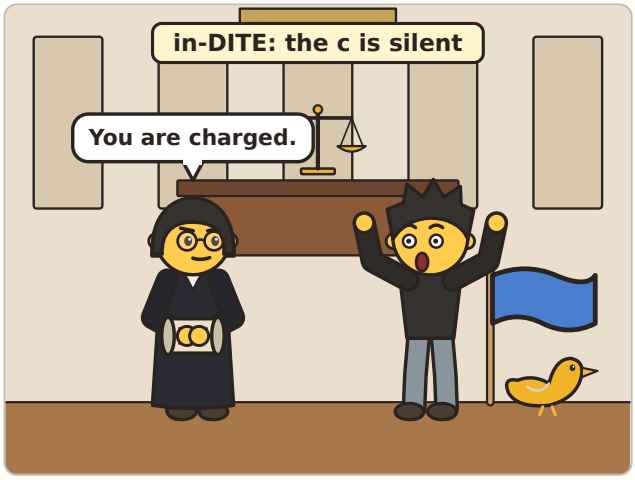
MEMORY HOOK **E-DICT: an order spoken OUT.** The royal herald unrolls a scroll and reads the queen’s new order aloud: every Friday is now pie day! That official order is an **edict**.

The queen’s **edict** *declared every Friday a holiday.*

PARTS **e** out + **dict** say

SIMILAR decree, order, command, proclamation

indict in-DITE *verb*



MEANING to formally charge someone with a crime

MEMORY HOOK **in-DITE: the INVITE no one wants.** The court’s letter is an invitation nobody wants: it formally charges the thief with stealing the town’s golden goose. To **indict** is to charge someone with a crime.

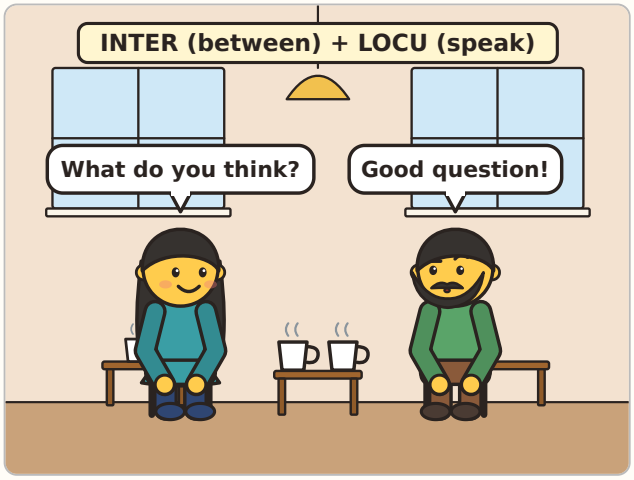
The grand jury voted to **indict** *the banker for stealing from his clients.*

PARTS **in** in, against + **dict** say, declare

SIMILAR charge, accuse, prosecute

OPPOSITE acquit, exonerate, clear

interlocutor in-ter-LOK-yuh-ter *noun*



MEANING a person taking part in a conversation

MEMORY HOOK **INTER-LOCU-TOR: the one you speak BETWEEN.** Across the café table, Lin and Omar trade ideas, each listening and answering in turn. Each is the other’s **interlocutor**.

Grandpa is a patient **interlocutor**; *he lets you finish every sentence.*

PARTS **inter** between + **locut** speak + **-or** one who

SIMILAR conversation partner, speaker, questioner

arrogant **AIR**-uh-gunt *adjective*



MEANING acting as if you are more important than others

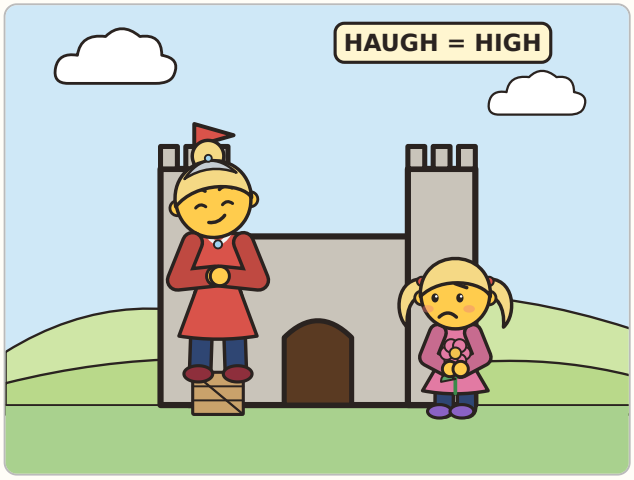
MEMORY HOOK **AIR-OGANT: nose high in the AIR.** Victor struts down the street with his nose so high in the air that he never sees the people saying hello. He is **arrogant**.

*The **arrogant** new player refused to pass the ball to anyone.*

PARTS **ar** to, toward (from ad) + **rog** ask, claim + **-ant** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR conceited, superior, overbearing, haughty
OPPOSITE humble, modest, meek

haughty **HAW**-tee *adjective*



MEANING proud in a cold way that looks down on others

MEMORY HOOK **HAUGH-ty = HIGH and mighty.** Lady Greta stands on a box so she can look down on everyone, and she will not speak to anyone below her. She is **haughty**.

*The **haughty** duchess would not even glance at the servants.*

SIMILAR arrogant, snobbish, superior, lofty
OPPOSITE humble, modest, friendly

condescending kon-dih-**SEN**-ding *adjective*



MEANING talking down to others as if they were less smart or important

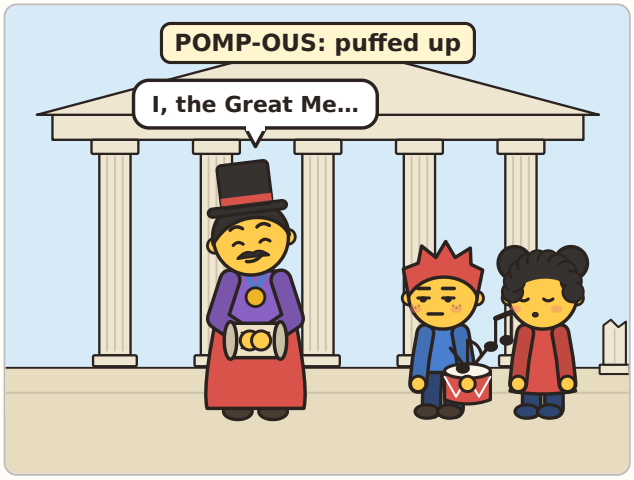
MEMORY HOOK **con-DESCEND: talks DOWN to you.** Rex bends way down to talk to the head chef as if she were a baby: "This is a SPOON." His tone is **condescending**.

*The salesman used a **condescending** tone, explaining what a "button" was.*

PARTS **con** with, together + **descend** come down

SIMILAR patronizing, superior, snobbish, arrogant
OPPOSITE respectful, humble

pompous **POM**-pus *adjective*



MEANING self-important and showy in speech or manner

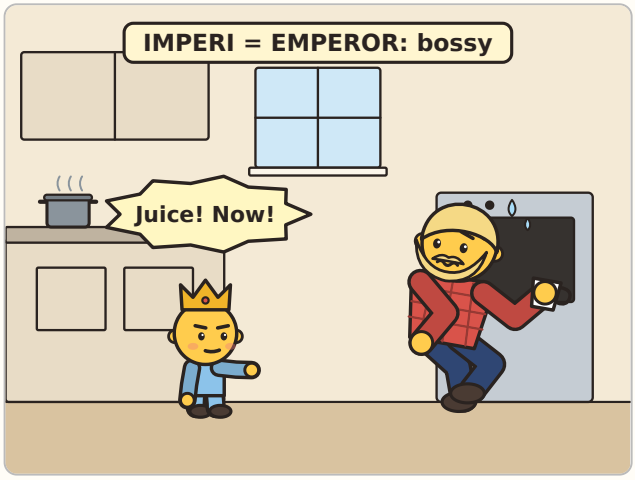
MEMORY HOOK **POMP-OUS: puffed up with POMP.** The duke arrives with a drumroll, a velvet cape and a speech all about how wonderful he is. He is **pompous**.

*The **pompous** duke gave a twenty-minute speech about himself at the ribbon cutting.*

PARTS **pomp** grand display, procession + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR self-important, puffed-up, pretentious, arrogant
OPPOSITE modest, unpretentious, down-to-earth

imperious im-**PEER**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING commanding and bossy, expecting to be obeyed

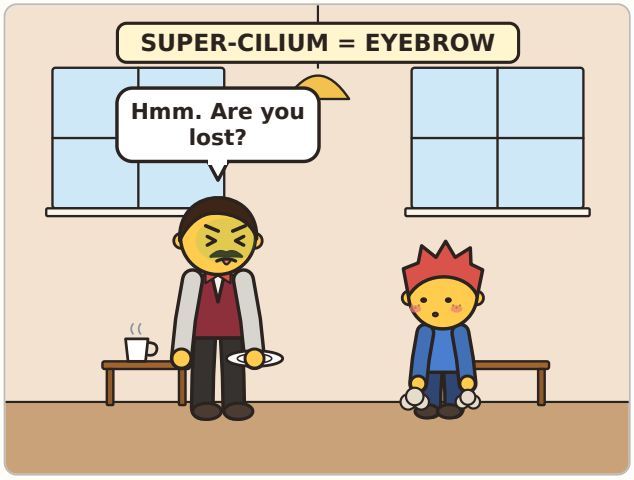
MEMORY HOOK **IMPERI-ous: bossy as an EMPEROR.** From his high chair, little Theo points like an emperor: "Juice! Now!" And Dad runs to obey. Theo is **imperious**.

With an **imperious** *wave, the toddler sent his father back for more juice.*

PARTS **imper** command (from Latin imperium) + **-ious** full of

SIMILAR domineering, bossy, overbearing, arrogant
OPPOSITE meek, humble, submissive

supercilious soo-per-**SIL**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING scornfully superior; looking down your nose at others

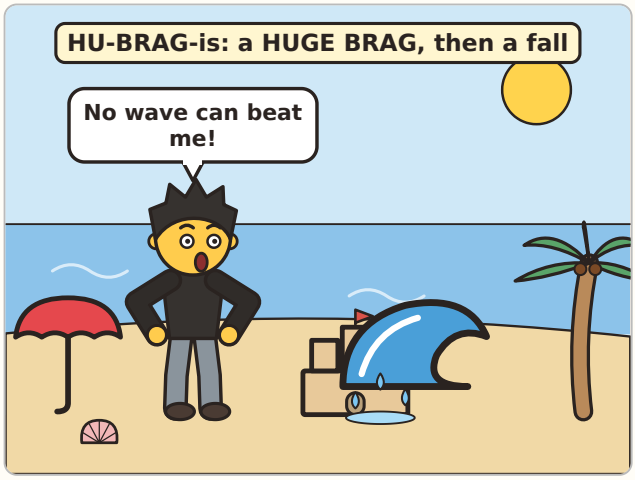
MEMORY HOOK **SUPER-CILIUM: one raised EYEBROW.** The snooty waiter raises one eyebrow at Pip's muddy sneakers: "Hmm. Are you lost?" His look is **supercilious**.

The **supercilious** *waiter raised an eyebrow at Pip's muddy sneakers.*

PARTS **super** above + **cili** eyelid + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR snobbish, disdainful, superior, arrogant
OPPOSITE humble, respectful, friendly

hubris **HYOO**-bris *noun*



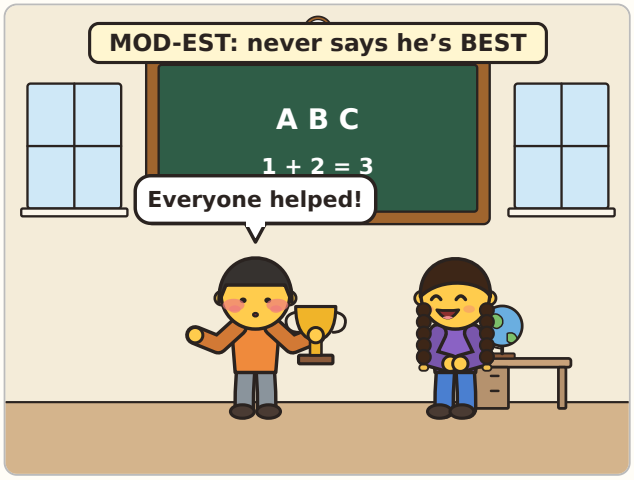
MEANING too much pride, the kind that leads to a downfall

MEMORY HOOK **a HUGE BRAG before a fall.** "No wave can beat my castle!" Rex brags, building right at the water's edge. The very next wave flattens it. His **hubris** brought him down.

In the old myths, a hero's **hubris** *usually ends in disaster.*

SIMILAR arrogance, overconfidence, excessive pride, conceit
OPPOSITE humility, modesty

modest **MOD**-ist *adjective*



MEANING not boasting about your abilities or achievements

MEMORY HOOK **MOD-EST: never says he's the BEST.** Kai wins first prize at the science fair but just says, "My friends helped a lot." He never calls himself the best. He is **modest**.

Though she had won the state prize, Kai's sister was too **modest** *to mention it.*

SIMILAR humble, unassuming, self-effacing, unpretentious
OPPOSITE arrogant, boastful, conceited

unassuming un-uh-**SOO**-ming *adjective*



MEANING not drawing attention to yourself; quiet and humble

MEMORY HOOK **UN-ASSUMING: you'd never ASSUME.** The quiet woman in the plain sweater, reading in the back row, is the famous author everyone came to see. You'd never assume it: she is **unassuming**.

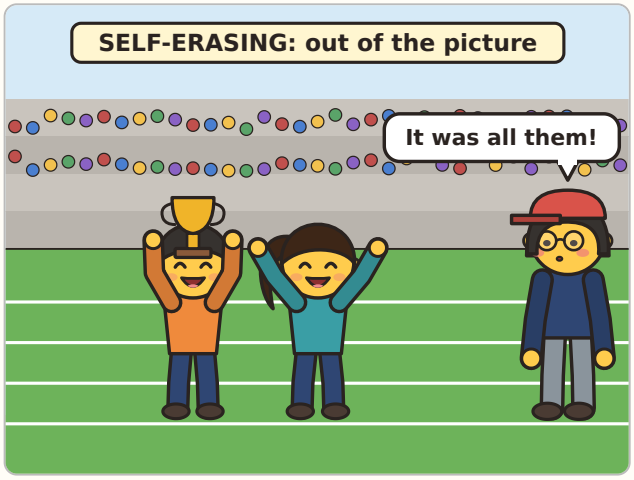
The **unassuming** *man in the back row turned out to be the famous author.*

PARTS **un-** not + **assume** take on airs (an old sense)

SIMILAR humble, modest, unpretentious, low-key

OPPOSITE pretentious, showy, arrogant

self-effacing self-ih-**FAY**-sing *adjective*



MEANING keeping yourself in the background; humble

MEMORY HOOK **SELF-ERASING: she rubs herSELF out.** When the team photo is taken, the coach steps to the very edge, nearly out of the picture, and says, "It was all them." She is **self-effacing**.

The **self-effacing** *coach gave all the credit to her players.*

PARTS **self** oneself + **efface** to rub out, erase

SIMILAR humble, modest, shy, retiring

OPPOSITE boastful, attention-seeking, arrogant

ethical **ETH**-ih-kul *adjective*



MEANING following principles of right conduct; morally right

MEMORY HOOK **EDITH-ICAL: Edith does the right thing.** When a customer pays twenty dollars too much, Edith runs down the street to give it back. Edith is **ethical**.

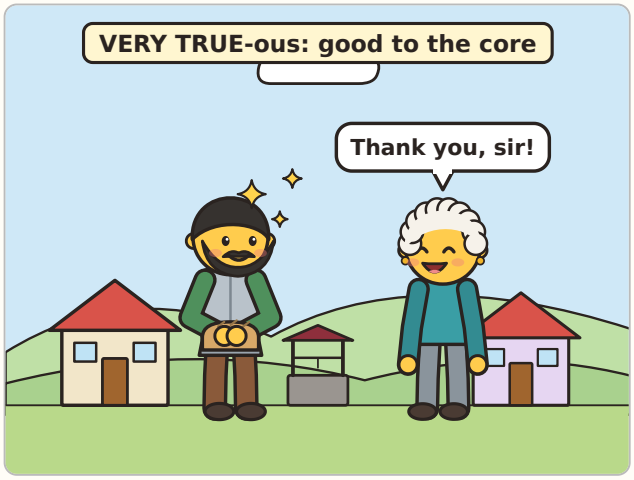
An **ethical** *reporter checks every fact before publishing a story.*

PARTS **eth** character, custom (Greek ethos) + **-ical** having to do with

SIMILAR moral, principled, honorable, right

OPPOSITE unethical, corrupt, dishonest

virtuous **VUR**-choo-us *adjective*



MEANING having high moral standards; good

MEMORY HOOK **VIR-TU-OUS: VERY TRUE and good.** Sir Omar keeps every promise, shares his bread and never tells a lie: he is very true and very good. He is **virtuous**.

The **virtuous** *shopkeeper returned the lost wallet with every dollar still inside.*

PARTS **virtu** goodness, excellence (Latin virtus) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR good, moral, upright, honorable

OPPOSITE wicked, corrupt, immoral

propriety pruh-**PRY**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING correct, proper behavior

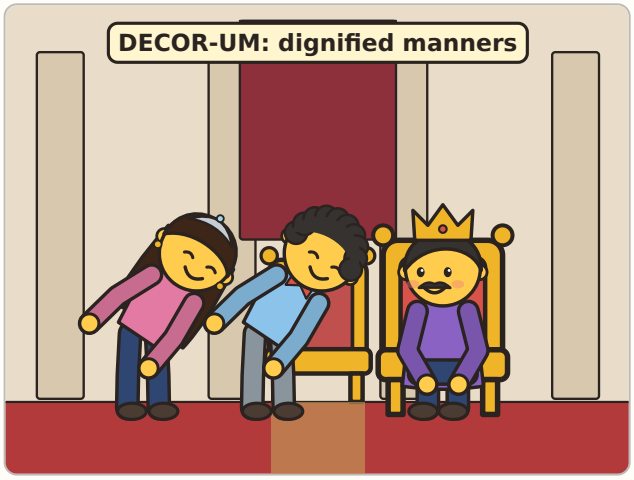
MEMORY HOOK **PROPER-iety: doing what is PROPER.** At the fancy dinner, Ivy keeps her napkin on her lap, her elbows off the table and her "thank you" ready. She shows perfect **propriety**.

Out of **propriety**, *the guests waited for the host to sit before they began eating.*

PARTS **propri** one's own (Latin proprius) + **-ety** the state or quality of

SIMILAR correctness, decency, good manners, etiquette
OPPOSITE impropriety, rudeness

decorum dih-**KOR**-um *noun*



MEANING polite, dignified behavior that suits the occasion

MEMORY HOOK **DECOR-um: manners to match the fancy DECOR.** In the grand palace hall, guests bow, speak softly and wait their turn, matching the elegant decor. They show perfect **decorum**.

The guests at the royal dinner behaved with perfect **decorum**.

SIMILAR dignity, good manners, etiquette, politeness
OPPOSITE rudeness, impropriety, unruliness

probity **PROH**-bih-tee *noun*



MEANING complete honesty and integrity

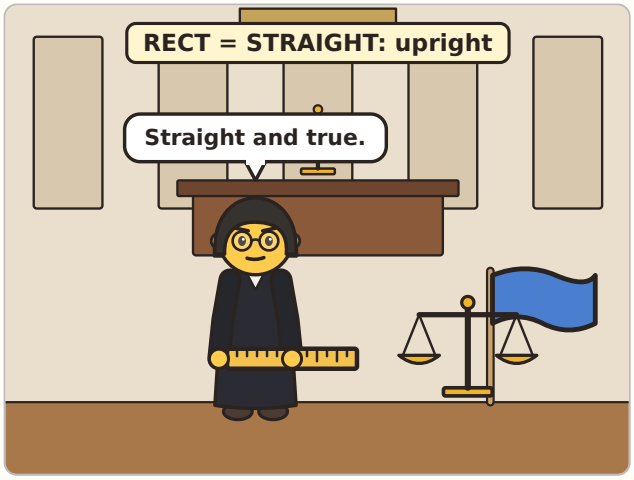
MEMORY HOOK **PROBE-ITY: probe all you want, it's honest.** The inspectors probe every page of Treasurer Lin's books and find every penny in its place. Her **probity** is complete.

The judge was known for her **probity**; *no one ever doubted her rulings.*

PARTS **prob** good, honest (Latin probus) + **-ity** the state or quality of

SIMILAR integrity, honesty, trustworthiness, uprightness
OPPOSITE dishonesty, corruption

rectitude **REK**-tih-tood *noun*



MEANING moral uprightness; strict honesty and goodness

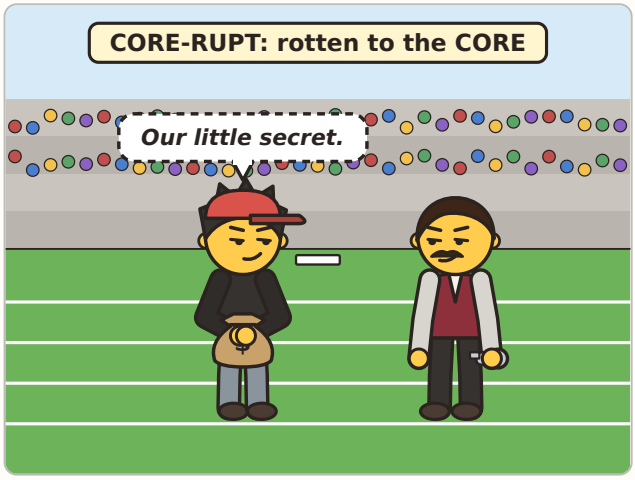
MEMORY HOOK **RECT = STRAIGHT: an upright life.** Judge Ada stands as straight as a ruler and lives the same way: she has never told a lie or taken a bribe. Her **rectitude** is famous.

Her **rectitude** *made her the obvious choice to guard the prize money.*

PARTS **rect** straight, right + **-itude** the state or quality of

SIMILAR uprightness, integrity, righteousness, honesty
OPPOSITE wickedness, corruption, dishonesty

corrupt kuh-**RUPT** *adjective*



MEANING dishonest, especially in exchange for money or power

MEMORY HOOK **CORE-RUPT: rotten to the CORE.** The referee pockets a bag of coins and calls every play for the team that paid him. Rotten to the core, he is **corrupt**.

*The **corrupt** referee was paid to call every play for one team.*

PARTS **cor** thoroughly (from con) + **rupt** break

SIMILAR dishonest, crooked, bribable, shady
OPPOSITE honest, ethical, upright

venal **VEE**-nul *adjective*



MEANING willing to be bribed; open to doing wrong for money

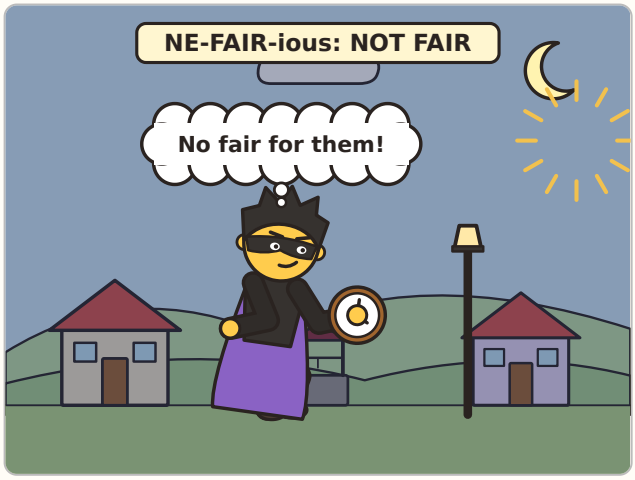
MEMORY HOOK **VEND-AL: pay him like a VENDING machine.** Drop a coin in his hand and the guard opens the gate for anyone, like a vending machine. He is **venal**.

*The **venal** guard let anyone through the gate for a gold coin.*

PARTS **ven** sale (Latin venum) + **-al** having to do with

SIMILAR bribable, corruptible, mercenary, crooked
OPPOSITE incorruptible, honest, upright

nefarious nih-**FAIR**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING wicked or criminal

MEMORY HOOK **NE-FAIR-ious: NOT FAIR, but wicked.** Late at night the villain sneaks off with the town clock so that everyone will miss the fair. His scheme is **nefarious**.

*The villain's **nefarious** plan was to steal the town's clock so everyone would miss the fair.*

PARTS **ne** not + **fas** what is right

SIMILAR wicked, villainous, criminal, crooked
OPPOSITE virtuous, good, noble

reprehensible rep-rih-**HEN**-suh-bul *adjective*



MEANING deserving strong blame

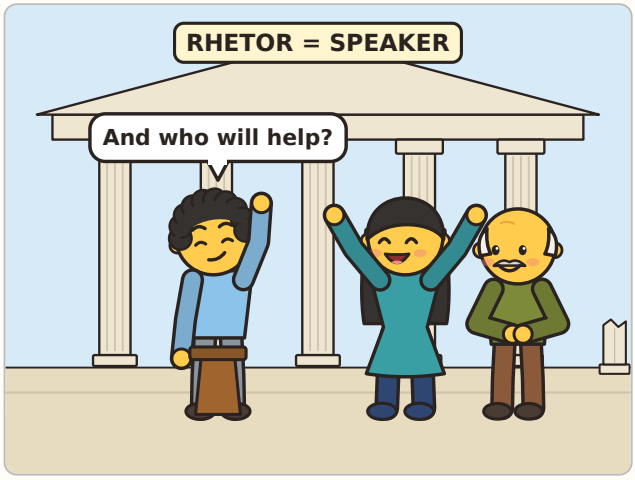
MEMORY HOOK **REPRIMAND-IBLE: deserves a REPRIMAND.** Rex knocks over little Theo's block tower on purpose, and Tia scolds him sharply. Such behavior is **reprehensible**.

*Rex behaved **reprehensibly** when he knocked down a little kid's block tower on purpose.*

PARTS **re** back + **prehens** seize, grasp + **-ible** deserving to be

SIMILAR shameful, disgraceful, blameworthy, deplorable
OPPOSITE praiseworthy, admirable, commendable

rhetoric RET-er-ik *noun*



MEANING the art of persuasive speaking or writing; also, showy talk with little substance

MEMORY HOOK **RHETOR = SPEAKER: the art of winning a crowd.** With a pause here and a question there, Jamal wins over the whole crowd using nothing but well-chosen words. He is a master of **rhetoric**.

The debate coach taught **rhetoric***: how to open strong, use examples and end with a question.*

PARTS **rhetor** public speaker (Greek) + **-ic** the art of

SIMILAR oratory, persuasion, eloquence, bombast

assert uh-SURT *verb*



MEANING to state something firmly and confidently

MEMORY HOOK **a SERGEANT doesn't ask: he ASSERTS.** "We march at dawn!" the sergeant says, firm and sure, without a trace of doubt. He doesn't ask; he **asserts**.

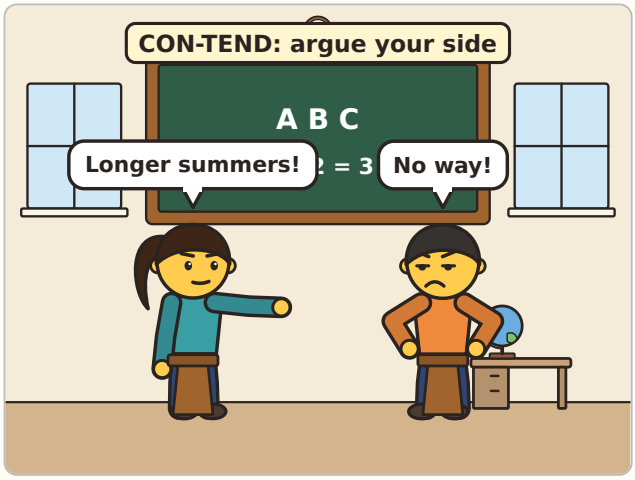
Zoe **asserted** *that her cat could open doors, and then the cat did.*

PARTS **as** to (from ad) + **sert** join, put

SIMILAR declare, affirm, state, insist

OPPOSITE deny, retract

contend kun-TEND *verb*



MEANING to argue that something is true; also, to compete

MEMORY HOOK **CON-TEND: a CONTEST of arguments.** In the class debate, Maya argues hard that summer should be longer, and she has three reasons ready. She **contends** it.

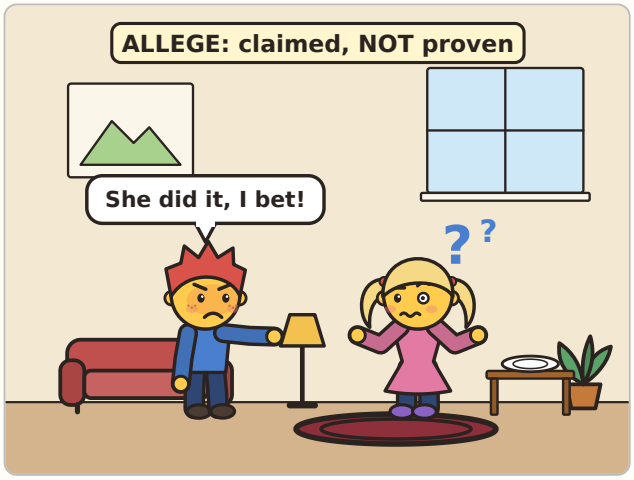
Maya **contends** *that summer vacation should be a month longer.*

PARTS **con** with, against + **tend** stretch, strive

SIMILAR argue, maintain, insist, hold

OPPOSITE concede, deny

allege uh-LEJ *verb*



MEANING to claim something, especially wrongdoing, without proof yet

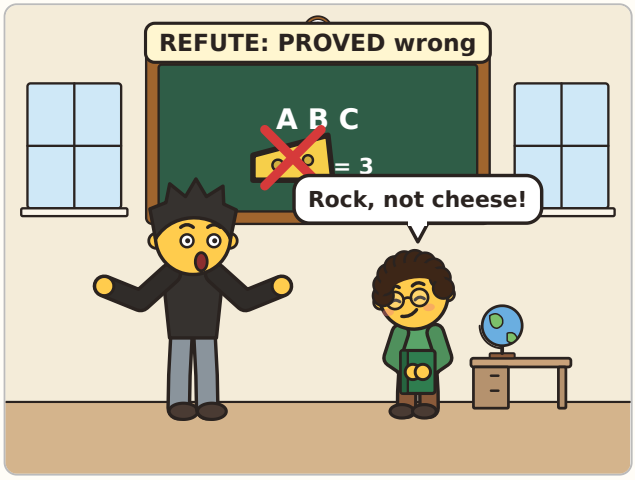
MEMORY HOOK **a-LEDGE: out on a LEDGE with no proof.** Pip says his sister ate his cupcake, but he has nothing to back it up, only a guess. He is out on a ledge: he **alleges** it.

Pip **alleged** *that his sister ate the last cupcake, but he had no proof.*

SIMILAR claim, charge, accuse

OPPOSITE deny

refute rih-**FYOOT** *verb*



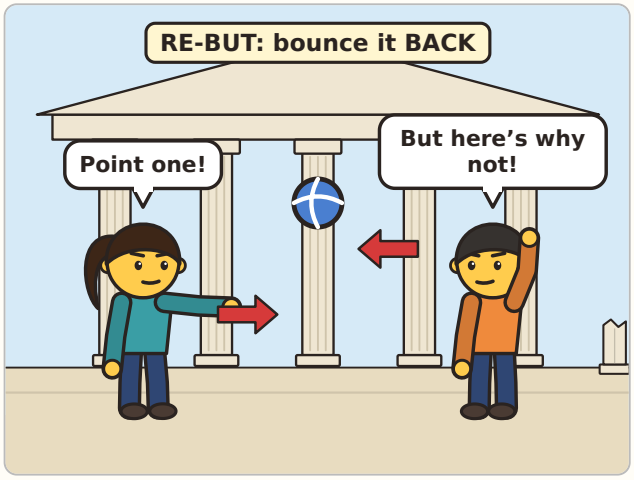
MEANING to prove that a claim is wrong

MEMORY HOOK **RE-FUTE: PROOF puts the boot to it.** Rex claims the moon is made of cheese, so Sami shows him a moon rock in the science book. Sami **refutes** the claim: he proves it wrong.

Sami **refuted** *Rex's claim by showing him a photo of a real moon rock.*

SIMILAR disprove, debunk, discredit, invalidate
OPPOSITE prove, confirm, support

rebut rih-**BUT** *verb*



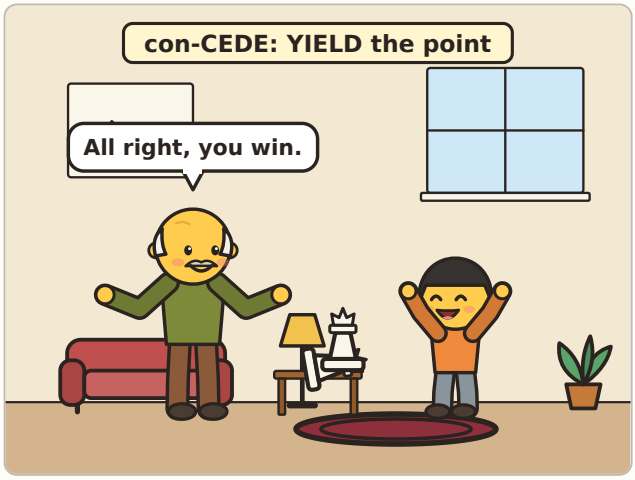
MEANING to argue against a claim by giving an answer

MEMORY HOOK **RE-BUT: bounce it right BACK.** Each time Maya makes a point, Dev bounces an answer right back, like a ball off a wall. He **rebuts** every claim, though he may not win.

Each speaker had two minutes to **rebut** *the other side's points.*

SIMILAR counter, answer, contradict, dispute
OPPOSITE accept, concede, agree with

concede kun-**SEED** *verb*



MEANING to admit that something is true, often unwillingly

MEMORY HOOK **con-CEDE: YIELD the point.** After a long chess game, Grandpa tips over his own king and smiles: "You win." He **concedes**.

After the long chess game, Grandpa **conceded** *that Kai had won.*

PARTS **con** thoroughly, with + **cede** yield, go
SIMILAR admit, acknowledge, grant, allow
OPPOSITE deny, dispute, contest

advocate **AD**-vuh-kayt *verb*



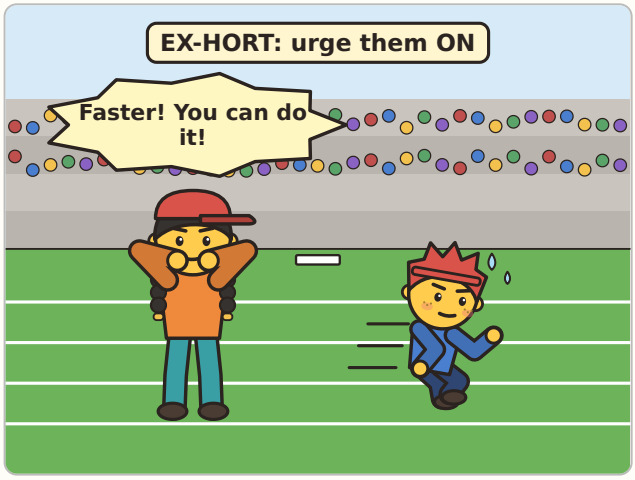
MEANING to speak or argue in favor of

MEMORY HOOK **AD-VOC: add your VOICE for it.** Rosa adds her voice to the call for a crosswalk near the school, speaking up at every meeting. She **advocates** for it.

Rosa **advocated** *for a crosswalk in front of the school.*

PARTS **ad** to + **voc** voice, call + **-ate** to act on
SIMILAR support, champion, promote, argue for
OPPOSITE oppose, attack, discourage

exhort ig-**ZORT** *verb*



MEANING to urge strongly and earnestly

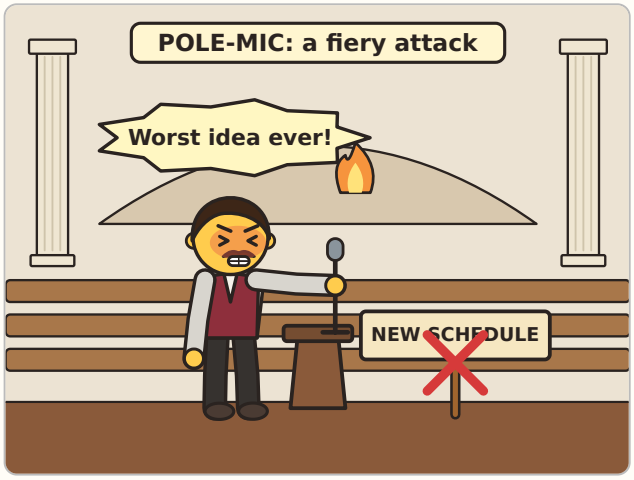
MEMORY HOOK **EX-HORT: HOLLER them forward.** On the last lap, the coach runs alongside the track, hollering, “Faster! You can do it!” She **exhorts** her runners.

The coach ***exhorted*** *her runners to give everything on the last lap.*

PARTS **ex** thoroughly + **hort** urge, encourage

SIMILAR urge, press, encourage, implore
OPPOSITE discourage, dissuade

polemic puh-**LEM**-ik *noun*



MEANING a strong written or spoken attack on an idea

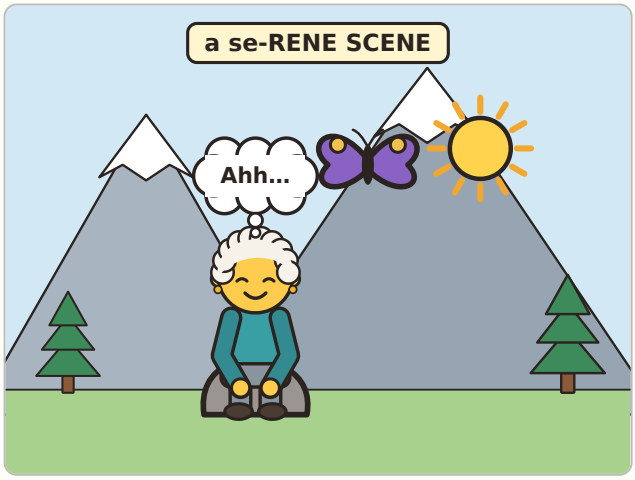
MEMORY HOOK **POLE-MIC: grab the MIC and attack.** Victor grabs the mic and launches a fiery attack on the new school schedule, calling it the worst idea in history. His speech is a **polemic**.

His letter to the editor was a fiery ***polemic*** *against the new parking rules.*

PARTS **polem** war (Greek polemos) + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR diatribe, attack, tirade, broadside
OPPOSITE tribute, praise

serene suh-**REEN** *adjective*



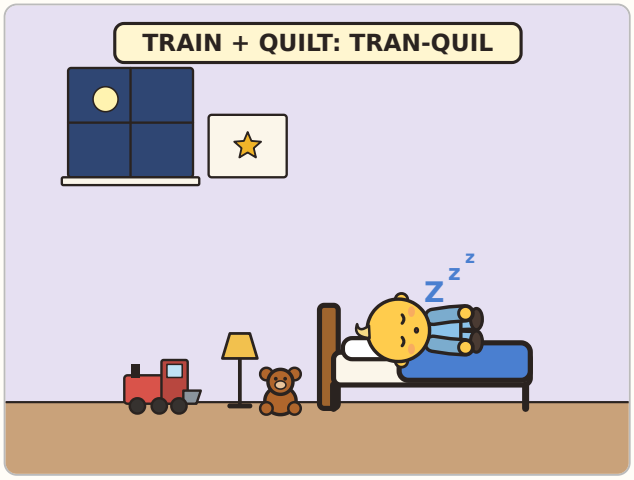
MEANING calm and peaceful; untroubled

MEMORY HOOK **a se-RENE SCENE.** High on the mountain, Nana Lou sits on a rock and watches the sun go down over the quiet valley. It is a **serene** scene.

At dawn the lake was ***serene****, without a ripple or a sound.*

SIMILAR peaceful, calm, untroubled, placid
OPPOSITE agitated, troubled, turbulent

tranquil **TRANG**-kwil *adjective*



MEANING quiet and still; free from disturbance

MEMORY HOOK **a toy TRAIN and a QUILT: TRAN-QUIL.** Theo’s toy train sits still on the rug while he sleeps under his warm quilt. The whole room is quiet and **tranquil**.

By evening the stormy sea had turned ***tranquil****.*

SIMILAR peaceful, quiet, placid, untroubled
OPPOSITE noisy, turbulent, chaotic

composed kum-**POHZD** *adjective*



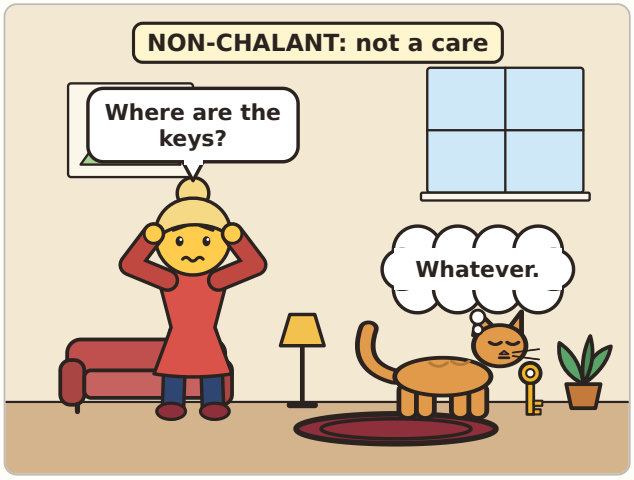
MEANING in control of your feelings; not flustered

MEMORY HOOK **the COMPOSER stays COMPOSED.** When the stage lights flicker during her recital, Lila keeps playing without missing a note. She stays **composed**.

Even when the lights went out, the pianist stayed **composed** *and went on playing.*

SIMILAR collected, self-possessed, poised, cool
OPPOSITE flustered, agitated, rattled

nonchalant non-shuh-**LAHNT** *adjective*



MEANING casually unconcerned, as if nothing much matters

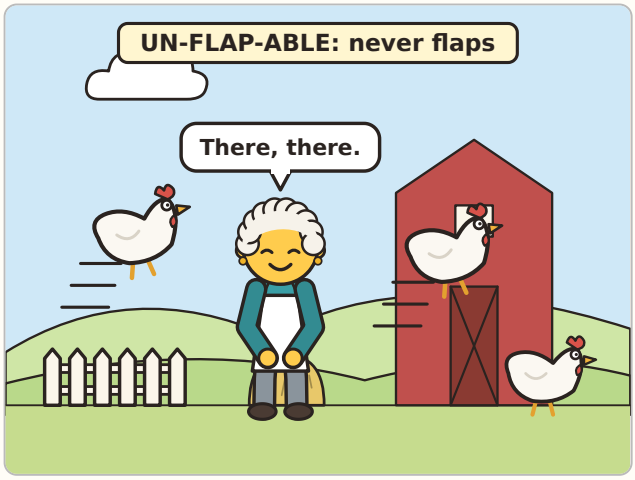
MEMORY HOOK **NON-CHALANT: "I shall NOT care.".** Everyone is hunting for the lost keys, but the cat just yawns in the sunny window: "I shall not care." The cat is **nonchalant**.

With a **nonchalant** *shrug, Dev said he had probably won the contest.*

PARTS **non** not + **chal** be concerned (French chaloir)

SIMILAR casual, unconcerned, offhand, blasé
OPPOSITE anxious, concerned, worried

unflappable un-**FLAP**-uh-bul *adjective*



MEANING staying calm even in a sudden crisis

MEMORY HOOK **UN-FLAP-able: never flaps like a chicken.** The chickens flap and squawk in a panic, but Nana Lou calmly scoops them up one by one. She is **unflappable**.

The **unflappable** *pilot landed the plane smoothly in the storm.*

PARTS **un-** not + **flap** a state of panic (informal) + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR cool, collected, unruffled, unexcitable
OPPOSITE excitable, jittery, panicky

stoic **STOH**-ik *adjective*



MEANING enduring pain or hardship without complaining

MEMORY HOOK **STO-IC: STONE-faced, no complaints.** In freezing rain and howling wind, Sven hauls in his nets hour after hour without one complaint. He is **stoic**.

The fisherman **stoically** *hauled his nets through the freezing rain for hours, without one complaint.*

PARTS **sto** porch (Greek stoa) + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR uncomplaining, long-suffering, patient, impassive
OPPOSITE complaining, whiny, emotional

impassive im-**PAS**-iv *adjective*



MEANING showing no feeling on your face

MEMORY HOOK **IM-PASS-ive: NO PASSION shows.** The kids tell jokes and make silly faces, but the palace guard's face does not move a bit. He is **impassive**.

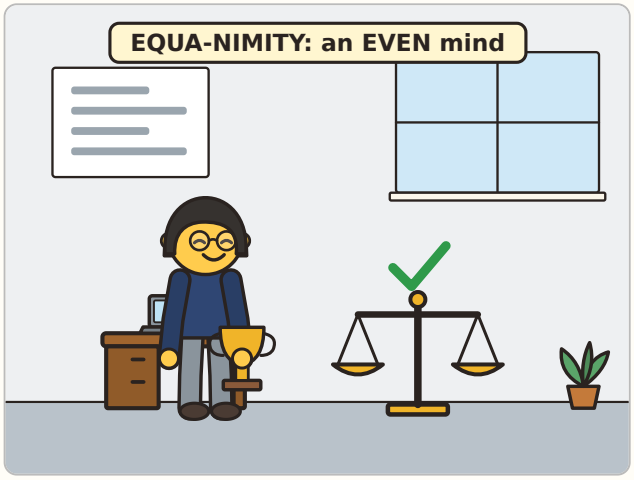
The palace guard stared **impassively** *ahead while the children made silly faces at him.*

PARTS **im-** not + **pass** feel, suffer + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR expressionless, unemotional, poker-faced, stolid

OPPOSITE emotional, expressive, impassioned

equanimity ee-kwuh-**NIM**-ih-tee *noun*



MEANING calmness and evenness of temper, especially under stress

MEMORY HOOK **EQUA-NIMITY: an EQUAL, even mind.** Whether her team wins or loses, Coach Ada's mood stays perfectly level, like a balanced scale. She meets both with **equanimity**.

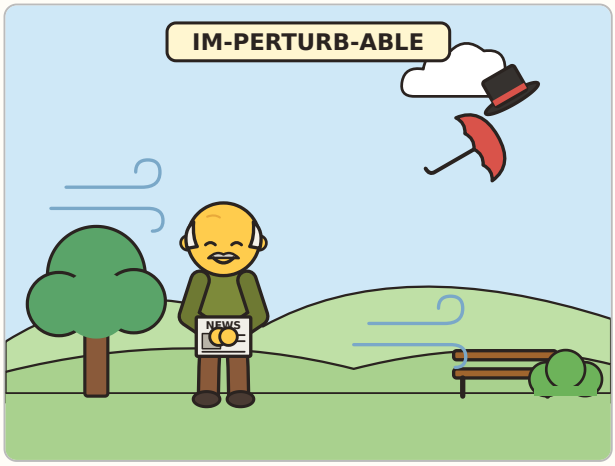
Coach Ada met both the big win and the bad loss with **equanimity**.

PARTS **equ** even, equal + **anim** mind, spirit + **-ity** the state of

SIMILAR composure, calm, poise, level-headedness

OPPOSITE agitation, panic, anxiety

imperturbable im-per-**TUR**-buh-bul *adjective*



MEANING so calm that nothing can upset you

MEMORY HOOK **IM-PERTURB-able: nothing DISTURBS him.** The wind howls, an umbrella flies past and hats blow away, but Grandpa calmly turns the page of his newspaper. He is **imperturbable**.

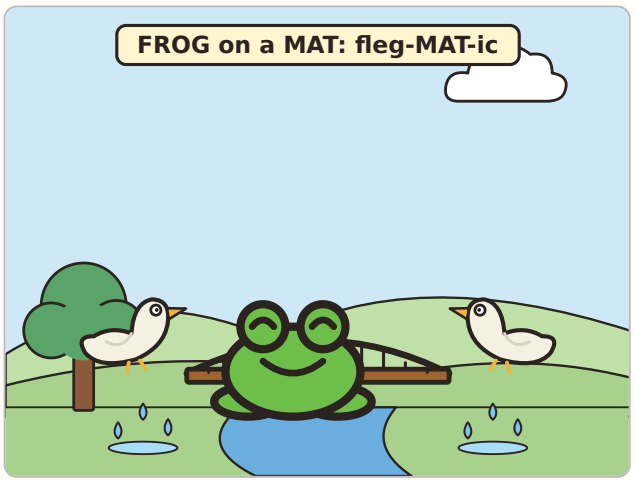
Grandpa is **imperturbable**; *he reads his paper calmly even in a thunderstorm.*

PARTS **im-** not + **per** thoroughly + **turb** disturb, stir up + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR unshakable, unruffled, untroubled, unexcitable

OPPOSITE excitable, nervous, touchy

phlegmatic fleg-**MAT**-ik *adjective*



MEANING calm and unexcitable by nature; slow to show feeling

MEMORY HOOK **a FROG on a MAT: fleg-MAT-ic.** While the ducks splash and squawk around him, the big frog sits on his lily pad, blinking slowly. Nothing excites him; he is **phlegmatic**.

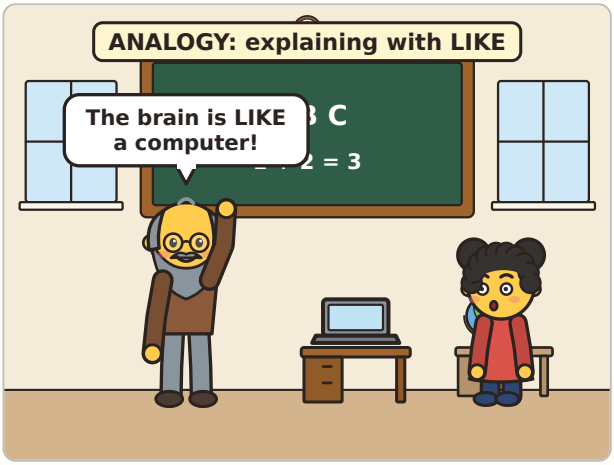
Even as a baby, Sam was **phlegmatic**: *he rarely cried, rarely squealed and hardly ever fussed.*

PARTS **phlegm** one of the four "humors" of old medicine + **-atic** having to do with

SIMILAR unemotional, stolid, unexcitable, placid

OPPOSITE excitable, passionate, emotional

analogy uh-**NAL**-uh-jee *noun*



MEANING a comparison that explains one thing by its likeness to another

MEMORY HOOK **"The brain is LIKE a computer".** To explain how the brain stores memories, Professor Edwin points from his head to his laptop: "It works like this!" That comparison is an **analogy**.

The coach used an **analogy** *: a team is like a clock, and every little gear matters.*

PARTS **ana** according to (Greek) + **log** word, reason, ratio

SIMILAR comparison, parallel, likeness, correspondence

OPPOSITE contrast

akin uh-**KIN** *adjective*



MEANING similar or related

MEMORY HOOK **A-KIN: alike as KIN.** Kai's puppy and Granny Mae's old dog have the same spots, the same floppy ears and the same bark. They look like kin: they are **akin**.

Her fear of heights is **akin** *to her brother's fear of deep water.*

PARTS **a-** of (an old English prefix) + **kin** family

SIMILAR similar, related, alike, comparable

OPPOSITE unlike, different, unrelated

kindred **KIN**-drid *adjective*



MEANING alike in nature or interests; related

MEMORY HOOK **KIN-DRED SPIRITS: family at heart.** Rosa and Nana Lou reach for the same old mystery novel and burst out laughing. They are like family at heart: **kindred** spirits.

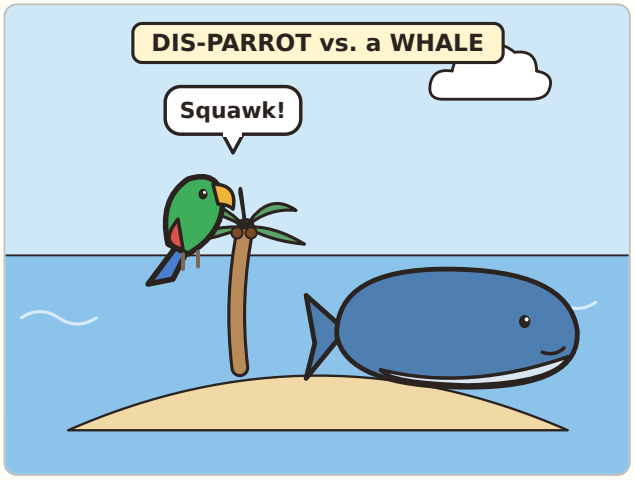
Rosa and Nana Lou turned out to be **kindred** *spirits, both crazy about mystery novels.*

PARTS **kin** family + **-red** condition (an old English ending, as in hatred)

SIMILAR related, like-minded, similar, allied

OPPOSITE unrelated, dissimilar, alien

disparate **DIS**-per-it *adjective*



MEANING so different that they can hardly be compared

MEMORY HOOK **DIS-PARROT and a WHALE.** A tiny feathered parrot and a huge swimming whale: they share almost nothing. They are **disparate**.

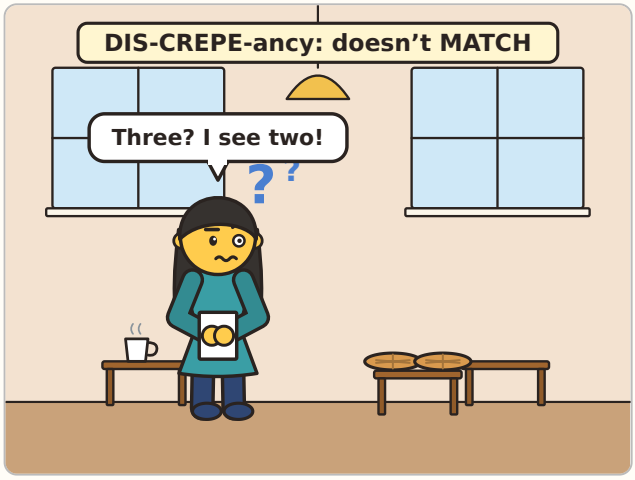
The club brought together **disparate** *people: a pilot, a poet, a plumber and a pastry chef.*

PARTS **dis** apart

SIMILAR different, dissimilar, unrelated, distinct

OPPOSITE similar, alike, akin

discrepancy dih-**SKREP**-un-see *noun*



MEANING a difference between things that should match

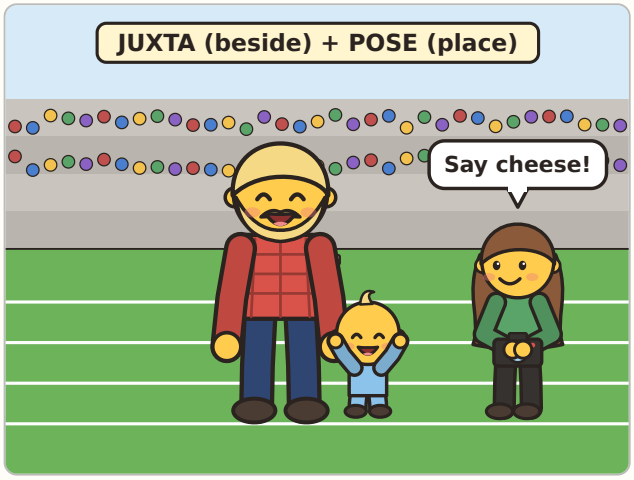
MEMORY HOOK **DIS-CREPE-ancy: 3 CREPES paid, 2 served.** The ticket says three crepes, but Lin's plate holds only two. She spots the **discrepancy**.

Lin noticed a **discrepancy** *between the receipt and the number of crepes on her plate.*

PARTS **dis** apart + **crep** sound, rattle (Latin crepare) + **-ancy** the state of

SIMILAR mismatch, inconsistency, difference, gap
OPPOSITE agreement, consistency, match

juxtapose **JUK**-stuh-pohz *verb*



MEANING to place side by side, especially to compare or contrast

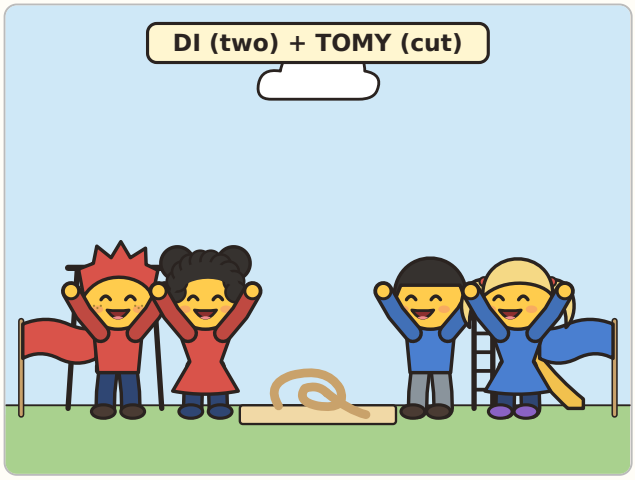
MEMORY HOOK **JUXTA-POSE: POSE them side by side.** For the team photo, Rosa poses the giant center right beside the littlest fan. To **juxtapose** is to place things side by side.

The photo **juxtaposes** *the tallest player on the team with the tiny mascot.*

PARTS **juxta** beside, near + **pose** place, put

SIMILAR place side by side, set beside, compare, pair
OPPOSITE separate

dichotomy dye-**KOT**-uh-mee *noun*



MEANING a split into two opposite parts or groups

MEMORY HOOK **DI-CHOTOMY: CUT in TWO.** At summer camp, everyone is split into two opposite teams, Red and Blue, and every game is Red against Blue. That split is a **dichotomy**.

The story sets up a sharp **dichotomy** *between the noisy city and the quiet farm.*

PARTS **dicho** in two + **tomy** cutting

SIMILAR division, split, contrast, divide
OPPOSITE unity

antithesis an-**TITH**-uh-sis *noun*



MEANING the direct opposite

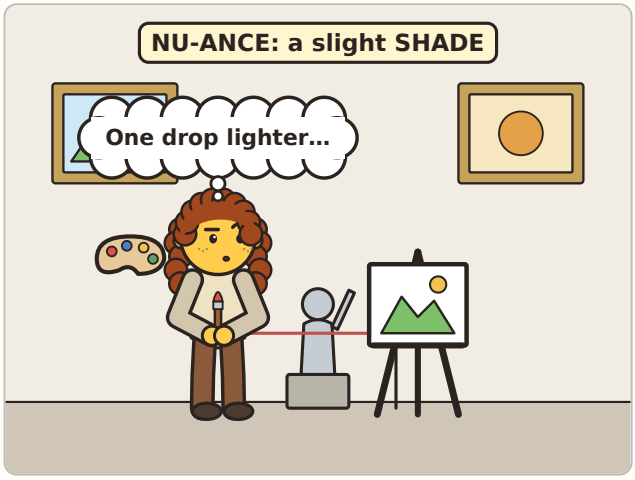
MEMORY HOOK **ANTI-THESIS: the total OPPOSITE.** Pip loves noise, mess and speed; his twin, Lila, loves quiet, order and books. Lila is Pip's **antithesis**.

Pip's messy room is the **antithesis** *of his twin sister's neat one.*

PARTS **anti** against, opposite + **thesis** a placing, a statement

SIMILAR opposite, reverse, contrary, converse
OPPOSITE equivalent

nuance NOO-ahns *noun*



MEANING a subtle difference in meaning, feeling or tone

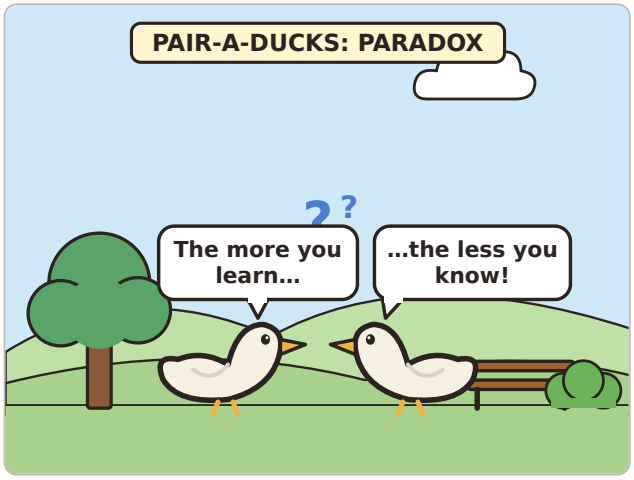
MEMORY HOOK **NEW-ANCE: one tiny NEW shade.** Nell mixes seven blues for the sky, each just one drop lighter than the last. Each tiny shade of difference is a **nuance**.

A good actor can show a dozen **nuances** *of sadness with just her eyes.*

PARTS **-ance** the state or quality of (a noun ending)

SIMILAR shade, subtlety, fine distinction, hint

paradox PAIR-uh-doks *noun*



MEANING a statement that seems to contradict itself but may be true

MEMORY HOOK **PAIR-A-DUCKS.** A pair of wise ducks quack, "The more you learn, the less you know!" It sounds impossible but may be true: a **paradox**.

"The more you learn, the less you know" is a famous **paradox**.

PARTS **para** beyond, against + **dox** opinion, belief

SIMILAR contradiction, seeming contradiction, inconsistency

commence kuh-MENS *verb*



MEANING to begin, especially in a formal way

MEMORY HOOK **COMMENCEMENT: the day your new life BEGINS.** Graduation is called commencement because it is a beginning, not an end. On that day, the graduates **commence** their grown-up lives.

The concert will **commence** *at seven o'clock sharp.*

SIMILAR begin, start, open, launch

OPPOSITE end, finish, conclude

initiate ih-NISH-ee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to set something going; also, to admit a new member to a group

MEMORY HOOK **INITIAL-ate: take the INITIAL step.** At the party everyone stands around shyly until Zoe takes the initial step onto the dance floor. She **initiates** the dancing.

Zoe **initiated** *the dancing by stepping onto the empty floor.*

PARTS **init** beginning + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR set in motion, institute, trigger, induct

OPPOSITE end, halt, terminate

inaugurate in-**AW**-gyuh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to open or begin with a formal ceremony; to install in office

MEMORY HOOK **IN AUGUST: a grand OPENING.** In August the town opens its new bridge with a band, balloons and a speech by Granny Mae. They **inaugurate** it.

The town **inaugurated** *its new library with a ribbon, a band and a cake.*

PARTS **in** in, into + **augur** one who reads signs (from birds) + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR open, launch, begin, install

OPPOSITE close, end, conclude

inception in-**SEP**-shun *noun*



MEANING the moment at which something is founded or begun

MEMORY HOOK **IN-CEPT-ion: the moment the idea is TAKEN IN.** Lin bites into her grandmother's bread and cries, "I'll open a bakery!" That moment was the bakery's **inception**.

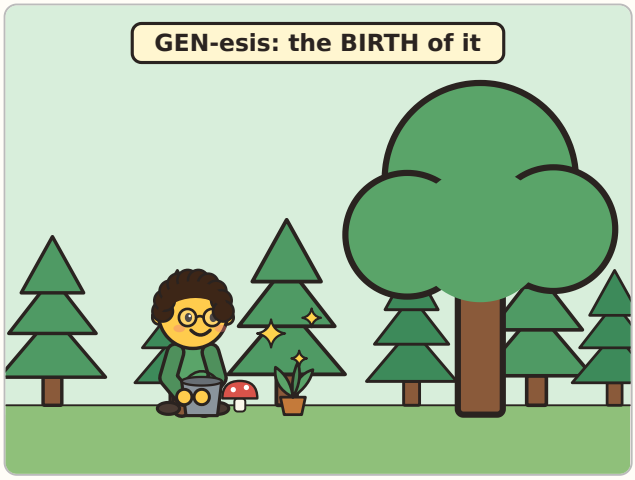
From its **inception**, *the bakery was famous for its cinnamon rolls.*

PARTS **in** in, on + **cept** take (from Latin capere) + **-ion** the act of

SIMILAR beginning, start, founding, outset

OPPOSITE end, conclusion, close

genesis **JEN**-uh-sis *noun*



MEANING the origin or birth of something

MEMORY HOOK **GEN-esis: the BIRTH of it.** Sami waters a tiny sprout beside the giant old oak. Every great tree has its **genesis**, its birth, in one small seed.

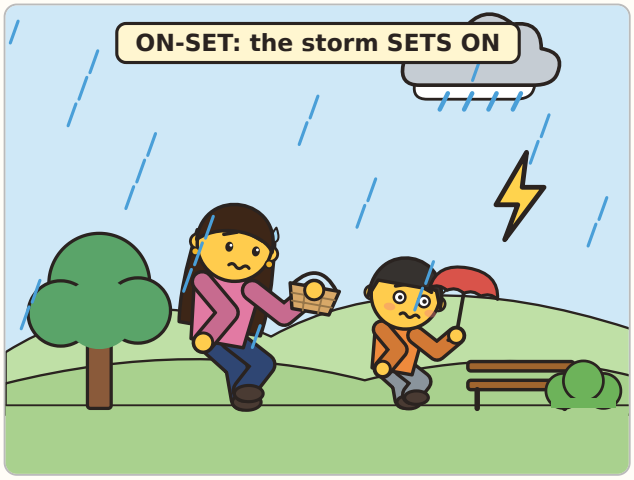
The **genesis** *of the giant oak was a single acorn.*

PARTS **gen** birth, origin + **-esis** process (Greek)

SIMILAR origin, birth, source, beginning

OPPOSITE end, finale, conclusion

onset **ON**-set *noun*



MEANING the beginning of something, usually something unpleasant

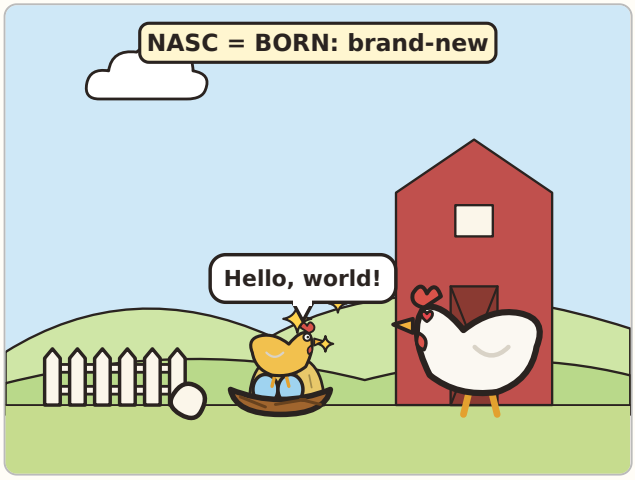
MEMORY HOOK **ON-SET: the storm SETS ON.** The sky darkens and the first raindrops fall: the storm is setting on. At its **onset**, the picnickers grab their baskets and run.

At the **onset** *of the storm, the picnickers grabbed their baskets and ran.*

SIMILAR outbreak, arrival, first signs, coming

OPPOSITE end, close

nascent **NAY**-sunt *adjective*



MEANING just born; only beginning to exist or grow

MEMORY HOOK **NASC = BORN: a just-hatched chick.** The chick has just pecked its way out of the shell, and its life has only begun. Something that new is **nascent**.

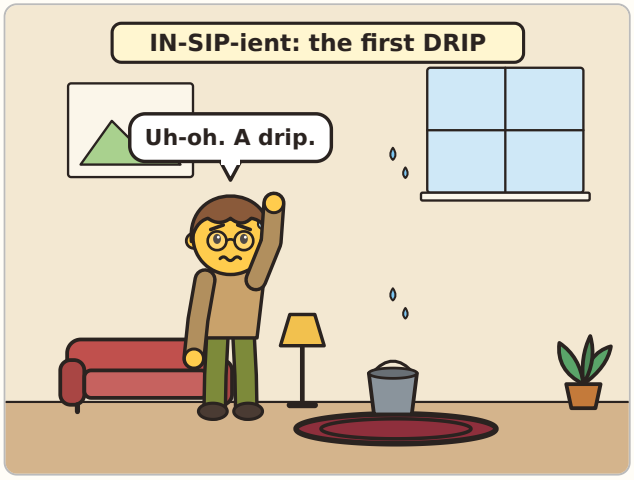
With six teams and one muddy field, the town's **nascent** *soccer league was only a few weeks old.*

PARTS **nasc** be born + **-ent** being or doing (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR budding, emerging, developing, embryonic

OPPOSITE mature, established, dying

incipient in-**SIP**-ee-unt *adjective*



MEANING just beginning to appear or develop, often as an early sign of trouble

MEMORY HOOK **IN-SIP-ient: the first little SIP of trouble.** A single drip from the ceiling is the first little sip of a leak. Fix it now, while the leak is still **incipient**, before the roof gives way.

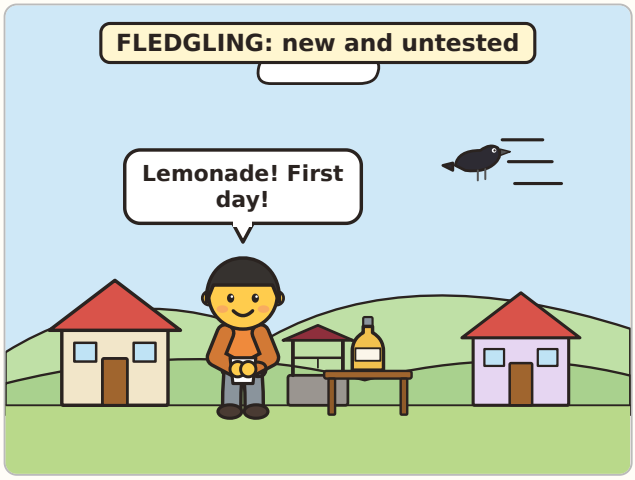
Dad spotted the **incipient** *leak while it was still a single drip.*

PARTS **in** in, on + **cip** take (from Latin capere) + **-ient** being (an adjective ending)

SIMILAR emerging, developing, early, beginning

OPPOSITE full-blown, developed, mature

fledgling **FLEJ**-ling *adjective*



MEANING new and inexperienced, like a young bird learning to fly

MEMORY HOOK **a FLEDGLING bird: first wobbly flight.** Like a baby bird on its first wobbly flight, Kai's brand-new lemonade stand is just getting started. It is a **fledgling** business.

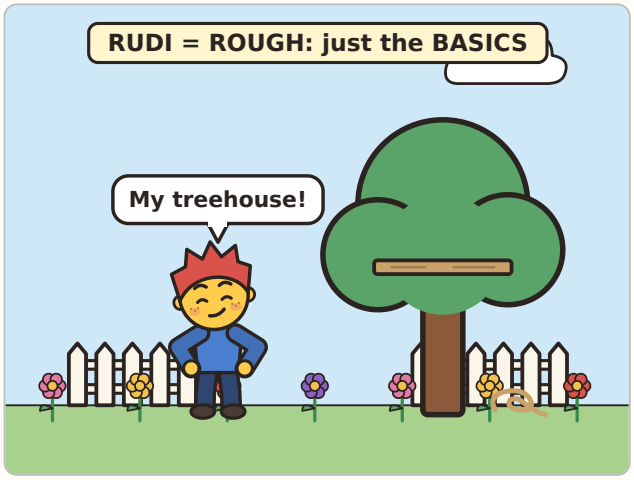
The **fledgling** *pilot gripped the controls nervously on her very first solo flight.*

PARTS **fledge** grow flight feathers + **-ling** a small or young one

SIMILAR new, inexperienced, budding, untested

OPPOSITE established, experienced, veteran

rudimentary roo-duh-**MEN**-tuh-ree *adjective*



MEANING basic and simple; not developed beyond the first stage

MEMORY HOOK **RUDE = ROUGH: just the basics.** Pip's first treehouse is rough and simple: four boards, a rope and a blanket for a roof. It is **rudimentary**.

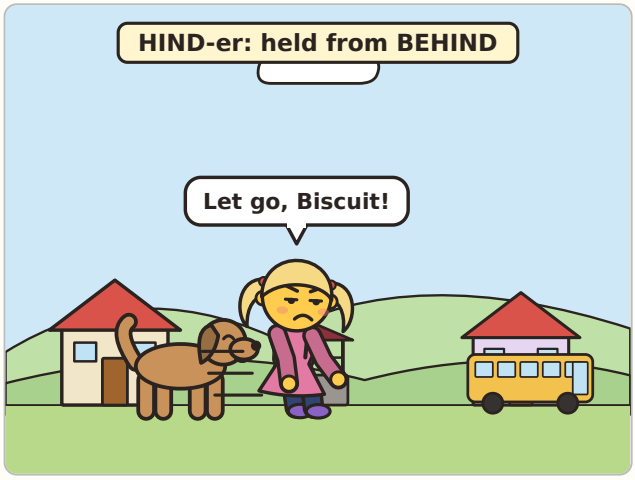
Pip's first treehouse was **rudimentary***: four boards and a blanket for a roof.*

PARTS **rudi** rough, unformed + **-mentary** having to do with

SIMILAR basic, elementary, simple, crude

OPPOSITE advanced, sophisticated, complex

hinder HIN-der *verb*



MEANING to get in the way of; to slow down

MEMORY HOOK **HIND-er: tugged from BEHIND.** Ivy tries to walk to the bus, but the puppy hangs onto her backpack from behind. The puppy **hinders** her.

The puppy tugging at her backpack **hindered** *Ivy's walk to the bus.*

SIMILAR hold back, slow, hamper, impede
OPPOSITE help, aid, facilitate

hamper HAM-per *verb*



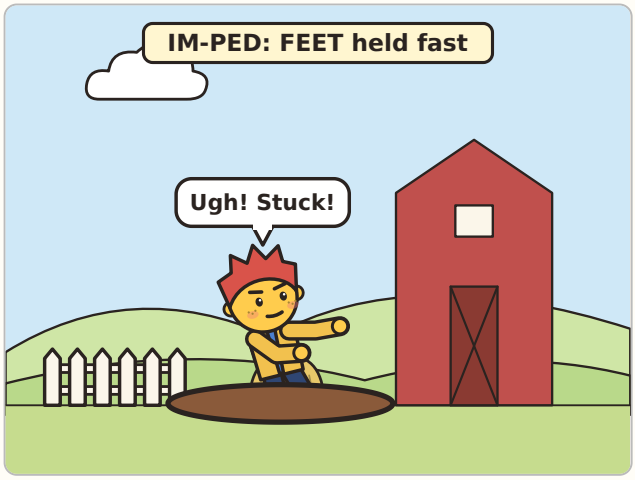
MEANING to hold back or slow down progress

MEMORY HOOK **a heavy HAMPER slows the hike.** Dev lugs the huge picnic hamper up the steep hill, one slow step at a time. The heavy basket **hampers** his climb.

The giant picnic basket **hampered** *Dev's climb up the hill.*

SIMILAR hinder, slow, restrict, handicap
OPPOSITE help, assist, aid

impede im-PEED *verb*



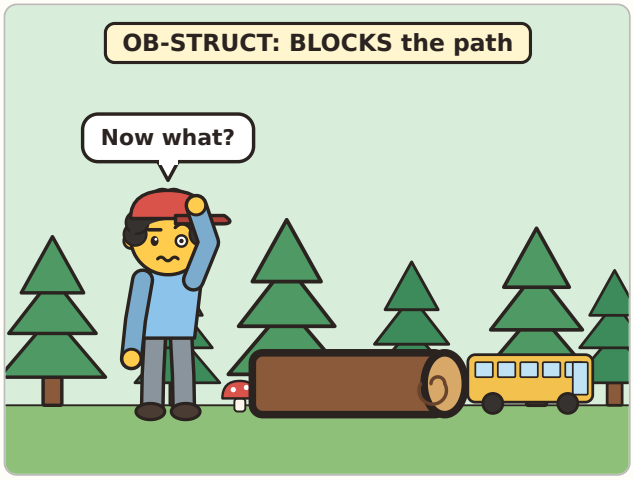
MEANING to slow or block movement or progress

MEMORY HOOK **IM-PED: FEET caught in the mud.** Pip's boots sink deep into the mud, and every step is a struggle. The mud **impedes** him: it catches his feet.

Thick mud **impeded** *the hikers at every step.*

PARTS **im** in + **ped** foot
SIMILAR hinder, slow, delay, hold up
OPPOSITE aid, speed, facilitate

obstruct ub-STRUKT *verb*



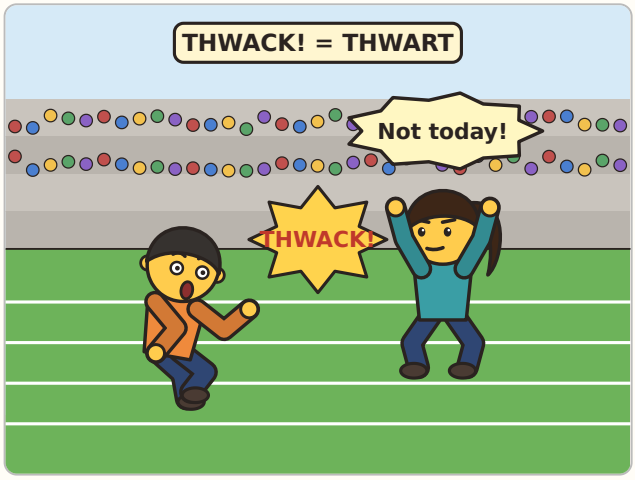
MEANING to block a path, passage or view

MEMORY HOOK **OB-STRUCT: a STRUCTURE in the way.** A huge log lies across the road like a wall, and the bus cannot get past. The log **obstructs** the road.

A fallen tree **obstructed** *the road to the lake.*

PARTS **ob** against, in the way + **struct** build, pile up
SIMILAR block, bar, clog, barricade
OPPOSITE clear, open, free

thwart THWORT *verb*



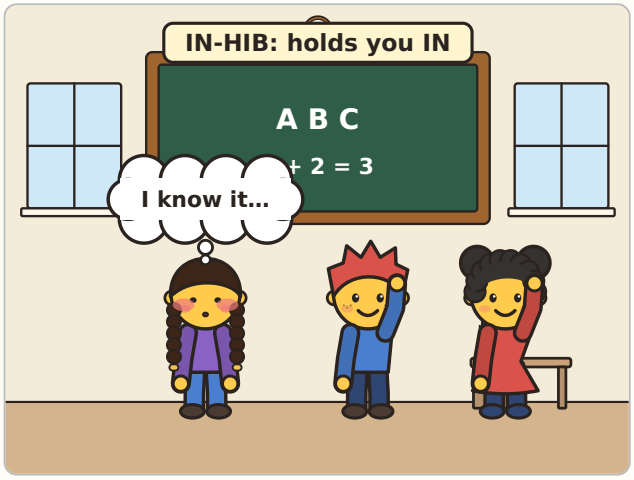
MEANING to stop someone from carrying out a plan

MEMORY HOOK **THWACK! the goalie THWARTS the shot.** Dev winds up for the winning goal, but Maya leaps and thwacks the ball away. She **thwarts** his plan.

The goalie **thwarted** *every shot in the second half.*

SIMILAR foil, frustrate, defeat, stop
OPPOSITE help, assist, enable

inhibit in-**HIB**-it *verb*



MEANING to hold back or restrain

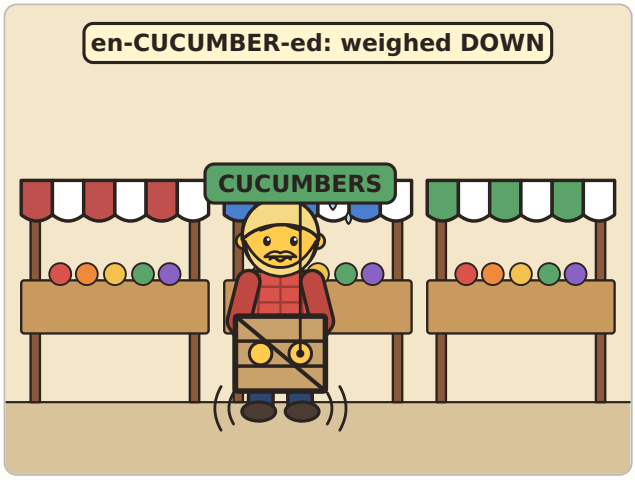
MEMORY HOOK **IN-HIB: shyness HOLDS her IN.** Lila knows the answer, but shyness holds her in, and her hand stays down. Shyness **inhibits** her.

Shyness **inhibited** *Lila from raising her hand, though she knew the answer.*

PARTS **in** in + **hib** hold (from Latin habere)

SIMILAR restrain, suppress, curb, discourage
OPPOSITE encourage, allow, promote

encumber en-**KUM**-ber *verb*



MEANING to weigh down with a burden

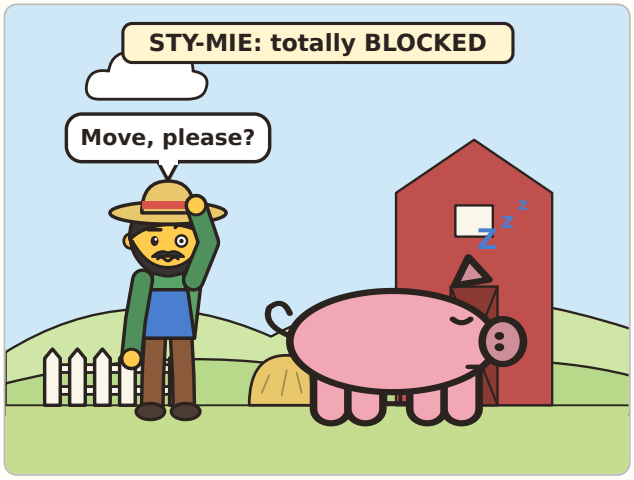
MEMORY HOOK **en-CUCUMBER-ed: weighed down.** Sven staggers home with a giant crate of a hundred cucumbers in his arms. He is **encumbered**: so weighed down he can barely move.

The hikers were **encumbered** *by tents, pots and three days of food.*

PARTS **en** in, into + **cumber** hindrance, heavy load

SIMILAR burden, weigh down, saddle, load
OPPOSITE free, relieve, unburden

stymie **STY**-mee *verb*



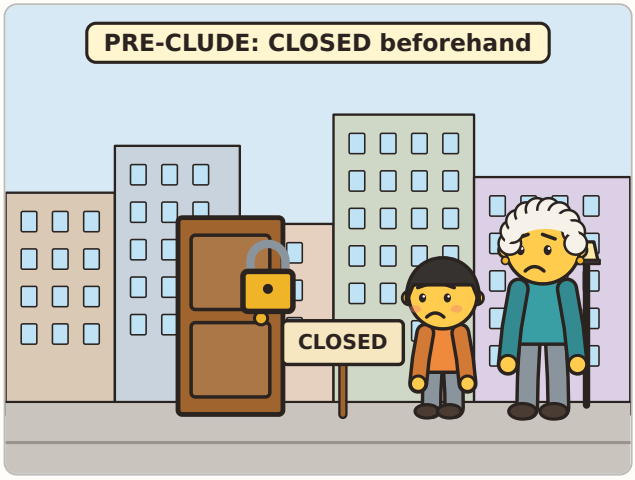
MEANING to block completely; to leave stuck or stumped

MEMORY HOOK **STY-MIE: the pig blocks the STY.** The giant pig flops across the gate of its sty, and no matter what Farmer Omar tries, he cannot get in. He is **stymied**.

The last riddle in the book **stymied** *the whole family.*

SIMILAR foil, stump, frustrate, stall
OPPOSITE help, enable, aid

preclude prih-**KLOOD** *verb*



MEANING to make impossible in advance; to rule out

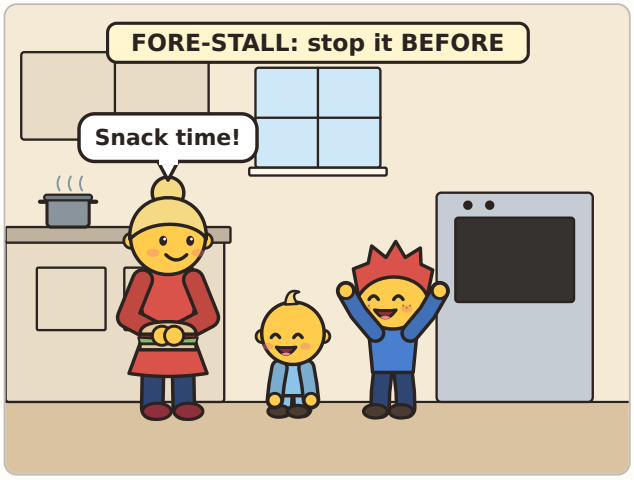
MEMORY HOOK **PRE-CLUDE: CLOSED beforehand.** The museum door was locked before anyone arrived, so no one could get in at all. The locked door **precluded** any visit.

The locked gate **precluded** *any visit to the garden.*

PARTS **pre** before + **clud** shut, close

SIMILAR rule out, prevent, prohibit, eliminate
OPPOSITE allow, permit, enable

forestall for-**STAWL** *verb*



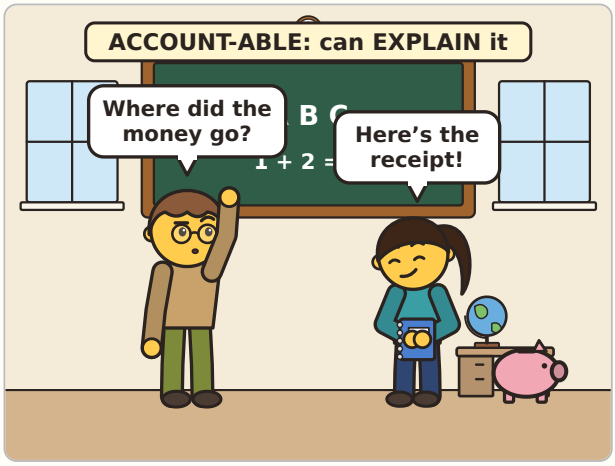
MEANING to prevent something by acting first

MEMORY HOOK **FORE-STALL: stop it BEFORE it starts.** Just before the kids get hungry and cranky, Mom hands out sandwiches. She **forestalls** the meltdown.

Mom **forestalled** *a meltdown by handing out snacks before the kids got hungry.*

SIMILAR prevent, head off, avert, preempt
OPPOSITE invite, allow

accountable uh-**KOWN**-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING responsible for your actions and expected to explain them

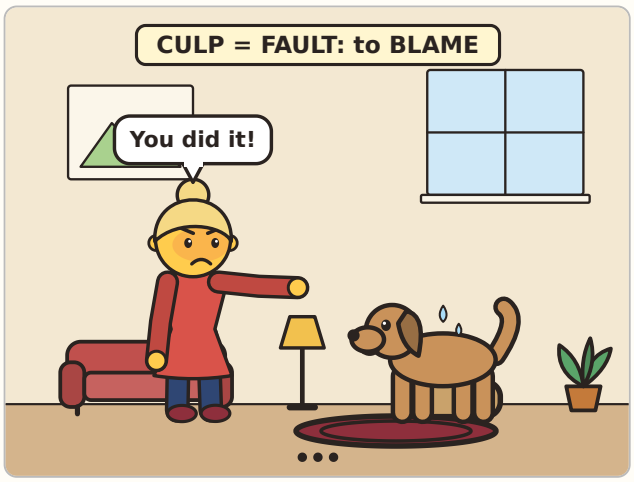
MEMORY HOOK **ACCOUNT-ABLE: able to give an ACCOUNT.** Maya, the class treasurer, can show where every dollar of the trip money went, down to the last receipt. She is **accountable**.

As class treasurer, Maya was **accountable** *for every dollar of the trip fund.*

PARTS **account** a report, an explanation + **-able** able to, liable to

SIMILAR responsible, answerable, liable
OPPOSITE unaccountable, exempt

culpable **KUL**-puh-bul *adjective*



MEANING deserving blame

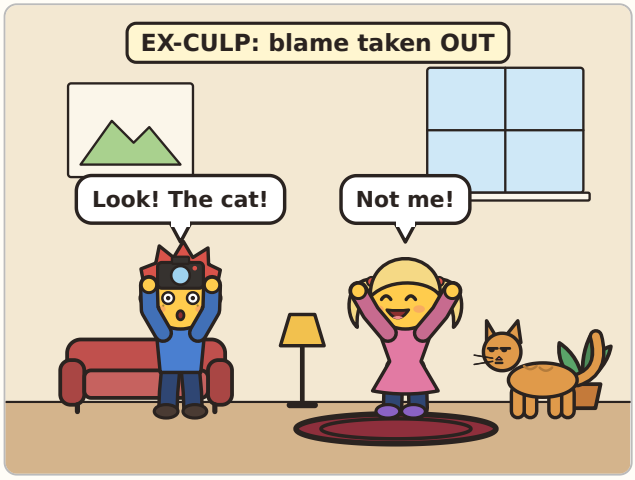
MEMORY HOOK **CULP-able: the CULPRIT is to blame.** Muddy paw prints lead straight from the kitchen to the dog's bed. The dog is the culprit: he is **culpable**.

The muddy paw prints showed that the dog was **culpable**.

PARTS **culp** fault, blame + **-able** deserving to be

SIMILAR blameworthy, guilty, at fault, responsible
OPPOSITE innocent, blameless, guiltless

exculpate EK-skul-payt *verb*



MEANING to show that someone is not guilty

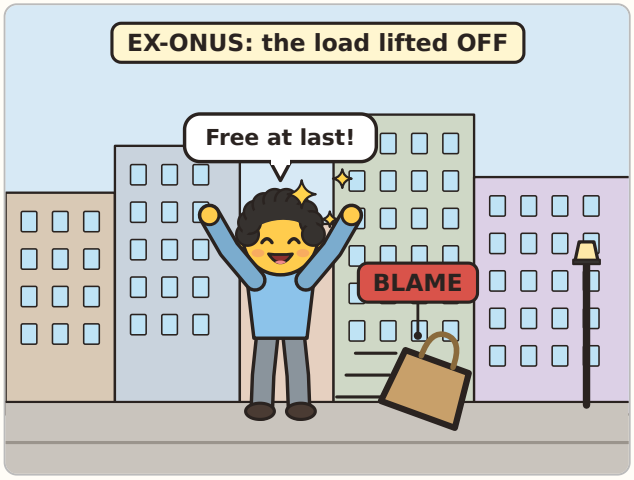
MEMORY HOOK **EX-CULP: blame taken OUT.** The camera shows the cat, not Ivy, knocking over the vase. The video takes the blame right out of Ivy's hands: it **exculpates** her.

The video from the hallway camera **exculpated** *Ivy: it showed the cat knocking over the vase.*

PARTS **ex** out, away from + **culp** fault, blame + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR clear, exonerate, vindicate, acquit
OPPOSITE incriminate, accuse, blame

exonerate ig-ZON-uh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to clear completely of blame

MEMORY HOOK **EX-ONUS: the load of blame lifted OFF.** When the real thief is caught, the heavy sack of blame falls off Jamal's shoulders. He is **exonerated**.

When the real thief confessed, the police **exonerated** *the gardener.*

PARTS **ex** out, off + **oner** burden (Latin onus) + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR clear, acquit, absolve, vindicate
OPPOSITE convict, blame, incriminate

acquit uh-KWIT *verb*



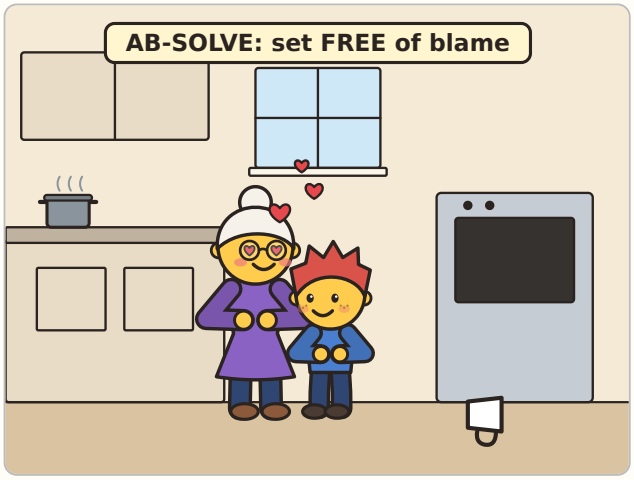
MEANING to declare someone not guilty in a court

MEMORY HOOK **AC-QUIT: you can QUIT worrying: not guilty!.** The jury foreman stands and reads, "Not guilty!" Rosa can quit worrying: the court has **acquitted** her.

The jury **acquitted** *the baker of stealing the prize-winning pie.*

SIMILAR clear, free, discharge, exonerate
OPPOSITE convict, condemn

absolve ub-ZOLV *verb*



MEANING to free someone from guilt, blame or a duty

MEMORY HOOK **AB-SOLVE: SOLVED and set free.** Pip breaks Grandma's teacup and expects a scolding, but she hugs him: "Accidents happen. You're forgiven." She **absolves** him.

Grandma **absolved** *Pip of the broken teacup: "Accidents happen."*

PARTS **ab** away, from + **solve** loosen

SIMILAR forgive, pardon, clear, release
OPPOSITE blame, condemn, charge

vindicate VIN-dih-kayt *verb*



MEANING to clear from blame or doubt; to prove right

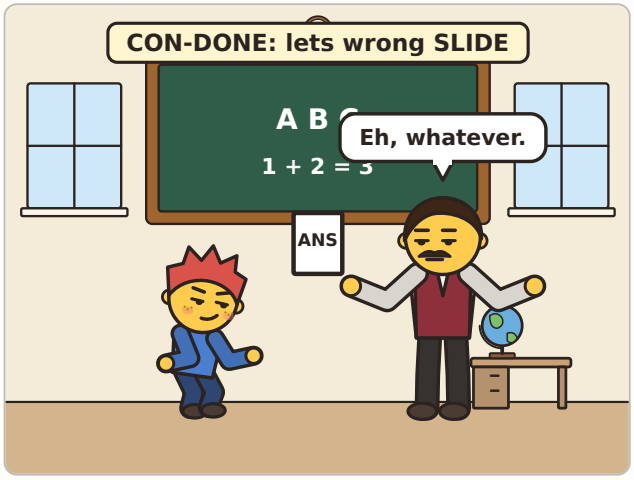
MEMORY HOOK **VIN = WIN: proved RIGHT at last.** Everyone laughed at Sami for saying the old well still had water, until it gushed. He wins: the gushing well **vindicates** him.

When the old well gushed water, Sami felt **vindicated**.

PARTS **vindic** claim, defend + **-ate** to make, to act on

SIMILAR justify, exonerate, clear, prove right
OPPOSITE discredit, incriminate, accuse

condone kun-DOHN *verb*



MEANING to accept or overlook wrongdoing

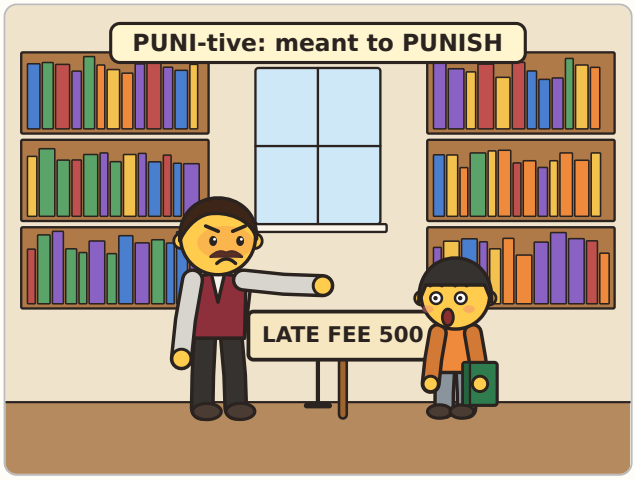
MEMORY HOOK **CON-DONE: "Eh, it's DONE all the time".** Pip peeks at the answer sheet, and the substitute just shrugs: "Eh, it's done all the time." By shrugging it off, he **condones** the cheating.

The school does not **condone** *copying homework.*

PARTS **con** thoroughly + **done** give (Latin donare)

SIMILAR overlook, excuse, tolerate, allow
OPPOSITE condemn, forbid, denounce

punitive PYOO-nih-tiv *adjective*



MEANING meant as punishment

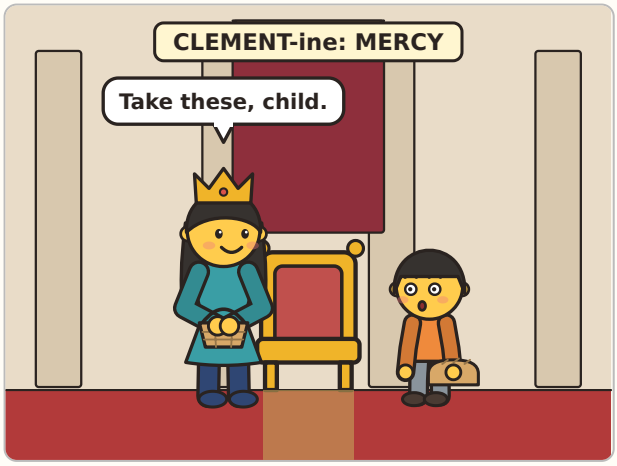
MEMORY HOOK **PUNI-tive: meant to PUNISH.** The librarian posts a sign: one late book, a five-hundred-dollar fine! A fine like that is not a reminder; it is **punitive**.

A five-hundred-dollar fine for one overdue library book would be **punitive**.

PARTS **puni** punish (Latin punire) + **-tive** tending to

SIMILAR penalizing, disciplinary, harsh, corrective
OPPOSITE rewarding, lenient, merciful

clemency KLEM-un-see *noun*



MEANING mercy, especially in punishing someone

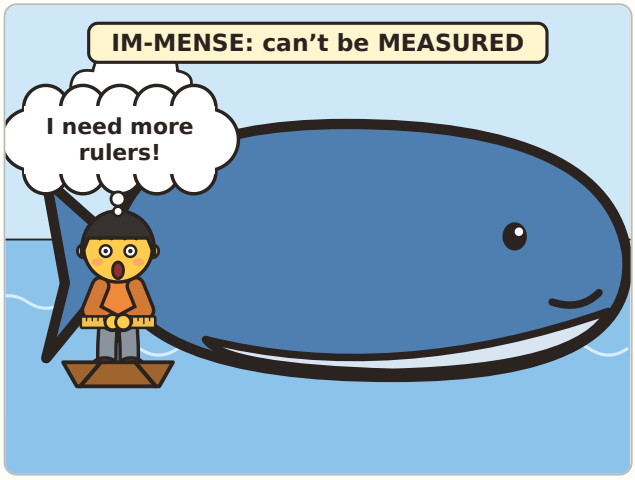
MEMORY HOOK **CLEMENTINE CLEMENCY: mercy, served sweet.** Instead of punishing the hungry boy who took a loaf of bread, the queen hands him a basket of clementines. She shows **clemency**.

The queen showed **clemency** *to the hungry boy who had taken a loaf of bread.*

PARTS **clem** mild, merciful (Latin clemens) + **-ency** the state or quality of

SIMILAR mercy, leniency, pardon, compassion
OPPOSITE severity, harshness, cruelty

immense ih-**MENS** *adjective*



MEANING extremely large or great

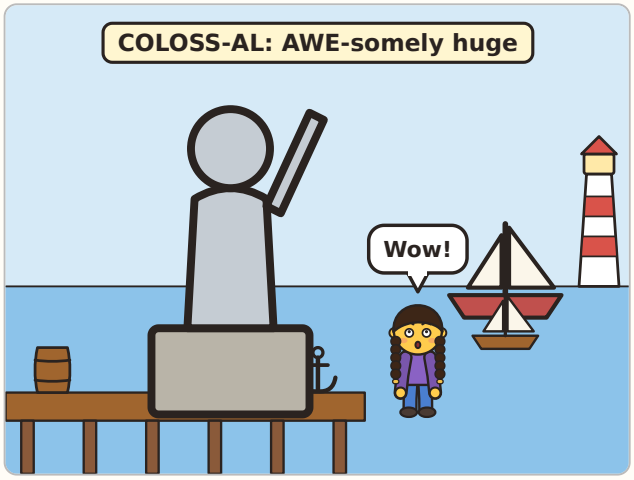
MEMORY HOOK **IM-MENSE: too big to MEASURE.** Kai tries to measure the whale with his little ruler and gives up after the tail. It is **immense**: too big to measure.

The blue whale is an **immense** *animal, longer than two school buses.*

PARTS **im-** not + **mense** measured

SIMILAR huge, enormous, vast, gigantic
OPPOSITE tiny, minute, minuscule

colossal kuh-**LOS**-ul *adjective*



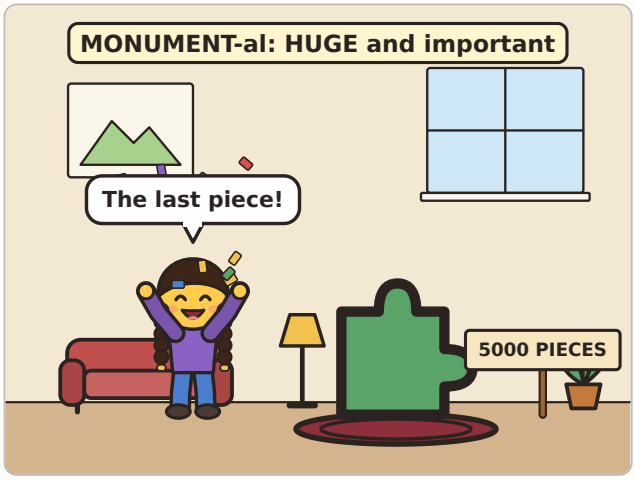
MEANING enormous; huge enough to fill you with awe

MEMORY HOOK **COLOSSUS: a statue so big it awes.** The giant statue at the harbor is so tall that the sailing ships look like toys at its feet. It is **colossal**.

A **colossal** *statue towered over the harbor, dwarfing the ships below.*

SIMILAR huge, enormous, gigantic, vast
OPPOSITE tiny, minuscule, diminutive

monumental mon-yuh-**MEN**-tul *adjective*



MEANING very great in size or importance

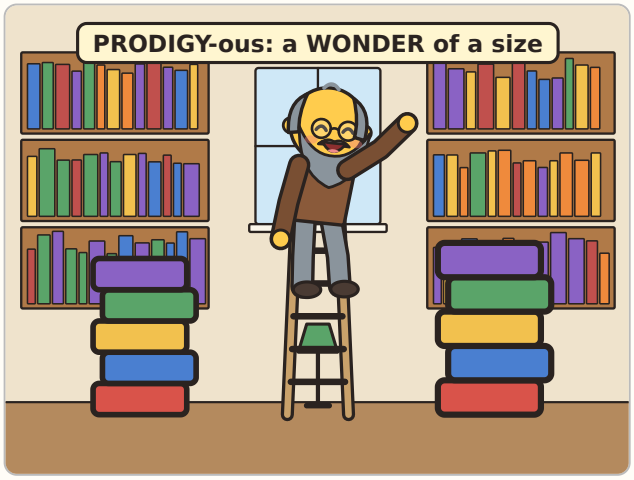
MEMORY HOOK **MONUMENT-al: as big as a MONUMENT.** After a whole summer, Lila fits the last of five thousand puzzle pieces into place. Finishing it was a **monumental** task.

Finishing the five-thousand-piece puzzle was a **monumental** *task.*

PARTS **mon** remind (Latin monere) + **-ment** a means or result (a noun ending) + **-al** having to do with

SIMILAR huge, enormous, vast, historic
OPPOSITE tiny, insignificant, trivial

prodigious pruh-**DIJ**-us *adjective*



MEANING remarkably large or impressive

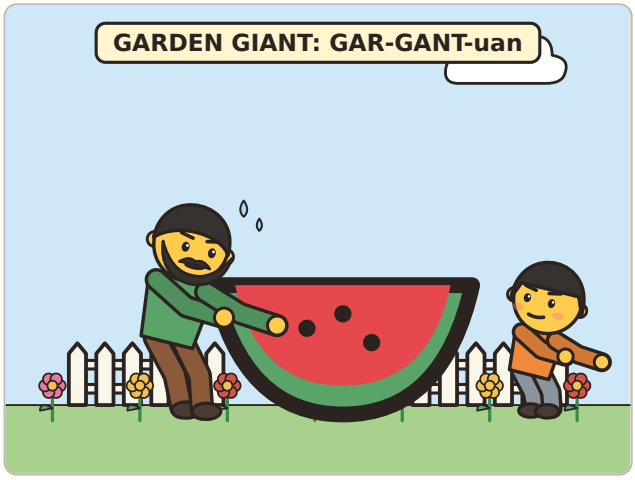
MEMORY HOOK **PRODIGY-ous: a wonder of a size.** Professor Edwin's books are stacked from the floor to the ceiling, so he needs a ladder to reach the top. His library is **prodigious**.

Professor Edwin owns a **prodigious** *library, with books stacked to the ceiling.*

PARTS **prodigi** a wonder (Latin prodigium) + **-ous** full of

SIMILAR huge, enormous, vast, remarkable
OPPOSITE tiny, ordinary, unremarkable

gargantuan gar-**GAN**-choo-un *adjective*



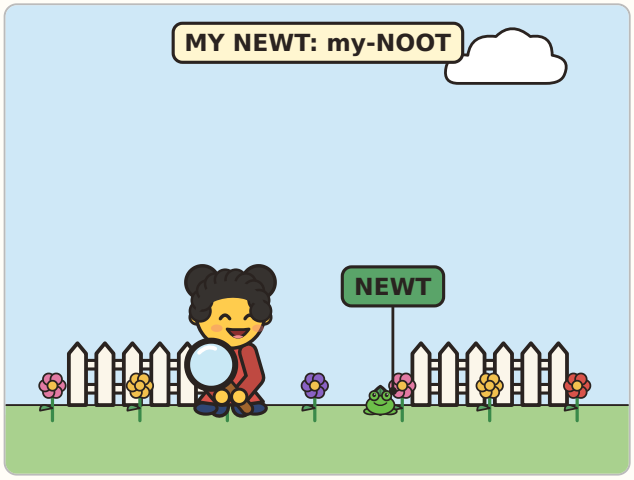
MEANING enormous, especially in bulk or appetite

MEMORY HOOK **GAR-GANT: a GARDEN GIANT.** Omar grows a watermelon so big that the whole family has to push to roll it out of the garden. It is **gargantuan**.

Omar grew a **gargantuan** *watermelon that took four people to lift.*

SIMILAR huge, enormous, gigantic, vast
OPPOSITE tiny, minute, minuscule

minute my-**NOOT** *adjective*



MEANING extremely small; also, very detailed

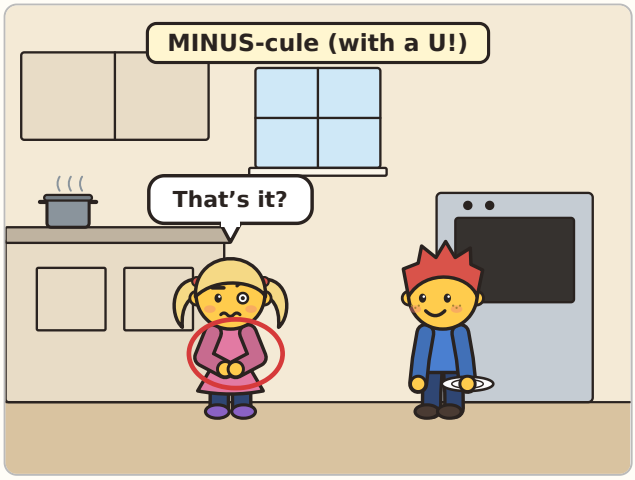
MEMORY HOOK **MY NEWT is my-NOOT.** Zoe's pet newt is so tiny it fits on a fingertip; she needs a magnifying glass to see its toes. Her newt is **minute**.

A **minute** *speck of dust jammed the old watch.*

PARTS **minut** made small (Latin minutus)

SIMILAR tiny, microscopic, teeny, wee
OPPOSITE huge, enormous, immense

minuscule **MIN**-uh-skyool *adjective*



MEANING extremely small

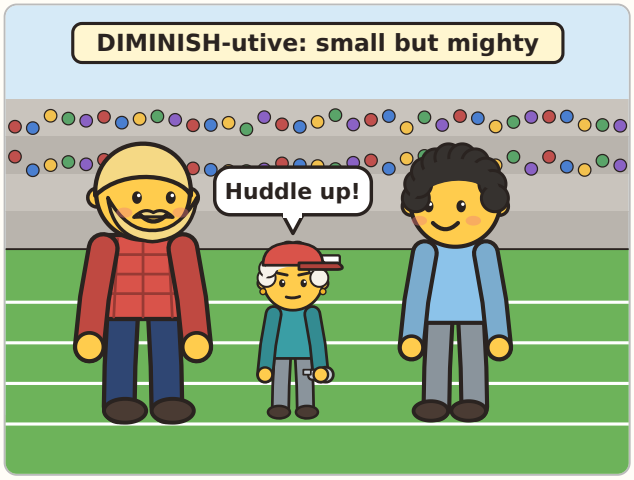
MEMORY HOOK **MINUS-cule: so small it's almost a MINUS.** The last cookie is shared with eight friends, and Ivy squints at her share: one crumb. It is **minuscule**.

Split among ten friends, the last cookie became ten **minuscule** *crumbs.*

PARTS **minus** less + **-cule** little (a Latin ending)

SIMILAR tiny, microscopic, teeny, wee
OPPOSITE huge, enormous, gigantic

diminutive dih-**MIN**-yuh-tiv *adjective*



MEANING very small, especially in height

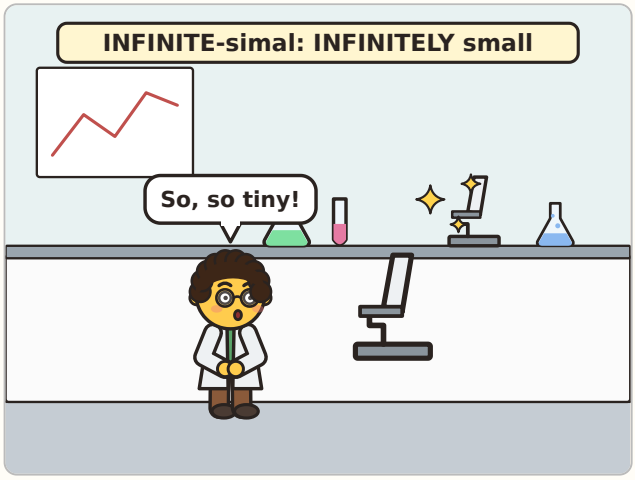
MEMORY HOOK **DIMINISH-utive: small and slight.** Nana Lou, barely five feet tall, coaches a team of giants, and they all listen when she blows her whistle. She is **diminutive** but mighty.

The **diminutive** *coach barely reached her players' shoulders, but they hung on her every word.*

PARTS **minu** make smaller (Latin minuere) + **-tive** tending to

SIMILAR tiny, teeny, wee, petite
OPPOSITE huge, gigantic, colossal

infinitesimal in-fin-ih-**TES**-ih-mul *adjective*



MEANING too small to measure

MEMORY HOOK **INFINITE-simal: INFINITELY small.** Sami peers into the microscope at creatures so small that no ruler could ever measure them. They are **infinitesimal**.

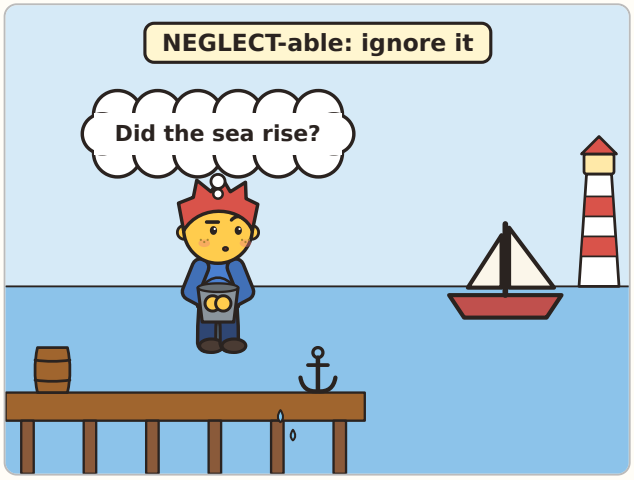
Under the microscope, Sami found **infinitesimal** *creatures swimming in a drop of pond water.*

PARTS **in-** not + **finit** limit, end

SIMILAR tiny, microscopic, teeny, imperceptible

OPPOSITE huge, immense, vast

negligible **NEG**-lih-juh-bul *adjective*



MEANING so small or unimportant it can be ignored

MEMORY HOOK **NEGLECT-able: small enough to NEGLECT.** Pip pours one bucket of water into the ocean and checks whether the sea has risen. The difference is **negligible**: small enough to ignore.

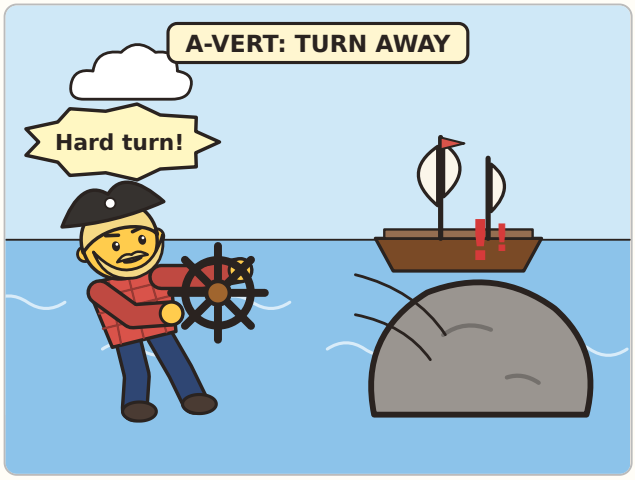
Pouring one cup of water into the ocean has a **negligible** *effect on its level.*

PARTS **neglig** neglect, disregard + **-ible** able to be

SIMILAR insignificant, trivial, slight, tiny

OPPOSITE significant, considerable, substantial

avert uh-**VURT** *verb*



MEANING to turn away; to keep something bad from happening

MEMORY HOOK **A-VERT: TURN AWAY from trouble.** Captain Sven sees the rock ahead and turns the wheel hard; by turning away in time, he **averts** a crash.

Pip **averted** *his eyes so he would not spoil the surprise in the gift bag.*

PARTS **a-** away (a form of ab-) + **vert** turn

SIMILAR prevent, ward off, avoid, turn away

OPPOSITE cause, invite

adverse ad-**VURS** *adjective*



MEANING harmful or unfavorable; working against you

MEMORY HOOK **AD-VERSE: the wind TURNS against you.** Ivy runs east with her kite, but the wind turns and blows hard the other way; **adverse** winds work against her.

The soccer final was put off a week because of **adverse** *weather: hail, lightning and high winds.*

PARTS **ad-** to, toward + **vers** turn

SIMILAR unfavorable, harmful, hostile, damaging

OPPOSITE favorable, beneficial, helpful

versatile VUR-suh-tul *adjective*



MEANING able to do many different things, or to be used in many ways

MEMORY HOOK **VERSE-atile: sings VERSES, plays it all.** Tia sings the verses, strums the guitar, beats the drum and plays the fiddle, turning easily from one to the next: she is **versatile**.

A **versatile** *player, Rosa can pitch, catch and cover first base.*

PARTS **vers** turn

SIMILAR adaptable, all-around, flexible, many-sided
OPPOSITE limited, narrow

inadvertent in-ud-VUR-tunt *adjective*



MEANING done by accident, without meaning to

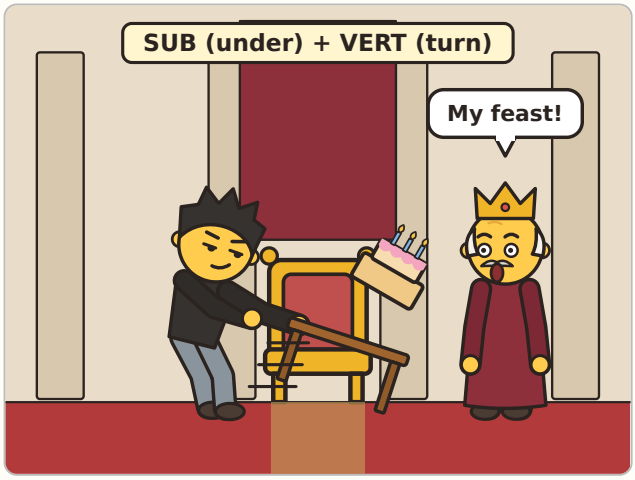
MEMORY HOOK **eyes IN the AD: a bump not meant.** Sami's eyes are on the ad on the sign, not on the path, so he bumps a fruit cart. The bump is **inadvertent**: he did not mean it.

One **inadvertent** *tap on the screen sent Grandpa's message to the whole family instead of just to Nana Lou.*

PARTS **in-** not + **ad-** to, toward + **vert** turn

SIMILAR accidental, unintentional, unplanned, unwitting
OPPOSITE deliberate, intentional, planned

subvert sub-VURT *verb*



MEANING to secretly weaken or overturn something established

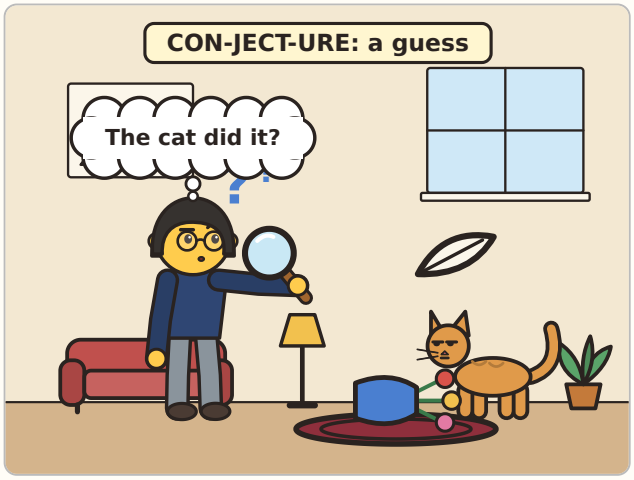
MEMORY HOOK **SUB-VERT: overturn it from BELOW.** Sneaky Rex crawls under the king's banquet table and tips it over from beneath. To **subvert** is to overturn from underneath.

The sneaky player tried to **subvert** *the rules by changing the score sheet when no one was looking.*

PARTS **sub-** under, from below + **vert** turn

SIMILAR undermine, overthrow, sabotage, weaken
OPPOSITE support, uphold, strengthen

conjecture kun-JEK-cher *noun*



MEANING a guess made without enough proof

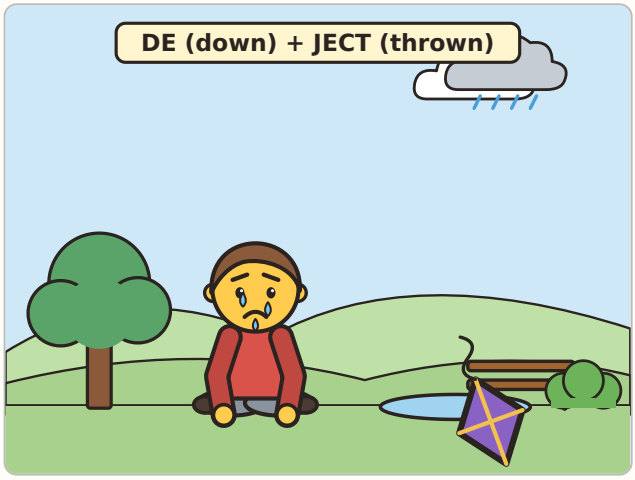
MEMORY HOOK **CON-JECT: THROW the clues TOGETHER.** Ada throws three clues together, a tipped vase, a paw print and a feather, and makes a guess: the cat chased a bird! Her **conjecture** may be wrong.

Whether the old map leads to anything at all is pure **conjecture**.

PARTS **con-** together + **ject** throw

SIMILAR guess, speculation, hunch, surmise
OPPOSITE fact, proof, certainty

dejected dih-**JEK**-tid *adjective*



MEANING sad and discouraged; low in spirits

MEMORY HOOK **DE-JECT-ed: THROWN DOWN.** The wind throws Jonah's new kite down into the mud, and his spirits fall with it: he sits slumped and **dejected**.

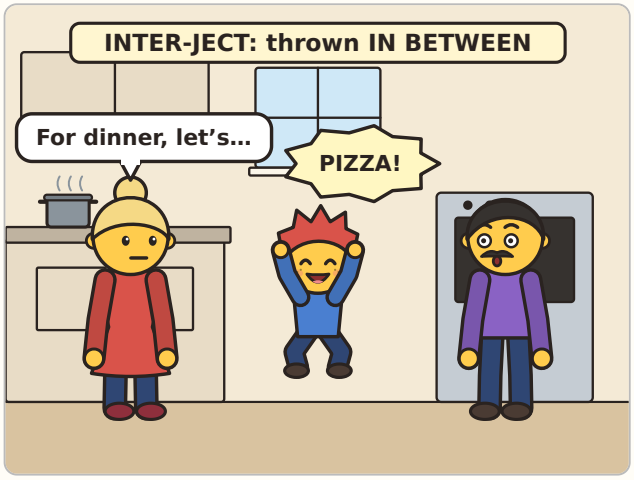
After missing the bus to the big game, Kai sat on the curb looking **dejected**.

PARTS **de-** down + **ject** throw

SIMILAR downcast, discouraged, dispirited, glum

OPPOSITE elated, cheerful, upbeat

interject in-ter-**JEKT** *verb*



MEANING to break in with a remark while someone else is talking

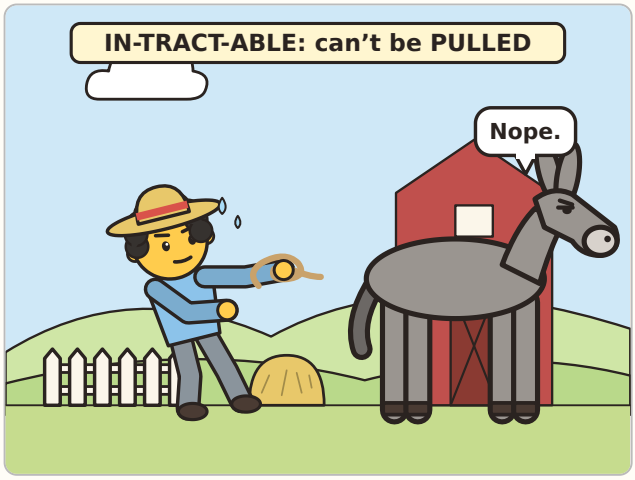
MEMORY HOOK **INTER-JECT: THROW words IN BETWEEN.** Mom and Dad are talking about dinner when Pip throws one word in between them: "Pizza!" He **interjects**.

Grandpa Gus likes to **interject** *a joke in the middle of every story.*

PARTS **inter-** between + **ject** throw

SIMILAR interrupt, cut in, break in, chime in

intractable in-**TRAK**-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING hard to manage, control or solve

MEMORY HOOK **IN-TRACT-ABLE: NOT PULL-ABLE.** Jamal pulls and pulls on the rope, but the donkey won't move an inch. He can't pull it or manage it: the donkey is **intractable**.

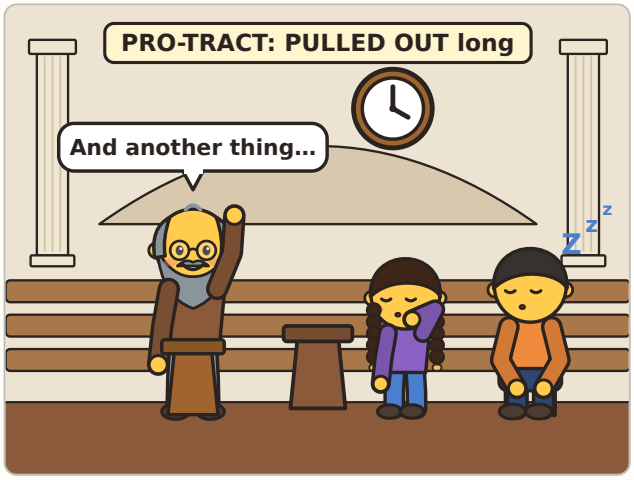
The **intractable** *goat refused to leave the porch, no matter how hard we pulled.*

PARTS **in-** not + **tract** pull, draw + **-able** able to be

SIMILAR unmanageable, unruly, uncontrollable, difficult

OPPOSITE manageable, tractable, obedient

protracted proh-**TRAK**-tid *adjective*



MEANING lasting much longer than expected or usual

MEMORY HOOK **PRO-TRACT-ed: PULLED OUT long.** Professor Edwin's "short" talk gets pulled out longer and longer, until his audience nods off. It is a **protracted** talk.

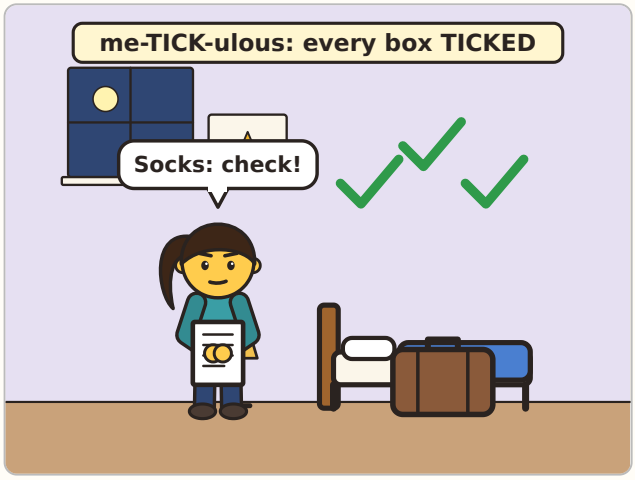
After a **protracted** *search, Nana Lou found her glasses on top of her head.*

PARTS **pro-** forward, out + **tract** pull, draw

SIMILAR prolonged, lengthy, drawn-out, extended

OPPOSITE brief, short, quick

meticulous muh-**TIK**-yuh-lus *adjective*



MEANING very careful about every small detail

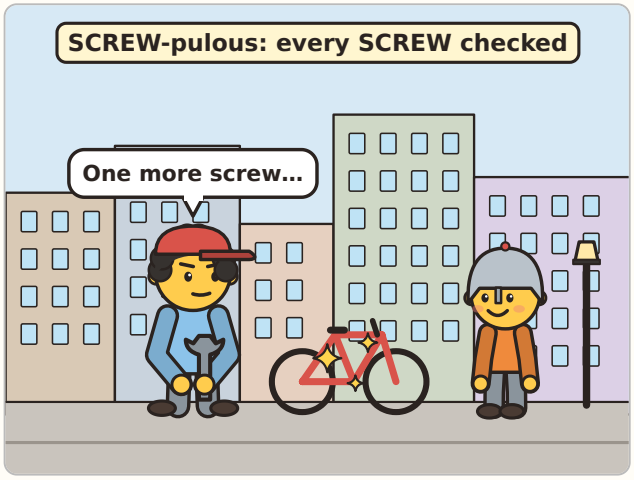
MEMORY HOOK **me-TICK-ulous: every box gets a TICK.** Maya puts a tick next to every item on her packing list, then checks each one twice: she is **meticulous**.

Lila keeps a **meticulous** *record of every bird she sees, with the date, the time and the weather.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR painstaking, thorough, precise, careful
OPPOSITE careless, sloppy, slapdash

scrupulous **SKROO**-pyuh-lus *adjective*



MEANING very careful to do what is right, or to get every detail exact

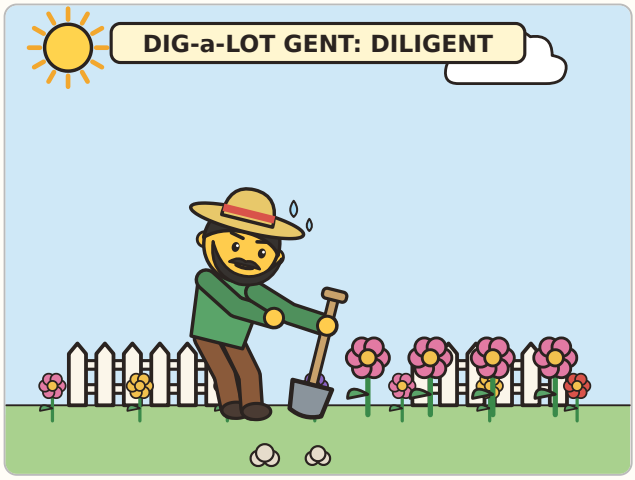
MEMORY HOOK **SCREW-pulous: every SCREW just right.** Jamal checks every single screw on Kai's bike, twice, before he says it is safe to ride: he is **scrupulous**.

The **scrupulous** *cashier ran after a customer to give back a dime of extra change.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR conscientious, principled, honest, painstaking
OPPOSITE unscrupulous, dishonest, careless

diligent **DIL**-uh-junt *adjective*



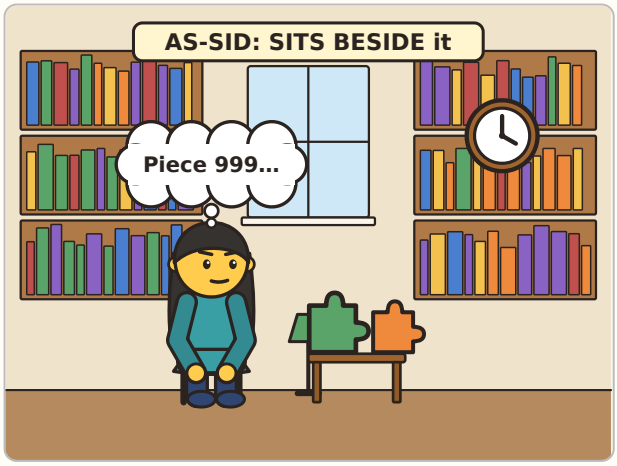
MEANING working hard and steadily, with care

MEMORY HOOK **DIG-a-LOT GENT.** Omar digs and plants all day, row after row, rain or shine. The hardworking gent is **diligent**.

A **diligent** *student, Sami reviews his notes every night, not just the night before a test.*

SIMILAR hardworking, industrious, conscientious, thorough
OPPOSITE lazy, idle, negligent

assiduous uh-**SIJ**-oo-us *adjective*



MEANING giving steady, careful attention to a task without letting up

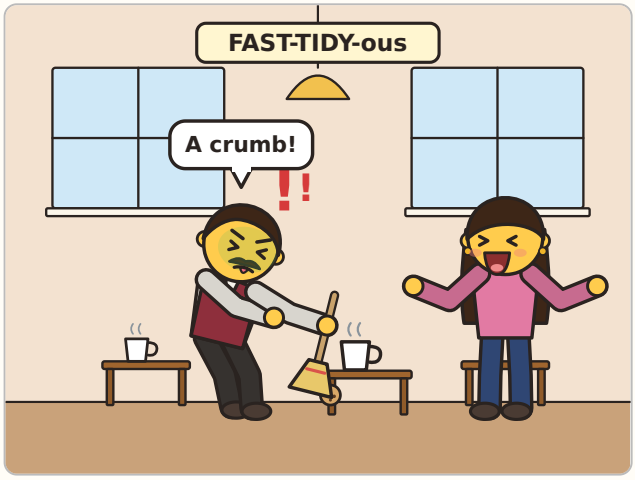
MEMORY HOOK **AS-SID-uous: SITS BESIDE the task.** Lin sits beside her thousand-piece puzzle hour after hour, fitting piece after piece, and never leaves her seat. Her work is **assiduous**.

Thanks to **assiduous** *practice, Rosa finally played the whole piece without a single mistake.*

PARTS **as-** to, near (a form of ad-) + **sid** sit + **-uous** full of, having

SIMILAR diligent, tireless, persevering, industrious
OPPOSITE lazy, negligent, halfhearted

fastidious fa-**STID**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING very fussy about details, neatness or cleanliness; hard to please

MEMORY HOOK **FAST-TIDY-ous: tidies FAST and often.** Victor tidies fast and often: one crumb on the café table, and out comes the broom. He is **fastidious**.

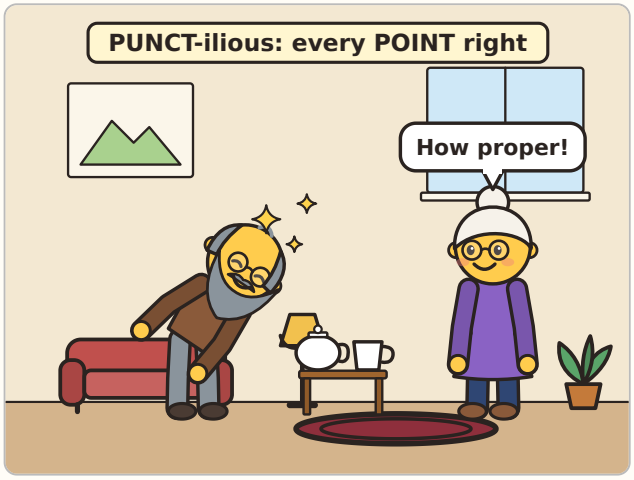
The **fastidious** *cat refused to eat from a bowl with a single crumb in it.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR fussy, finicky, particular, meticulous

OPPOSITE sloppy, slovenly, careless

punctilious punk-**TIL**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING very careful to follow the exact rules of proper behavior

MEMORY HOOK **PUNCT: every POINT of manners.** Professor Edwin bows just so, pours the tea just so and sets each spoon just so: every small point of manners is right. He is **punctilious**.

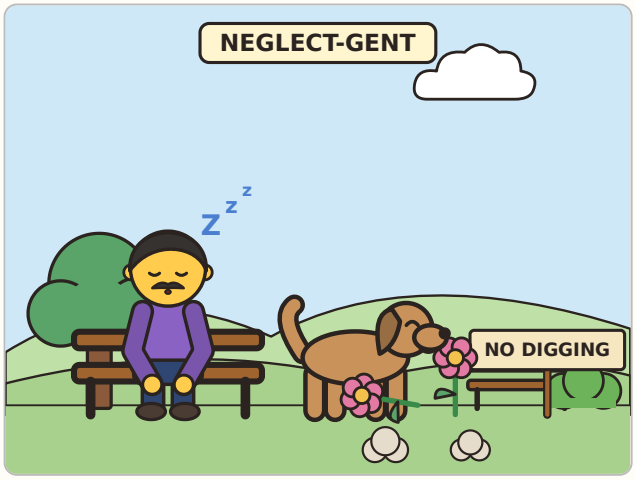
The **punctilious** *host greeted every guest by name and seated each one by the place card.*

PARTS **punct** point + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR proper, exact, formal, scrupulous

OPPOSITE casual, careless, lax

negligent **NEG**-lih-junt *adjective*



MEANING failing to take the care you should

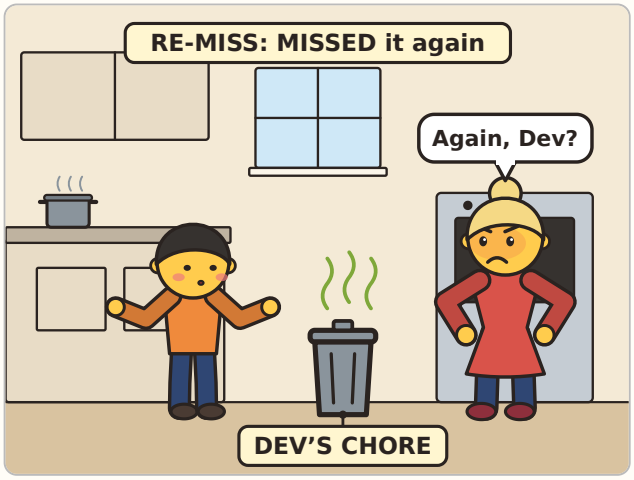
MEMORY HOOK **NEGLECT-GENT.** The gent dozes on the park bench while his dog digs up the flower bed: he neglects the dog he should be watching. He is **negligent**.

The **negligent** *landlord ignored the broken stair for months.*

SIMILAR careless, neglectful, lax, remiss

OPPOSITE careful, attentive, diligent

remiss rih-**MIS** *adjective*



MEANING careless about a duty; failing to do what you should

MEMORY HOOK **RE-MISS: MISSED his chore AGAIN.** Taking out the trash is Dev's job, but he missed it Monday and missed it again Tuesday. He has been **remiss**.

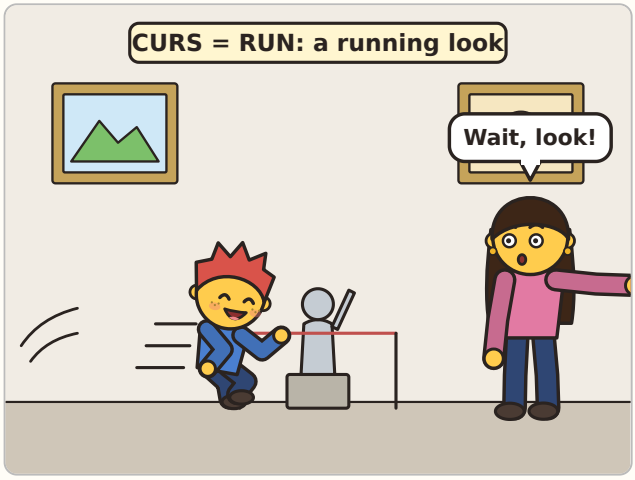
I would be **remiss** *if I didn't thank the volunteers who set up all the chairs.*

PARTS **re-** back + **miss** send, let go

SIMILAR neglectful, negligent, lax, careless

OPPOSITE careful, attentive, diligent

cursory KUR-suh-ree *adjective*



MEANING quick and not thorough; done in a hurry

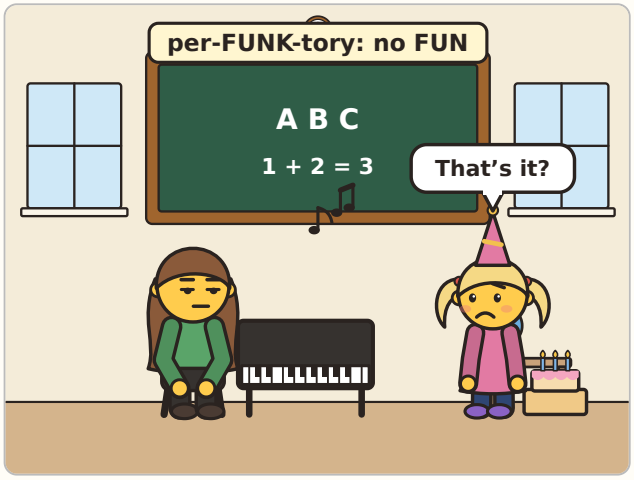
MEMORY HOOK **CURS = RUN: a RUNNING look.** Pip runs past every painting in the museum, giving each one half a second: his look is **cursory**.

*A **cursory** glance at the menu told Kai there was no pizza.*

PARTS **curs** run

SIMILAR hasty, hurried, quick, superficial
OPPOSITE thorough, careful, detailed

perfunctory per-FUNK-tuh-ree *adjective*



MEANING done only as a routine, with little care or interest

MEMORY HOOK **per-FUNK-tory: no FUN, just get THROUGH it.** Rosa plays "Happy Birthday" with a blank face, no fun and no feeling, only to get through it. Her playing is **perfunctory**.

*Jonah gave his aunt a **perfunctory** wave without looking up from his book.*

PARTS **per-** through + **funct** perform

SIMILAR halfhearted, routine, mechanical, superficial
OPPOSITE wholehearted, thorough, careful

authentic aw-**THEN**-tik *adjective*



MEANING real and not a copy; true to where it came from

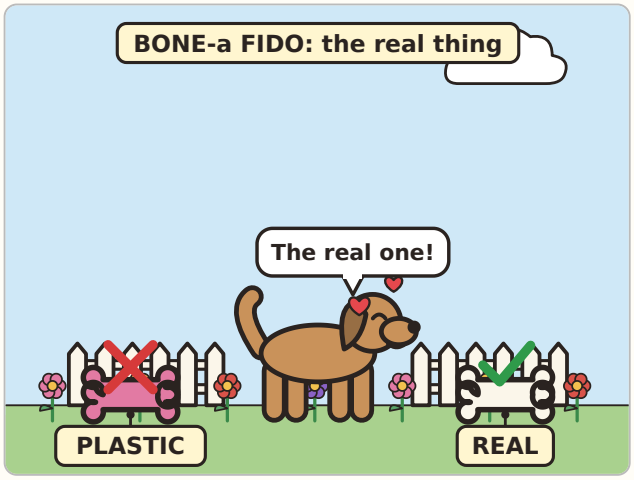
MEMORY HOOK **AUTH-entic: from the real AUTHOR.** Nell's book is signed by the author himself, right at the bookstore table: a real signature from the real writer. It is **authentic**.

*The museum made sure the old letter was **authentic** before putting it on display.*

PARTS **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR genuine, real, true, bona fide
OPPOSITE fake, false, phony

bona fide BOH-nuh FIDE *adjective*



MEANING real; also, made or done in good faith, with no trickery

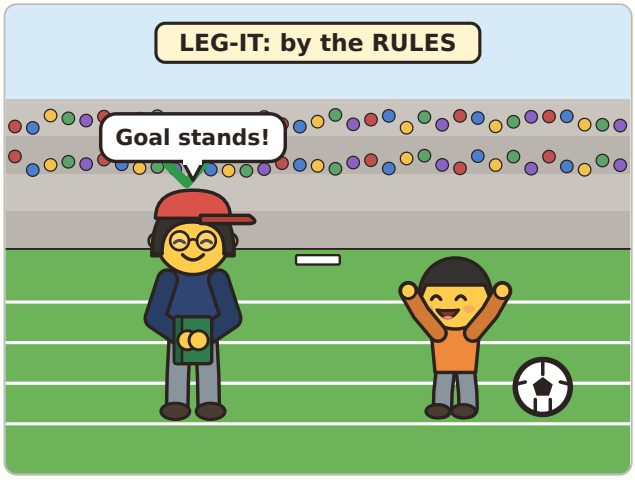
MEMORY HOOK **BONE-a FIDO: a REAL bone.** Fido sniffs the two bones: one is plastic, but the other is the real thing, a **bona fide** bone!

*After years of lessons, Theo's big sister is now a **bona fide** pilot.*

PARTS **bona** good + **fide** faith

SIMILAR genuine, real, true, authentic
OPPOSITE fake, false, phony

legitimate lih-**JIT**-uh-mit *adjective*



MEANING allowed by law or the rules; also, fair and reasonable

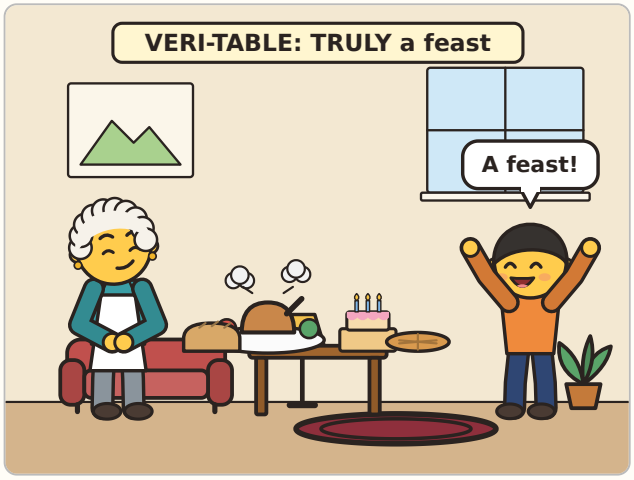
MEMORY HOOK **LEG-IT: the LEG kick was LEGAL.** The referee checks the rule book: Kai's left-leg kick broke no rule. "Legit!" The goal is **legitimate**.

Being sick is a **legitimate** *reason to miss practice.*

PARTS **leg** law

SIMILAR lawful, legal, valid, rightful
OPPOSITE illegal, unlawful, illegitimate

veritable **VAIR**-ih-tuh-bul *adjective*



MEANING truly deserving the name; used to stress that a description fits

MEMORY HOOK **VERY TABLE: TRULY a FEAST.** Nana Lou's dinner table is piled so high with food that feast is the only word for it: a **veritable** feast!

Granny Mae's garden is a **veritable** *jungle of tomatoes, beans and squash.*

PARTS **ver** true + **-able** able to be, worth being

SIMILAR genuine, real, true, absolute
OPPOSITE fake, false, phony

spurious **SPYOOR**-ee-us *adjective*



MEANING false, though made to look true or real

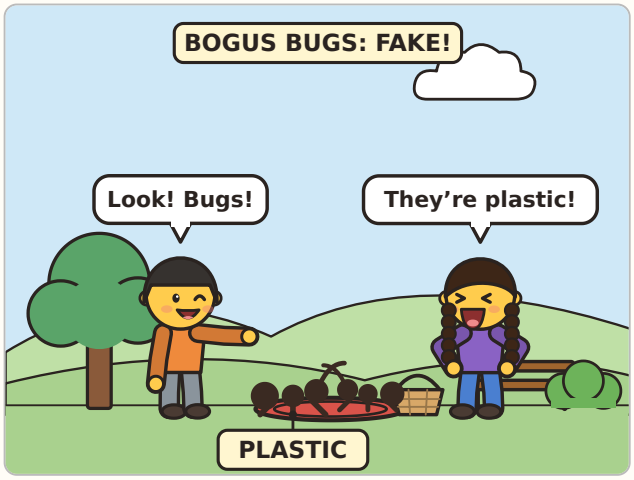
MEMORY HOOK **SPY-YOUR-ious: a SPY in a fake mustache.** The spy's mustache looks real from far away, but up close it is glued on and false. His disguise is **spurious**.

The ad made **spurious** *claims that the cream would make anyone look twenty years younger.*

PARTS **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR fake, false, phony, sham
OPPOSITE genuine, real, true

bogus **BOH**-gus *adjective*



MEANING fake; not genuine

MEMORY HOOK **BOGUS BUGS: plastic bugs!.** Kai sets plastic bugs on the picnic blanket to fool his sister. Lila laughs: the bugs are **bogus**, not real at all.

The **bogus** *ticket looked real until the usher held it up to the light.*

SIMILAR fake, false, phony, sham
OPPOSITE genuine, real, true

counterfeit KOWN-ter-fit *adjective*



MEANING made to look real in order to fool people

MEMORY HOOK **COUNTER-FEIT: FAKE money on the COUNTER.** Rex slaps shiny coins on the shop counter, but the clerk looks closely: they are painted wood! The coins are **counterfeit**.

The shopkeeper held the bill up to the light and saw that it was **counterfeit**.

PARTS **counter-** against, opposite + **feit** made

SIMILAR fake, false, phony, sham

OPPOSITE genuine, real, true

apocryphal uh-POK-ruh-ful *adjective*



MEANING widely told but probably not true

MEMORY HOOK **a POCKET-FULL of tall tales.** Grandpa Gus has a pocket full of tall tales: the fish as big as a boat, the bear he out-ran. Fun stories, but probably not true: they are **apocryphal**.

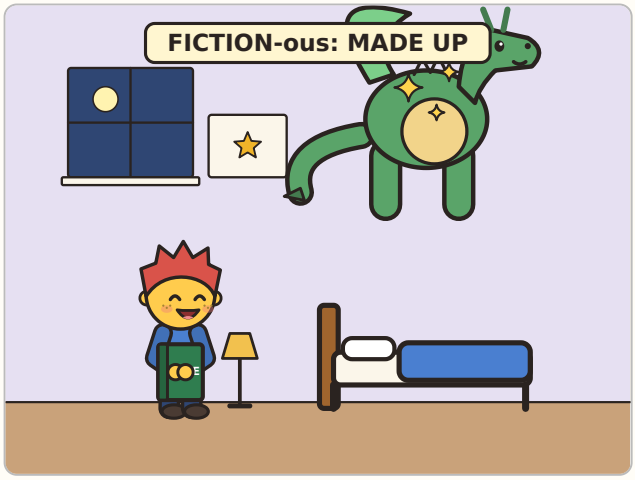
The **apocryphal** *story says the town's founder once out-ran a bear.*

PARTS **apo-** away + **cryph** hidden (as in crypt)

SIMILAR doubtful, unverified, legendary, made-up

OPPOSITE verified, documented, confirmed

fictitious fik-TISH-us *adjective*



MEANING made up; not real

MEMORY HOOK **FICTION-ous: straight out of FICTION.** A friendly dragon in Pip's storybook flies over the castle. Fun to read about, but the dragon is **fictitious**: made up.

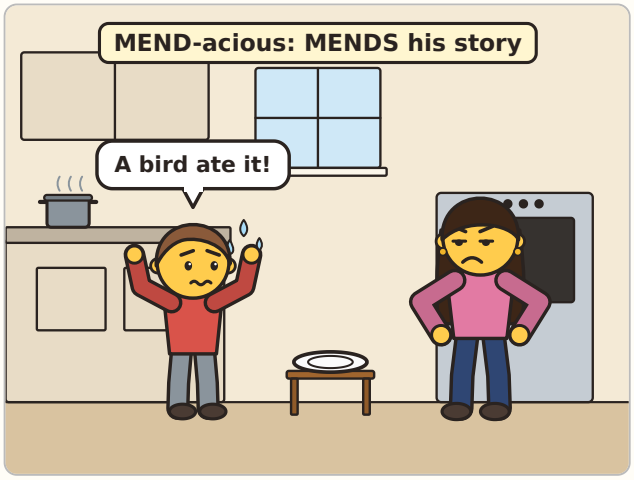
The detective in the mystery lives at a **fictitious** *address that no mail carrier could ever find.*

PARTS **fict** shaped, made up + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR imaginary, invented, made-up, false

OPPOSITE real, factual, true

mendacious men-DAY-shus *adjective*



MEANING lying; not telling the truth

MEMORY HOOK **MEND-acious: he MENDS his story with lies.** Caught beside the empty pie plate, Jonah mends his story again and again: "A dog ate it! No, a bird!" Every patch is a lie; he is **mendacious**.

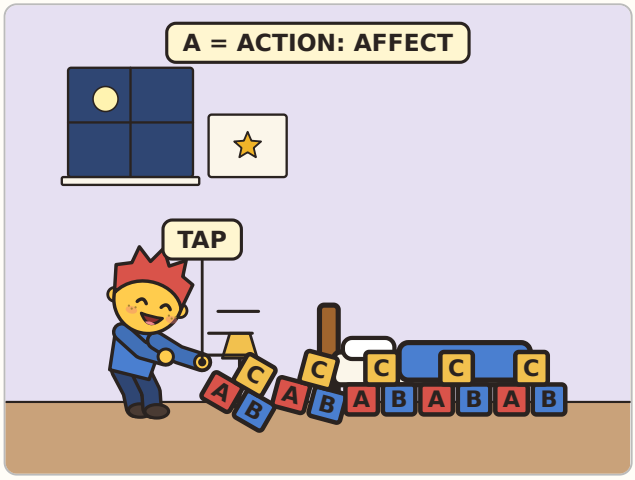
The **mendacious** *knight told the queen he had slain the dragon, though he had never left the castle.*

PARTS **mendac** lying + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR lying, dishonest, untruthful, deceitful

OPPOSITE honest, truthful, candid

affect uh-**FEKT** *verb*



MEANING to have an influence on; to change

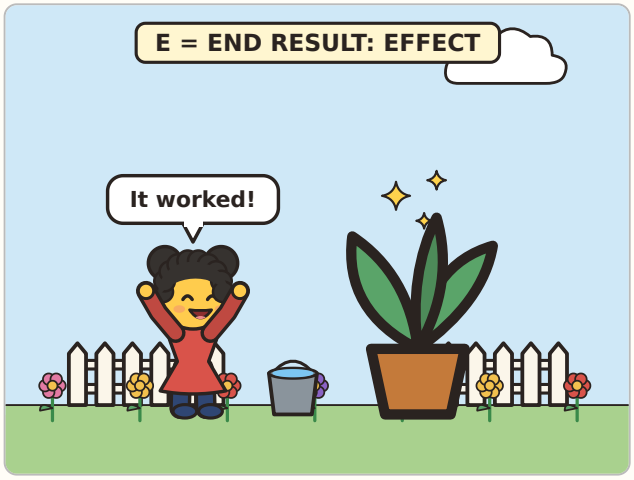
MEMORY HOOK **A is for ACTION: you AFFECT.** Pip taps the first block, and his one small action changes the whole row: his tap **affects** every block down the line.

Lack of sleep can **affect** *how well you do on a test.*

PARTS **af-** to (a form of ad-) + **fect** do, make

SIMILAR influence, change, alter, sway

effect ih-**FEKT** *noun*



MEANING a result; a change that something causes

MEMORY HOOK **E is for END: the EFFECT comes last.** Zoe waters her bean plant every day for a month. The end result, a plant taller than she is, is the **effect** of all that care.

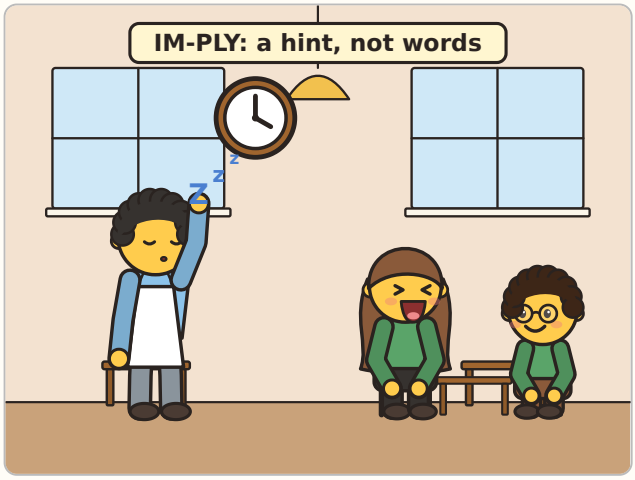
The new streetlights had a clear **effect***: far fewer people tripped on the dark corner.*

PARTS **ef-** out (a form of ex-) + **fect** do, make

SIMILAR result, outcome, consequence, impact

OPPOSITE cause

imply im-**PLY** *verb*



MEANING to suggest something without saying it directly

MEMORY HOOK **IM-PLY: the hint goes IN the message.** The café is closing. Jamal yawns and points at the clock; without a word, he **implies** that it is time for the last customers to go.

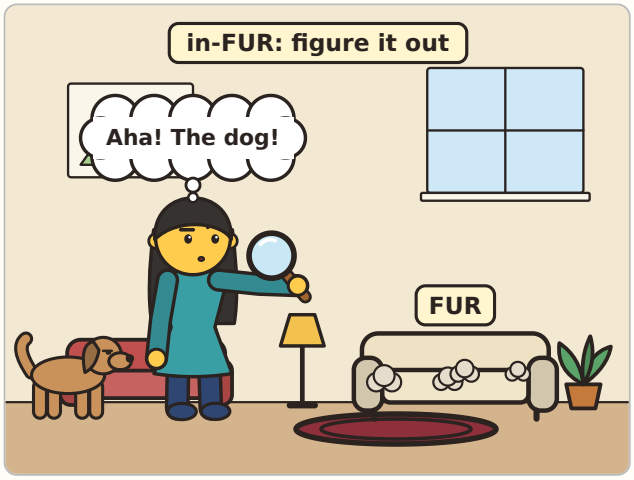
By yawning loudly through the whole movie, Kai **implied** *that it was boring.*

PARTS **im-** in (a form of in-) + **ply** fold

SIMILAR suggest, hint, insinuate, signal

OPPOSITE state, declare

infer in-**FUR** *verb*



MEANING to figure out from clues or evidence

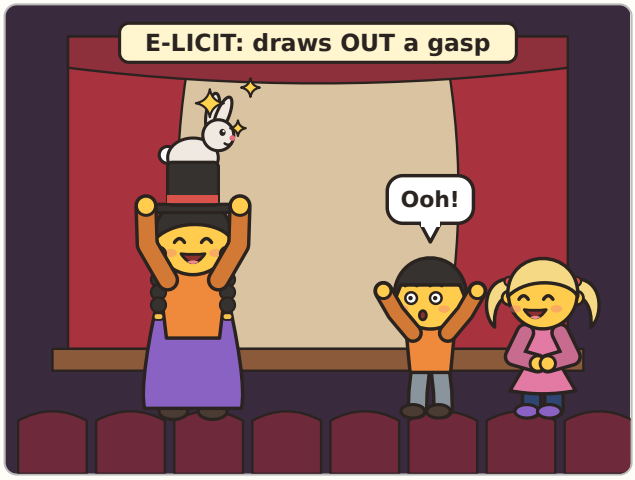
MEMORY HOOK **in-FUR: she INFERS from the FUR.** Lin spots brown fur all over the white sofa and figures it out: the dog has been napping there again. From the fur, she **infers** the truth.

From the muddy paw prints on the rug, Lin **inferred** *that the dog had come inside.*

PARTS **in-** in + **fer** carry, bring

SIMILAR deduce, conclude, gather, reason

elicit ih-**LIS**-it *verb*



MEANING to draw out a response, an answer or a feeling

MEMORY HOOK **E-LICIT: draws OUT an "Ooh!".** Tia pulls a rabbit out of her hat, and the trick draws a gasp out of the crowd: it **elicits** a great big "Ooh!"

The clown's silly walk ***elicited*** *giggles from every child in the room.*

PARTS **e-** out (a form of ex-) + **lic** lure, draw

SIMILAR draw out, evoke, bring out, prompt
OPPOSITE suppress, stifle

illicit il-**LIS**-it *adjective*



MEANING not allowed by law or by the rules

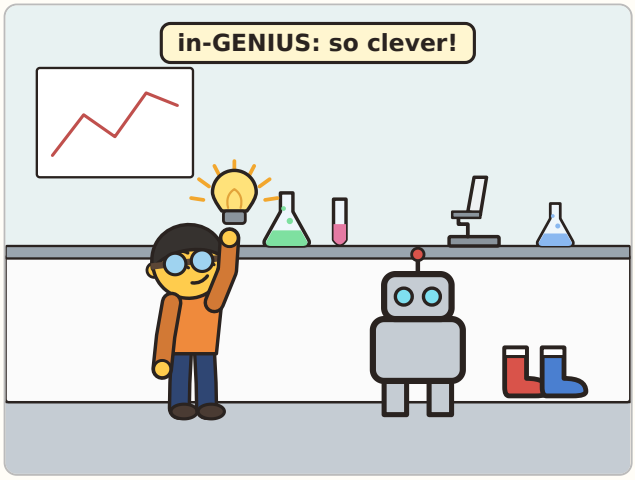
MEMORY HOOK **ILL-icit: ILLegal, against the rules.** The sign says NO CATS ON THE TABLE, but Pepper sneaks up for the fish anyway. Her snack is **illicit**!

The camp counselors found an ***illicit*** *stash of candy hidden under a bunk.*

PARTS **il-** not (a form of in-) + **licit** allowed

SIMILAR illegal, unlawful, forbidden, banned
OPPOSITE legal, lawful, legitimate

ingenious in-**JEEN**-yus *adjective*



MEANING very clever and inventive

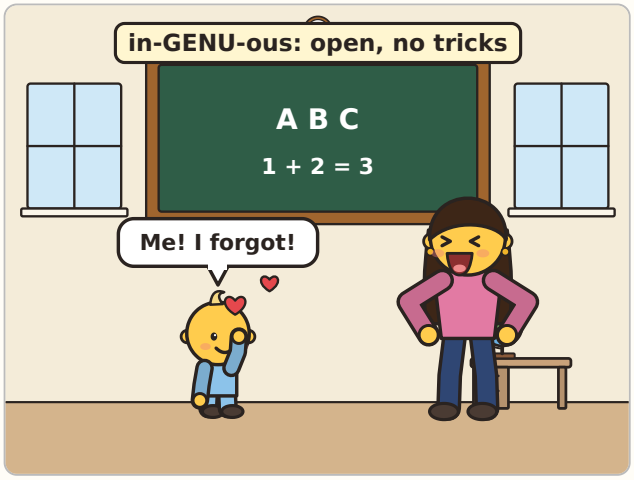
MEMORY HOOK **in-GENIUS: a little GENIUS.** Dev's robot sorts the laundry by color and folds every sock: an idea worthy of a genius. It is **ingenious**.

Sami rigged an ***ingenious*** *pulley that lowers snacks down to his bottom bunk.*

PARTS **in-** in + **gen** birth, produce + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR clever, inventive, creative, brilliant
OPPOSITE unimaginative, clumsy, dull

ingenuous in-**JEN**-yoo-us *adjective*



MEANING innocent, trusting and open; with nothing to hide

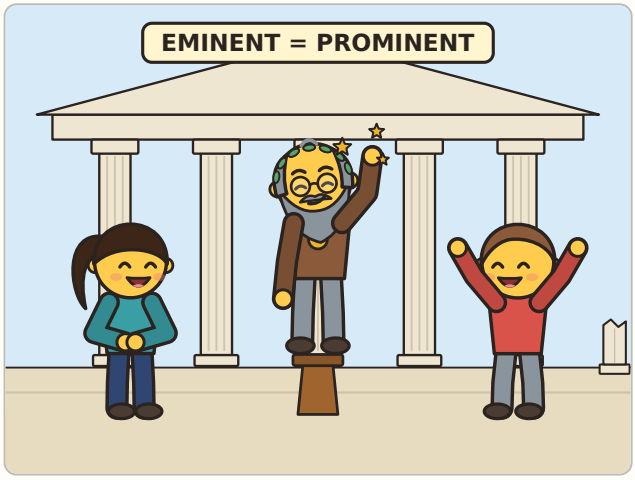
MEMORY HOOK **in-GENU-ous: GENUine, no tricks.** When the teacher asks who forgot their homework, little Theo's hand shoots up at once: he hides nothing. He is **ingenuous**.

With ***ingenuous*** *delight, Theo told the whole family exactly what he had bought Mom for her birthday.*

PARTS **in-** in + **gen** birth + **-uous** full of, having

SIMILAR innocent, naive, trusting, candid
OPPOSITE sly, crafty, disingenuous

eminent EM-uh-nunt *adjective*



MEANING famous and respected in a field

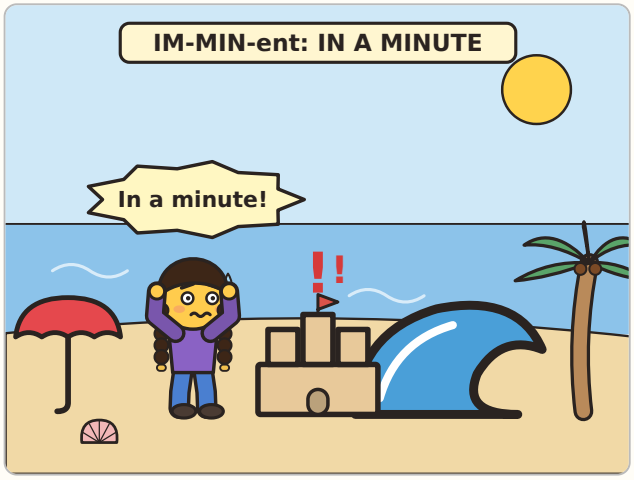
MEMORY HOOK **EMINENT rhymes with PROMINENT.** Professor Edwin stands out above everyone in his field, and the crowd rises to cheer him: he is **eminent**.

*An **eminent** scientist visited our school to talk about volcanoes.*

PARTS **e-** out (a form of ex-) + **min** jut, stand out

SIMILAR distinguished, renowned, prominent, esteemed
OPPOSITE unknown, obscure

imminent IM-uh-nunt *adjective*



MEANING about to happen, often something bad

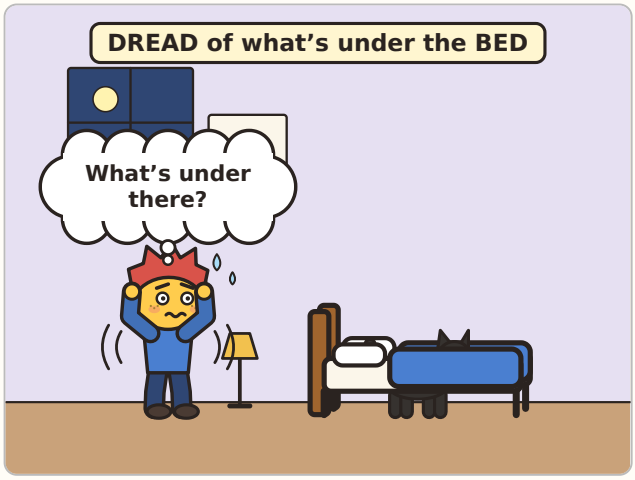
MEMORY HOOK **IM-MIN-ent: IN A MINute!.** A huge wave is rolling toward Lila's sandcastle; it will hit in a minute. The crash is **imminent**!

*With thunder rumbling closer, the lifeguard warned that a storm was **imminent**.*

PARTS **im-** over (a form of in-) + **min** jut, hang over

SIMILAR impending, approaching, near, looming
OPPOSITE distant, remote, far-off

dread DRED *noun*



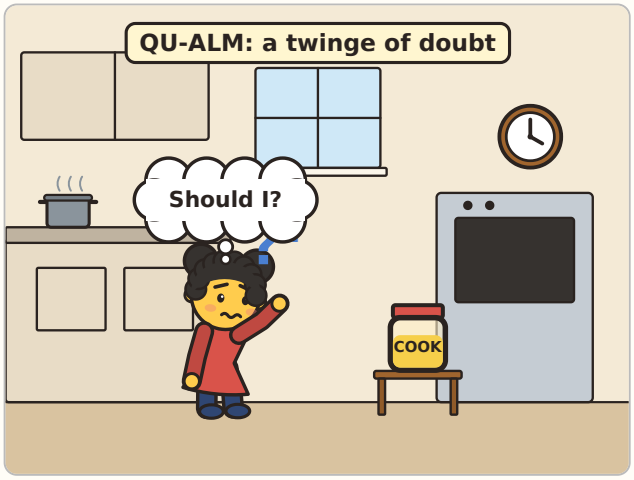
MEANING great fear of something that is coming

MEMORY HOOK **DREAD: the thing under the BED.** As bedtime nears, Pip is full of **dread**: he is sure something is hiding under his bed. (It is only the cat.)

*Kai felt a growing **dread** as the dentist's door creaked open.*

SIMILAR fear, apprehension, terror, foreboding
OPPOSITE eagerness, confidence, calm

qualm KWAHM *noun*



MEANING a sudden uneasy feeling, especially a doubt about whether something is right

MEMORY HOOK **QU + CALM: calm, with a QUestion.** Zoe reaches calmly for the cookie jar before dinner, then pauses: "Should I?" That little twinge of doubt is a **qualm**.

*Rosa had no **qualms** about eating the last cookie; she had baked them all herself.*

SIMILAR doubt, misgiving, scruple, reservation
OPPOSITE certainty, confidence

misgiving mis-**GIV**-ing *noun*



MEANING a feeling of doubt or worry about whether something will turn out well

MEMORY HOOK **MIS-GIVING: GIVING, with doubts.** Marcus holds out the car keys to Jonah for his first drive alone, but his hand hesitates: he has a **misgiving** about giving them.

Despite her **misgivings**, *Ada let her son ride the giant roller coaster.*

PARTS **mis-** badly, wrongly

SIMILAR doubt, qualm, reservation, apprehension
OPPOSITE confidence, certainty, trust

unnerve un-**NURV** *verb*



MEANING to make someone lose courage or calm

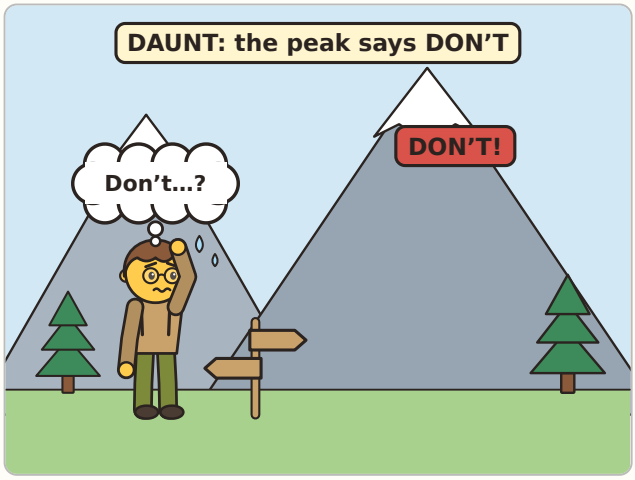
MEMORY HOOK **UN-NERVE: his NERVE is gone.** Dev boasted he would jump from the high rock into the river, but standing at the edge, he loses his nerve. The height **unnerves** him.

The creaking floorboards **unnerved** *the new babysitter.*

PARTS **un-** undo, take away + **nerve** courage

SIMILAR rattle, unsettle, frighten, fluster
OPPOSITE reassure, steady, calm

daunt **DAWNT** *verb*



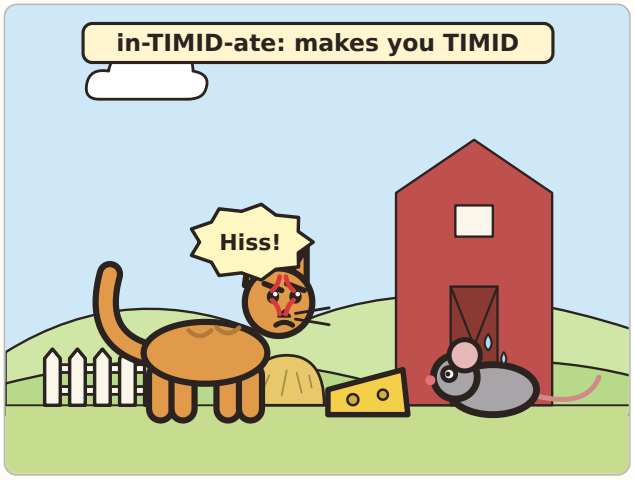
MEANING to make someone feel discouraged or afraid to try

MEMORY HOOK **DAUNT = DON'T: the mountain says DON'T.** The giant mountain seems to say "Don't!" to tiny Felix at its foot. Its size **daunts** him, and he almost turns back.

The steep trail did not **daunt** *Granny Mae; she reached the top before anyone else.*

SIMILAR discourage, dishearten, frighten, intimidate
OPPOSITE encourage, embolden, hearten

intimidate in-**TIM**-ih-dayt *verb*



MEANING to frighten someone, often to make them do what you want

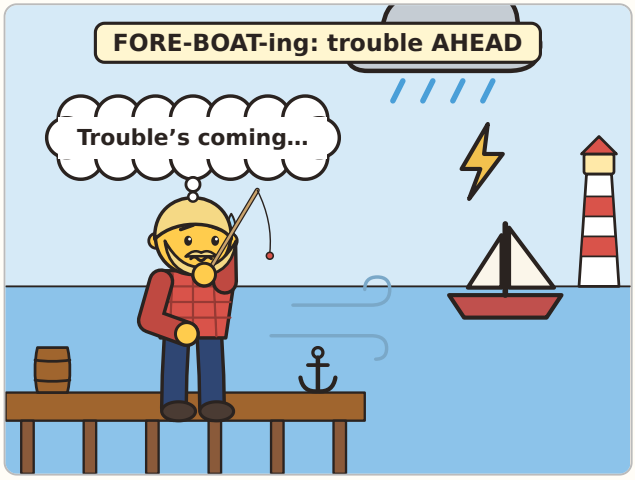
MEMORY HOOK **in-TIMID-ate: makes you TIMID.** The barn cat puffs up and hisses, and the little mouse turns timid and backs away from the cheese. The cat **intimidates** the mouse.

The big dog's deep bark **intimidated** *the mail carrier.*

PARTS **in-** in, into + **timid** fearful + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR frighten, scare, bully, daunt
OPPOSITE reassure, encourage, comfort

foreboding for-**BOH**-ding *noun*



MEANING a feeling that something bad is going to happen

MEMORY HOOK **FORE-BOAT-ing: a bad feeling before the BOAT trip.** Before the boat trip, Sven sees black clouds rolling in and feels sure that trouble is coming. That feeling is a **foreboding**.

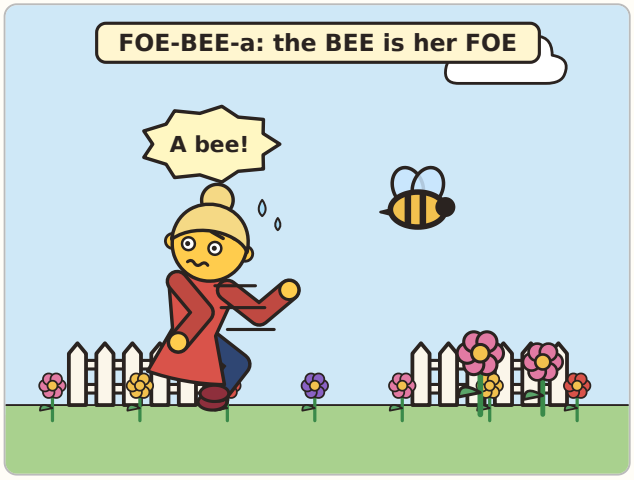
Watching the black clouds gather, Sven had a **foreboding** *that the fishing trip would end early.*

PARTS **fore-** before, ahead + **bode** foretell

SIMILAR apprehension, dread, premonition, fear

OPPOSITE optimism, hope, confidence

phobia **FOH**-bee-uh *noun*



MEANING a strong, lasting fear of one thing, often far beyond any real danger

MEMORY HOOK **FOE-BEE-a: every BEE is her FOE.** To Greta, every bee is a foe: she has a **phobia** of bees and runs from even the smallest one.

Felix has a **phobia** *of elevators, so he always takes the stairs.*

PARTS **phob** fear

SIMILAR fear, terror, horror, aversion

OPPOSITE fondness, liking

consternation kon-ster-**NAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING sudden alarm and confusion; shocked dismay

MEMORY HOOK **the whole NATION STARES in alarm.** At the town fair, the giant cake begins to topple, and the whole crowd stares and gasps in alarm: **consternation**!

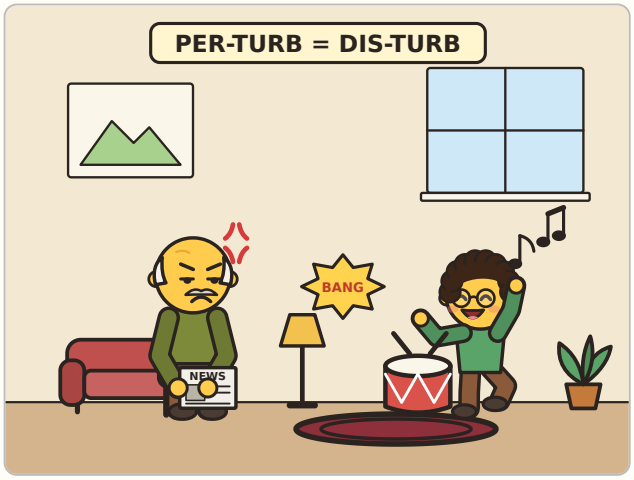
To the baker's **consternation**, *the wedding cake slid right off the cart.*

PARTS **con-** thoroughly, together + **-ation** the act or state of

SIMILAR dismay, alarm, shock, panic

OPPOSITE calm, composure, delight

perturb per-**TURB** *verb*



MEANING to make someone worried or upset

MEMORY HOOK **PERTURB rhymes with DISTURB.** Sami's drumming next door keeps disturbing Grandpa's crossword until he can't think straight. The noise **perturbs** him.

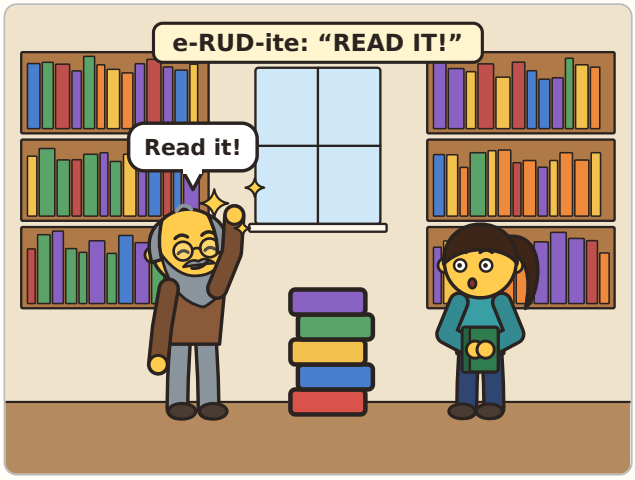
It **perturbed** *Grandpa Gus that the newspaper had not come by eight.*

PARTS **per-** thoroughly + **turb** disturb, stir up

SIMILAR disturb, upset, unsettle, worry

OPPOSITE calm, soothe, reassure

erudite AIR-yuh-dite *adjective*



MEANING having or showing great knowledge from reading and study

MEMORY HOOK **“READ IT!”: he has read them all.** Ask Professor Edwin about any book in the library and he smiles: “Read it!” He has read them all; he is **erudite**.

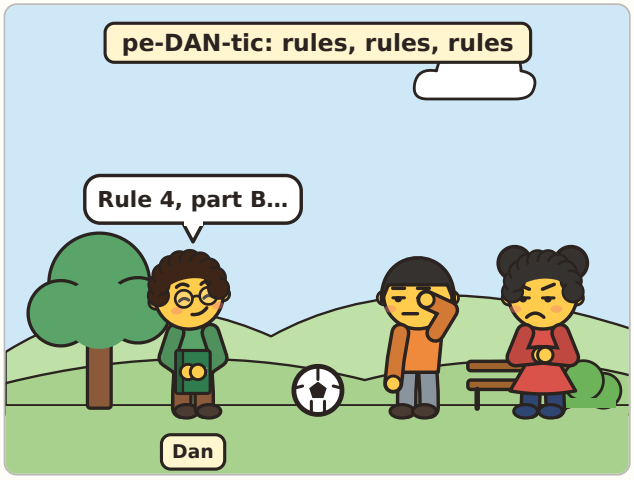
*The **erudite** librarian could answer questions about almost any book on the shelves.*

PARTS **e-** out (a form of ex-) + **rud** rough, untaught

SIMILAR learned, scholarly, knowledgeable, well-read

OPPOSITE ignorant, uneducated, unlettered

pedantic puh-DAN-tik *adjective*



MEANING too concerned with small details and rules, often to show off learning

MEMORY HOOK **pe-DAN-tic: DAN and his rules.** Dan stops the soccer game to read out the rule about exactly how round the ball must be. Dan is **pedantic**.

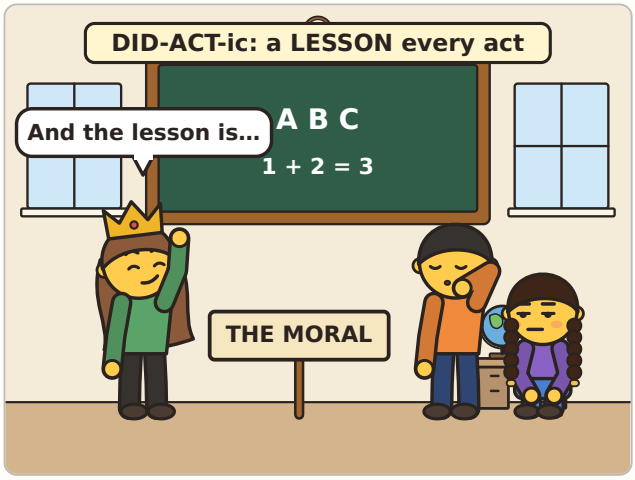
*My **pedantic** cousin corrected my grammar in the middle of my birthday toast.*

PARTS **-ic** having to do with, like

SIMILAR nitpicking, fussy, hair-splitting, overprecise

OPPOSITE easygoing, flexible, casual

didactic dye-DAK-tik *adjective*



MEANING meant to teach a lesson, often in a preachy way

MEMORY HOOK **DID-ACT-ic: every ACT stops for a LESSON.** The class play did act out a story, but every scene stopped for a lecture: “And the lesson is…” The play is **didactic**.

*The picture book was so **didactic** that every page ended with a lesson about brushing your teeth.*

PARTS **didact** teach + **-ic** having to do with

SIMILAR instructive, preachy, moralizing, educational

OPPOSITE entertaining, subtle

connoisseur kon-uh-SUR *noun*



MEANING an expert judge of things that need fine taste, such as food, art or music

MEMORY HOOK **CONE-a-SIR: the CONE expert, sir.** Victor takes one lick of each ice cream cone and names the flavor and the farm it came from. He is a **connoisseur**.

*A cheese **connoisseur** can tell where a cheese was made from a single bite.*

SIMILAR expert, judge, authority, aficionado

OPPOSITE amateur, dilettante, beginner

dilettante **DIL**-uh-tahnt *noun*



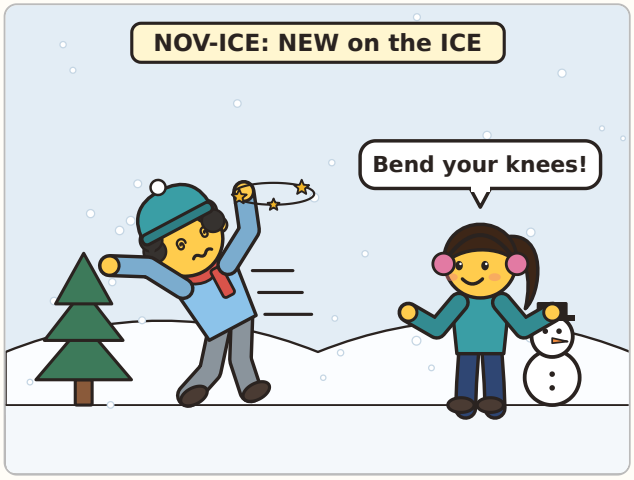
MEANING a person who dabbles in a subject or an art without serious study

MEMORY HOOK **DILLY-DALLY-tante: a little of everything.** Pip dillydallies: guitar on Monday, painting on Tuesday, chess on Wednesday. He dabbles in each and masters none: he is a **dilettante**.

He calls himself a painter, but he is a **dilettante** *who finishes about one picture a year.*

SIMILAR dabbler, hobbyist, trifler
OPPOSITE expert, professional, connoisseur

novice **NOV**-is *noun*



MEANING a beginner; someone new to a skill or activity

MEMORY HOOK **NOV-ICE: NEW on the ICE.** Jamal is new on the ice: wobbly knees, waving arms, one big bump. He is a **novice** skater.

As a **novice** *skater, Lin spent more time on the ice than on her feet.*

PARTS **nov** new

SIMILAR beginner, newcomer, learner, rookie
OPPOSITE expert, veteran, master

prodigy **PROD**-ih-jee *noun*



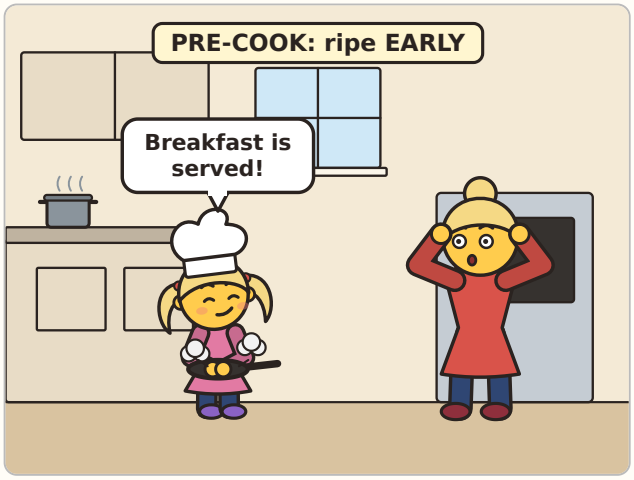
MEANING a young person with an amazing talent

MEMORY HOOK **PRO-digy: a PRO, and only three.** Little Theo is only three, yet he plays the violin like a pro. The crowd can't believe it: he is a **prodigy**!

At six, the piano **prodigy** *played a concert in a packed hall.*

SIMILAR genius, wonder child, wunderkind

precocious prih-**KOH**-shus *adjective*



MEANING showing skills or behavior unusually early for one's age

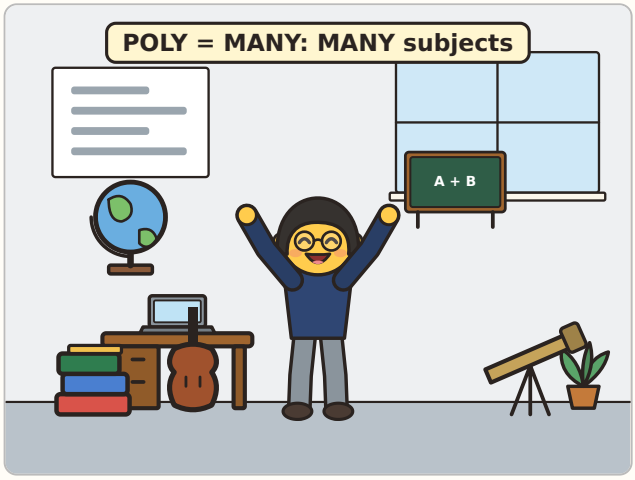
MEMORY HOOK **PRE-COOK-ious: COOKS before age five.** Ivy is only four, yet she cooks a whole breakfast: pancakes, eggs and toast. She is **precocious**: ripe early.

The **precocious** *toddler could read the cereal box before she turned three.*

PARTS **pre-** before + **coc** cook, ripen + **-ious** full of, having

SIMILAR advanced, gifted, forward, mature for one's age
OPPOSITE immature, late-blooming

polymath **POL**-ee-math *noun*



MEANING a person who knows a great deal about many different subjects

MEMORY HOOK **POLY-MATH: MATH and MANY more.** Ada knows math, music, maps, stars and many more subjects besides: she is a **polymath**.

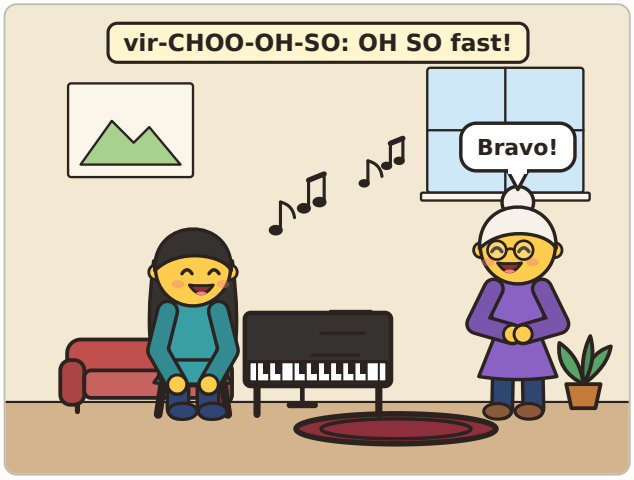
A true **polymath**, *Professor Edwin has written books on birds, bridges and old poems.*

PARTS **poly-** many + **math** learning

SIMILAR Renaissance person, universal genius

OPPOSITE specialist

virtuoso vur-choo-**OH**-soh *noun*



MEANING a person with outstanding skill, especially in playing music

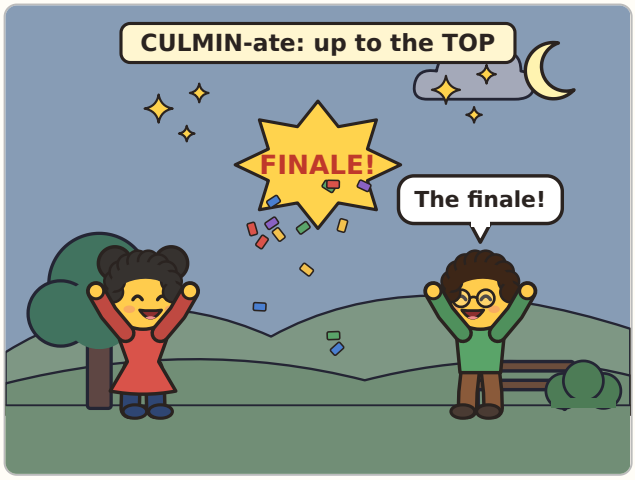
MEMORY HOOK **vir-CHOO-OH-SO: fast as a CHOO-CHOO.** Lin's fingers race over the piano keys like a speeding train: choo-choo, oh so fast! She is a **virtuoso**.

The violin **virtuoso** *played so fast that her bow seemed to blur.*

SIMILAR master, maestro, expert, ace

OPPOSITE novice, beginner, amateur

culminate **KUL**-muh-nayt *verb*



MEANING to reach the highest point or the final, biggest stage

MEMORY HOOK **CLIMB-inate: it CLIMBS to the big finish.** The fireworks show climbs higher and higher and ends with one giant golden burst: the show **culminates** in a grand finale.

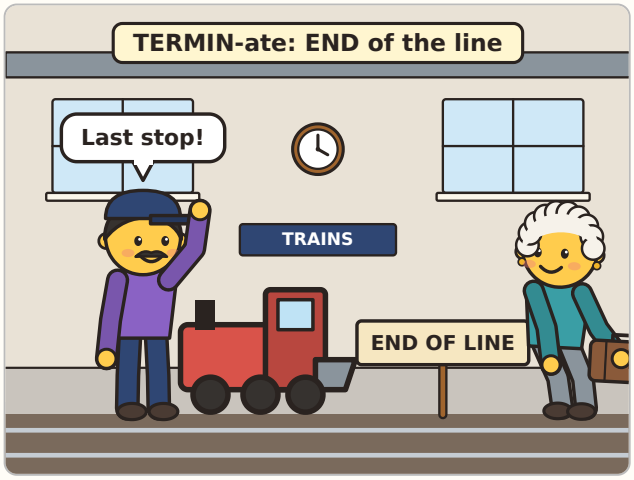
A week of rehearsals **culminated** *in a standing ovation on opening night.*

PARTS **culmin** top, peak + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR climax, peak, come to a head, build up to

OPPOSITE begin, start

terminate **TUR**-muh-nayt *verb*



MEANING to bring to an end, or to come to an end

MEMORY HOOK **TERMIN-al: the END of the line.** The train pulls into the terminal, the very end of the line. "Everybody off!" The trip **terminates** here.

The bus line **terminates** *at the edge of town, so we walked the last mile.*

PARTS **termin** end, boundary + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR end, stop, conclude, cancel

OPPOSITE begin, initiate, continue

cessation seh-**SAY**-shun *noun*



MEANING a stopping; the end of something

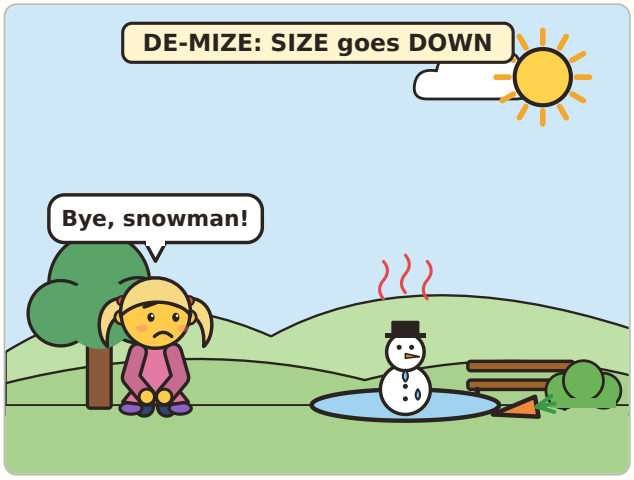
MEMORY HOOK **CEASE-ation: the rain CEASES.** The rain ceases, a rainbow appears, and Nell shakes out her umbrella. The **cessation** of the storm brings everyone outside.

*The **cessation** of the rain brought everyone out onto their porches.*

PARTS **cess** stop (from Latin cedere, to go, to yield) + **-ation** the act of

SIMILAR stop, halt, end, pause
OPPOSITE continuation, beginning, start

demise dih-**MIZE** *noun*



MEANING the end of something; also, a death

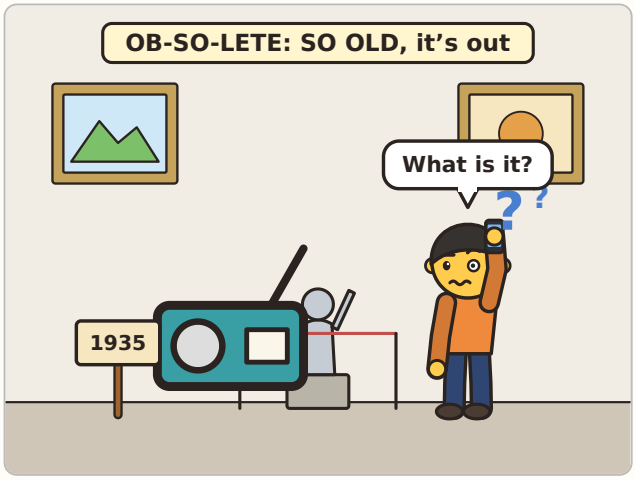
MEMORY HOOK **DE-MIZE: his SIZE goes DOWN to nothing.** In the spring sun, the snowman's size shrinks down, down, down, until only a puddle, a hat and a carrot are left. That is the snowman's **demise**.

*The arrival of the big new mall led to the **demise** of the little corner bookshop.*

PARTS **mis** send, let go

SIMILAR end, death, passing, finish
OPPOSITE birth, beginning, rise

obsolete ob-suh-**LEET** *adjective*



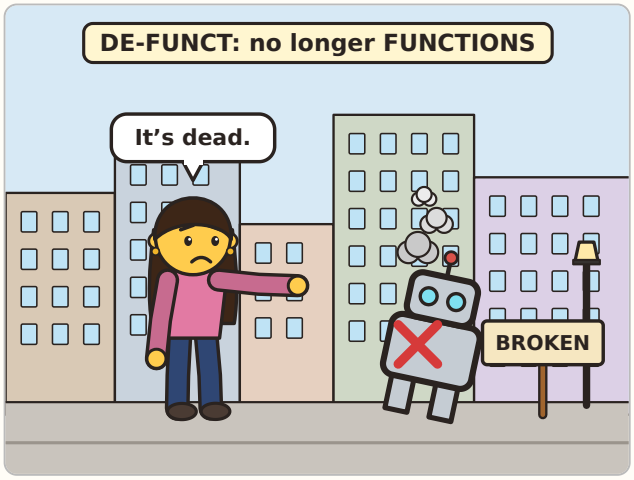
MEANING no longer used or useful; out of date

MEMORY HOOK **OB-SO-LETE: SO OLD, it's out.** At the museum, Dev stares at a giant old radio the size of a fridge. Nobody uses one like that anymore: it is **obsolete**.

*Grandpa still keeps his **obsolete** typewriter on a shelf in the den.*

SIMILAR outdated, outmoded, antiquated, disused
OPPOSITE current, modern, up-to-date

defunct dih-**FUNKT** *adjective*



MEANING no longer existing, working or in use

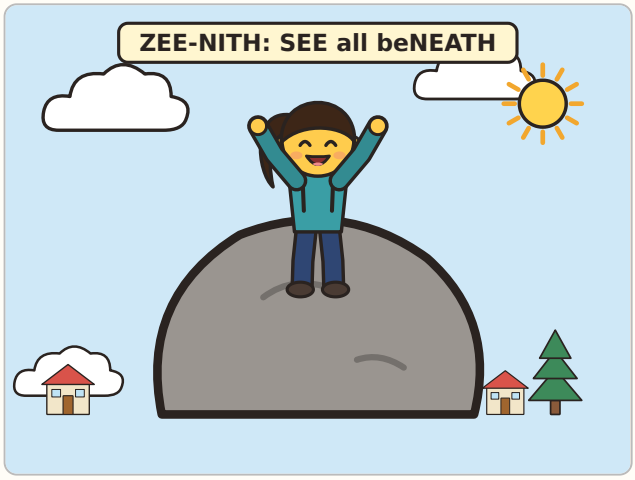
MEMORY HOOK **DE-FUNCT: no longer FUNCTIONS.** The old robot in the alley no longer functions: no lights, no beeps, just a puff of dust. It is **defunct**.

*The **defunct** factory has been turned into apartments and a bakery.*

PARTS **de-** off, away + **funct** perform

SIMILAR extinct, dead, disused, inoperative
OPPOSITE working, active, operating

zenith ZEE-nith *noun*



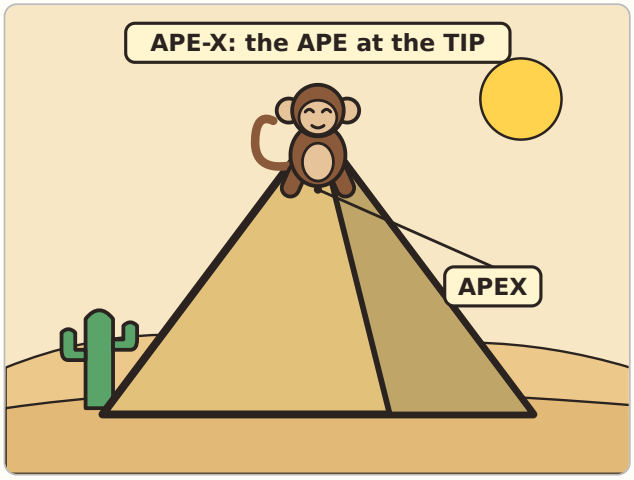
MEANING the highest point; the time of greatest success or power

MEMORY HOOK **ZEE-NITH: SEE everything beNEATH.** From the very top of the peak, with the sun straight overhead, Maya can see everything beneath her. She has reached the **zenith**.

*At its **zenith**, the little bakery sold a thousand loaves a day.*

SIMILAR peak, summit, top
OPPOSITE bottom, low point, rock bottom

apex AY-peks *noun*



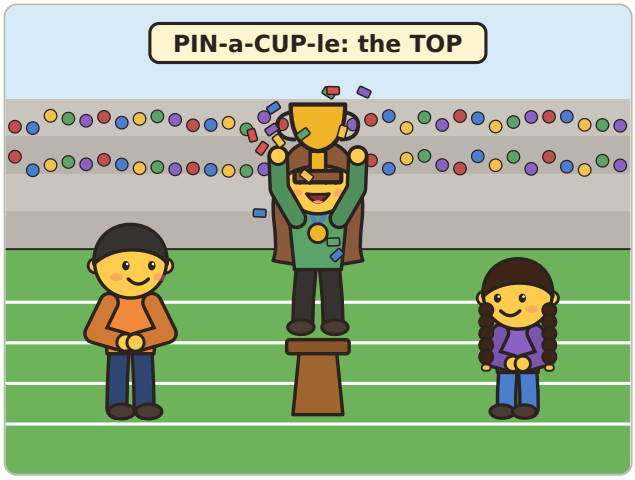
MEANING the top or highest point, often a pointed tip

MEMORY HOOK **APE-X: the APE on the very tip.** A cheeky ape scrambles up to the pointed tip of the pyramid and waves: he has reached the **apex**.

*The lion is called an **apex** predator because no other animal hunts it.*

SIMILAR peak, summit, top
OPPOSITE bottom, low point, rock bottom

pinnacle PIN-uh-kul *noun*



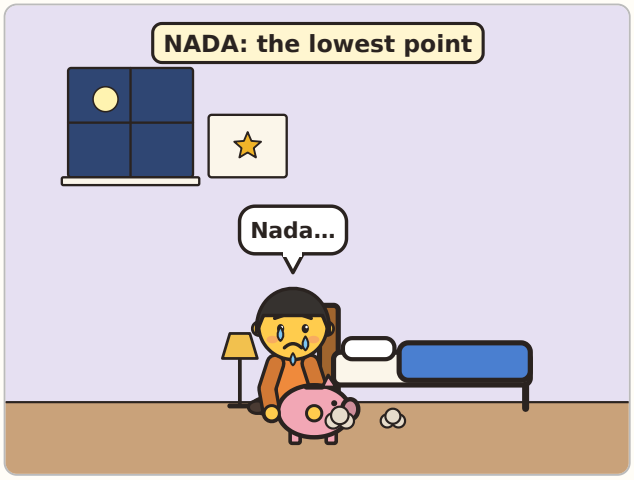
MEANING the highest point of success or achievement

MEMORY HOOK **a PIN and a CUP: the very top.** Rosa wins the gold pin and the giant cup at the national meet, the highest honor of all: the **pinnacle** of her career.

*Winning the state title was the **pinnacle** of Coach Omar's career.*

SIMILAR peak, summit, top
OPPOSITE bottom, low point, rock bottom

nadir NAY-der *noun*



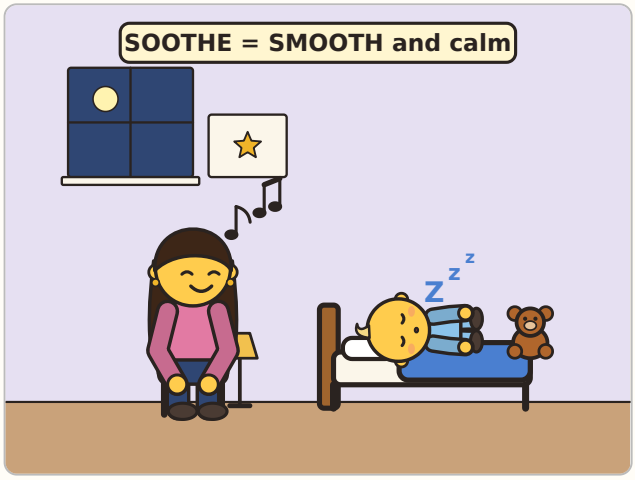
MEANING the lowest point

MEMORY HOOK **NADA left: rock bottom.** Kai has spent every last coin. He shakes his piggy bank and gets nada, nothing at all: his savings have hit their **nadir**.

*The team's **nadir** came in October, when it lost five games in a row.*

SIMILAR bottom, low point, rock bottom
OPPOSITE peak, summit, top

soothe SOOTH *verb*



MEANING to calm or comfort, often gently; to ease pain

MEMORY HOOK **SOOTHE rhymes with SMOOTH.** Priya sings a smooth, slow lullaby, and little Theo's crying fades into sleepy sighs. Her song **soothes** him.

Priya hummed an old lullaby to **soothe** *the fussy baby.*

SIMILAR calm, comfort, ease, relieve
OPPOSITE agitate, upset, irritate

console kun-SOHL *verb*



MEANING to comfort someone who is sad or disappointed

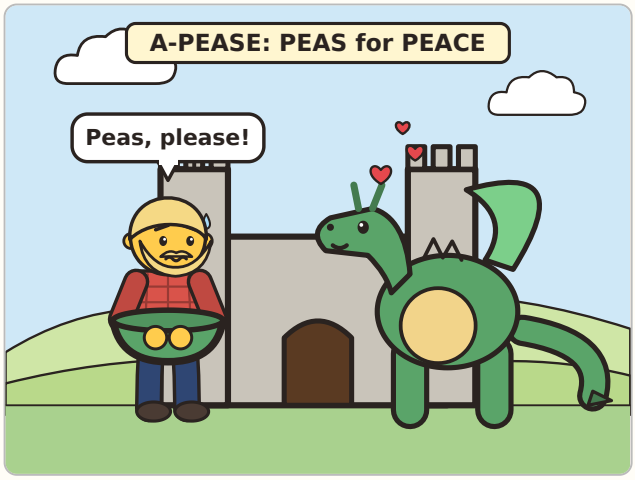
MEMORY HOOK **a CONE for a SAD SOUL.** Pip comes in last in the race, so Nana Lou hands him an ice cream cone and a hug: "You ran your best." She **consoles** him.

Rosa **consoled** *her little brother after his kite blew away.*

PARTS **con-** with + **sol** comfort

SIMILAR comfort, cheer, solace, reassure
OPPOSITE upset, distress, trouble

appease uh-PEEZ *verb*



MEANING to calm someone by giving them what they demand

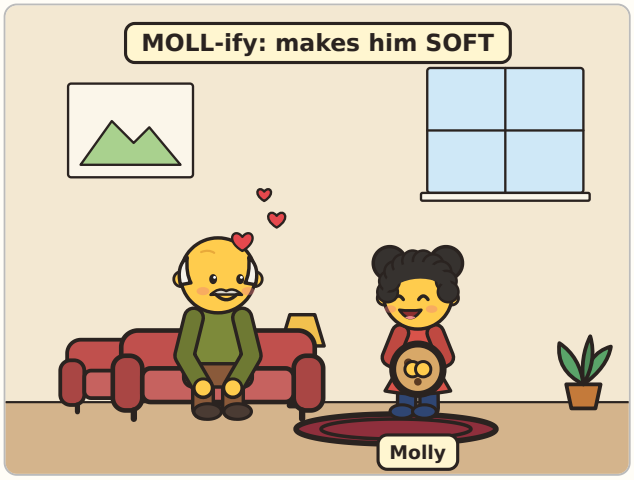
MEMORY HOOK **a-PEAS: PEAS for PEACE.** The dragon roars for its dinner, so Sven slides it a giant bowl of peas. Full and happy, it settles down: Sven **appeases** the dragon.

To stop the twins' chant of "Snacks! Snacks!", Mom **appeased** *them with a plate of crackers.*

PARTS **ap-** to (a form of ad-) + **pease** peace (from Latin pax)

SIMILAR placate, pacify, satisfy, buy off
OPPOSITE provoke, anger, enrage

mollify MOL-uh-fye *verb*



MEANING to soften someone's anger

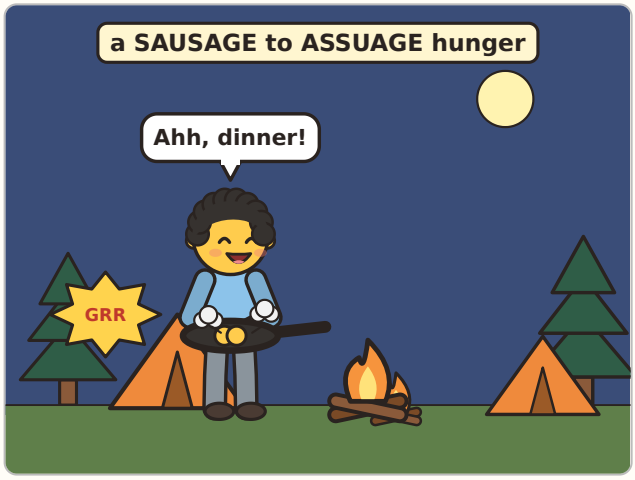
MEMORY HOOK **MOLLY-fy: Molly makes him MELLOW.** Grandpa Gus is grumbling until little Molly brings him a warm cookie and a hug. His anger softens: Molly **mollifies** him.

A free dessert **mollified** *the diner whose soup had come out cold.*

PARTS **moll** soft + **-ify** to make

SIMILAR placate, pacify, soften, sweeten
OPPOSITE anger, enrage, provoke

assuage uh-**SWAYJ** *verb*



MEANING to make a bad feeling, such as hunger, pain or guilt, less strong

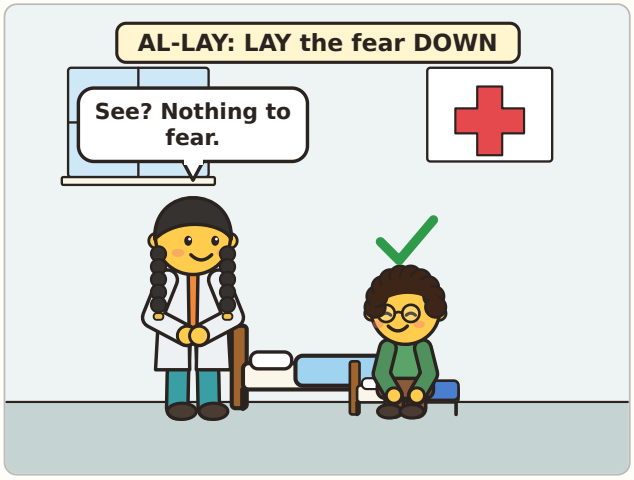
MEMORY HOOK **A SAUSAGE to ASSUAGE his hunger.** After a long day of hiking, Jamal's stomach growls. One hot sausage from the campfire **assuages** his hunger.

A tall glass of lemonade **assuaged** *our thirst after the long hike.*

PARTS **as-** to (a form of ad-) + **suage** sweeten (from Latin suavis, sweet)

SIMILAR ease, relieve, lessen, alleviate
OPPOSITE worsen, intensify, aggravate

allay uh-**LAY** *verb*



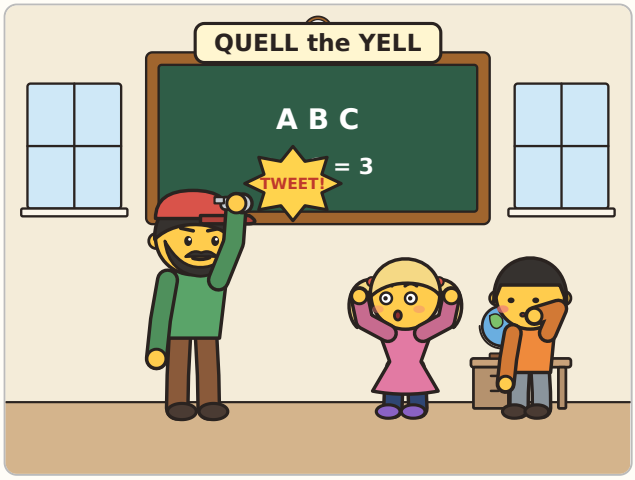
MEANING to make fear, worry or doubt less strong

MEMORY HOOK **AL-LAY: LAY your fears DOWN.** Before his checkup, Sami is scared, so Nurse Tia shows him each tool and lets him listen to his own heartbeat. Her kindness **allays** his fears.

The pilot's calm voice **allayed** *the nervous passengers' fears.*

SIMILAR ease, calm, relieve, lessen
OPPOSITE arouse, stir up, increase

quell **KWEL** *verb*



MEANING to put an end to something, such as a riot or a rumor, often by force

MEMORY HOOK **QUELL the YELL.** The lunchroom roars with yelling until Coach Omar blows one sharp whistle, and the noise stops at once. He **quells** the yell.

The teacher **quelled** *the giggling with a single raised eyebrow.*

SIMILAR suppress, crush, put down, stamp out
OPPOSITE incite, provoke, stir up

conciliate kun-**SIL**-ee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to win over someone who is angry, often by friendly acts

MEMORY HOOK **CON-SILLY-ate: win him over with something SILLY.** Victor is angry about the ball in his garden, so Greta brings him a pie and sings a silly sorry song. His frown melts: she **conciliates** him.

The hotel **conciliated** *the upset guests with a free night's stay.*

PARTS **con-** together + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR placate, win over, pacify, disarm
OPPOSITE antagonize, alienate, anger

reconcile REK-un-sile *verb*



MEANING to become friends again after a quarrel; also, to make two things agree

MEMORY HOOK **from WRECK to SMILE: REC-on-SMILE.** Lila and Maya had a wreck of a fight, but now they hug and smile, friends again: they **reconcile**.

After a week of silence, the two friends finally **reconciled** *over a shared pizza.*

PARTS **re-** again + **concile** bring together, win over

SIMILAR make up, reunite, make peace, settle

OPPOSITE estrange, divide, alienate

defuse dee-FYOOZ *verb*



MEANING to calm a tense or dangerous situation

MEMORY HOOK **DE-FUSE: put out the FUSE before the BOOM.** Kai and Dev are about to blow up at each other. Ada pours water on the sizzling fuse of their fight: she **defuses** it.

Pip **defused** *the argument at the dinner table by making everyone laugh.*

PARTS **de-** remove + **fuse** the wick that sets something off

SIMILAR calm, ease, settle, smooth over

OPPOSITE inflame, escalate, provoke

hostile HOS-tul *adjective*



MEANING unfriendly; showing that you want to fight or oppose

MEMORY HOOK **HOST-ILE: a HOST who wants a fight.** Felix answers his door with a scowl and crossed arms: “No visitors!” He is the most **hostile** host on the street.

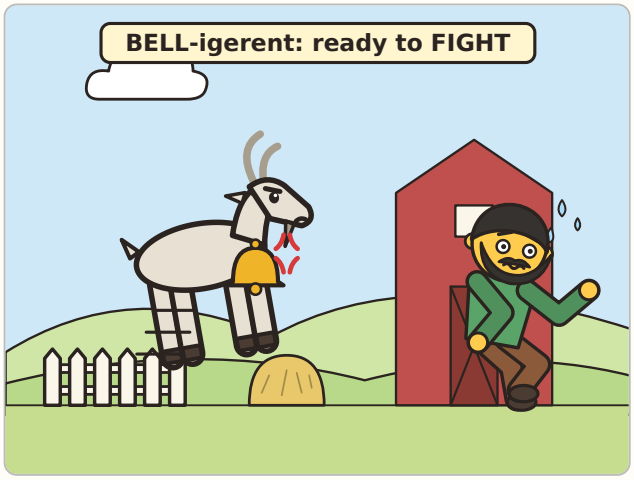
The cat gave the new puppy a **hostile** *stare and a low hiss.*

PARTS **host** enemy, stranger

SIMILAR unfriendly, antagonistic, aggressive, combative

OPPOSITE friendly, welcoming, amicable

belligerent buh-LIJ-er-unt *adjective*



MEANING acting angry and ready to fight

MEMORY HOOK **BELL-igerent: the goat with the BELL charges.** The goat with the bell around his neck lowers his horns and charges at anyone who comes near the barn. He is **belligerent**.

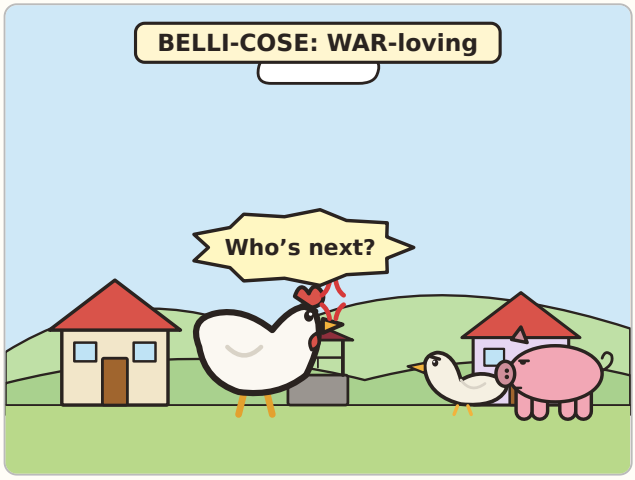
The **belligerent** *customer shouted at the cashier over a ten-cent coupon.*

PARTS **bell** war + **ger** wage, carry on

SIMILAR aggressive, hostile, combative, quarrelsome

OPPOSITE peaceful, friendly, conciliatory

bellicose **BEL**-ih-kohs *adjective*



MEANING eager to fight or go to war; warlike by nature

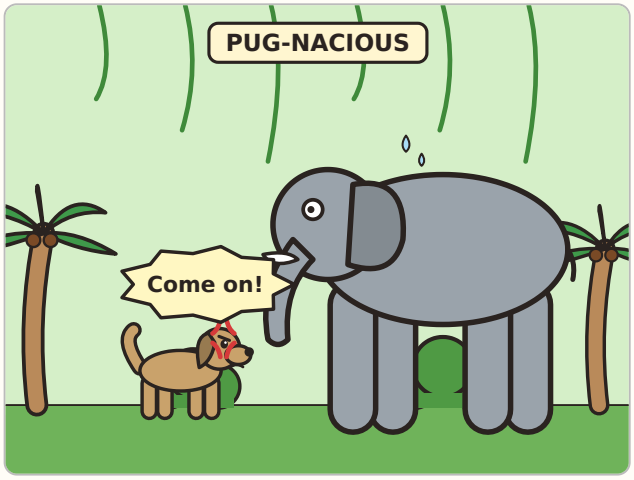
MEMORY HOOK **BELL-i-COSE: loves war (BELLum).** Every single morning, the rooster puffs up his chest and dares every animal in the yard to fight him. Fighting is his nature: he is **bellicose**.

The **bellicose** *rooster picked a fight with every bird in the yard.*

PARTS **bell** war + **-ose** full of

SIMILAR warlike, aggressive, combative, belligerent
OPPOSITE peaceful, peace-loving, pacifist

pugnacious pug-**NAY**-shus *adjective*



MEANING quick to argue or fight

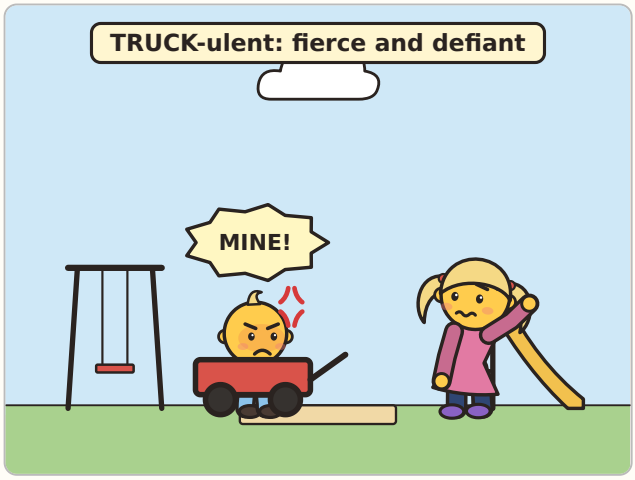
MEMORY HOOK **PUG-NACIOUS: a PUG ready to fight.** The tiny pug plants his feet and growls at an elephant a hundred times his size: "Come on!" He is **pugnacious**.

The **pugnacious** *little terrier barked at dogs five times his size.*

PARTS **pugn** fight (from Latin pugnus, fist) + **-acious** full of, having

SIMILAR combative, quarrelsome, belligerent, argumentative
OPPOSITE peaceable, agreeable, easygoing

truculent **TRUK**-yuh-lunt *adjective*



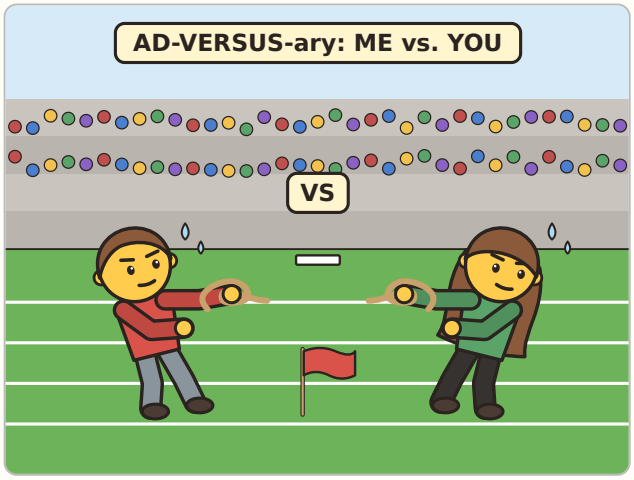
MEANING quick to argue or fight; fierce and defiant

MEMORY HOOK **TRUCK-ulent: "MY TRUCK! Don't touch!".** Theo sits in his toy truck with his arms crossed and a fierce scowl: "Mine! Go away!" He is **truculent**.

The **truculent** *toddler crossed his arms and refused to put on his shoes.*

SIMILAR defiant, combative, surly, belligerent
OPPOSITE meek, cooperative, gentle

adversary **AD**-ver-sair-ee *noun*



MEANING an opponent; someone you compete or fight against

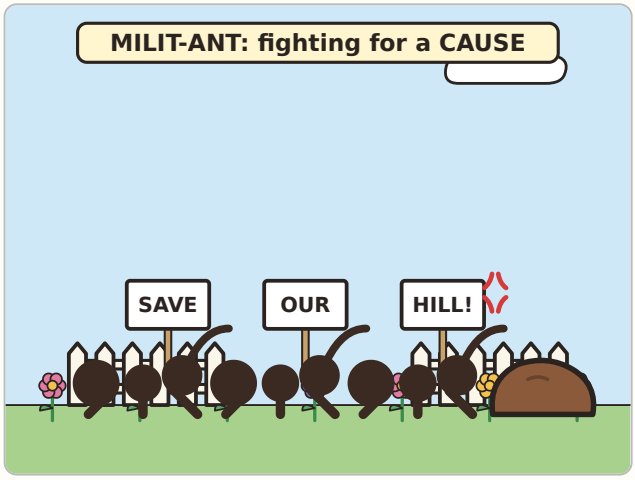
MEMORY HOOK **AD-VERSUS-ary: ME VERSUS YOU.** In the tug-of-war, it is Jonah versus Rosa, each pulling the other way: they are **adversaries**.

In the chess final, Maya faced her toughest **adversary***: her own grandfather.*

PARTS **ad-** toward + **vers** turn

SIMILAR opponent, rival, foe, enemy
OPPOSITE ally, friend, teammate

militant **MIL**-ih-tunt *adjective*



MEANING fighting hard and aggressively for a cause

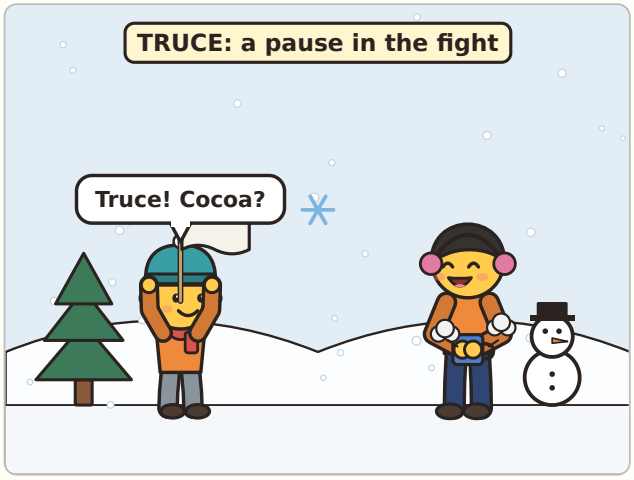
MEMORY HOOK **MILIT-ANT: an ANT army for a cause.** The ants march in a fierce line with tiny signs: SAVE OUR HILL! They will fight hard for their anthill: they are **militant**.

*The **militant** members of the garden club demanded that every lawn in town become a vegetable patch.*

PARTS **milit** soldier

SIMILAR aggressive, combative, radical, zealous
OPPOSITE moderate, peaceful, passive

truce **TROOS** *noun*



MEANING an agreement to stop fighting for a while

MEMORY HOOK **TRUCE: a TRUE pause, for now.** In the middle of their snowball fight, Kai waves a white flag: “Truce! Cocoa break!” For now, the fight is paused: it is a **truce**.

*The two brothers called a **truce** in their pillow fight so they could eat breakfast.*

SIMILAR ceasefire, pause, lull
OPPOSITE war, fighting, hostilities

armistice **AR**-mih-stis *noun*



MEANING an agreement between two sides at war to stop fighting

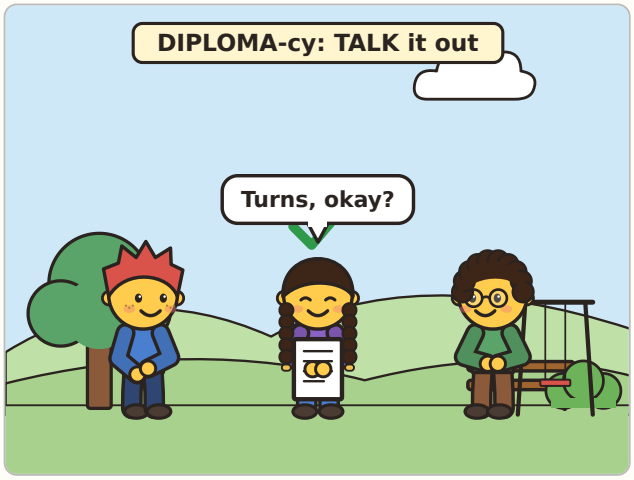
MEMORY HOOK **ARMS STILL: ARMI-STICE.** The two kings shake hands over a signed scroll, and both armies put down their arms and stand still. The **armistice** ends the war.

*The **armistice** was signed at dawn, and by noon the fighting had stopped all along the border.*

PARTS **armi** arms, weapons + **stice** a standing still

SIMILAR ceasefire, truce, peace agreement
OPPOSITE war, hostilities

diplomacy dih-**PLOH**-muh-see *noun*



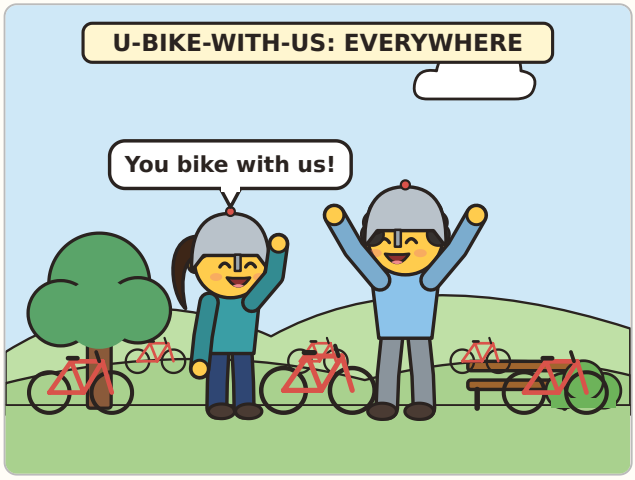
MEANING the work of managing relations between nations; also, skill in handling people tactfully

MEMORY HOOK **DIPLOMA-cy: talk it out, then sign the paper.** Pip and Sami are fighting over the tree swing, so Lila sits them down, listens to each and gets them to sign a turn-taking deal. That is **diplomacy**.

*With a little **diplomacy**, Lila got both brothers to share the last slice of cake.*

SIMILAR tact, negotiation, statecraft, discretion
OPPOSITE tactlessness, bluntness

ubiquitous yoo-**BIK**-wih-tus *adjective*



MEANING found everywhere; seeming to be everywhere at once

MEMORY HOOK **YOU BIKE WITH US: bikes everywhere.** In this town, everyone calls out "You bike with us!" Bikes are on every path, every rack and every porch: they are **ubiquitous**.

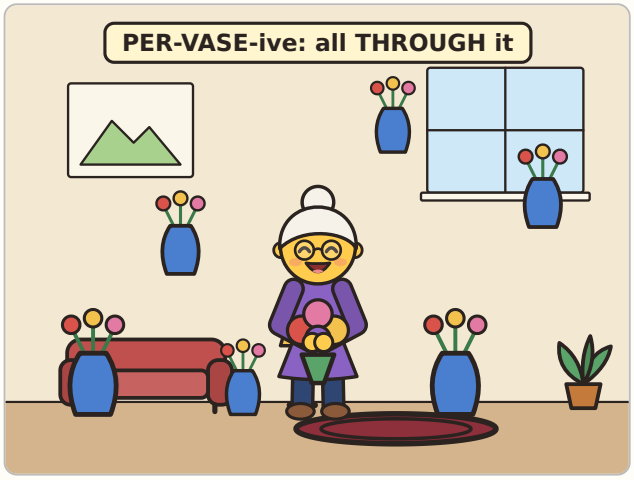
Phones are so **ubiquitous** *now that it is hard to find a bus rider without one.*

PARTS **ubiqu** everywhere + **-ous** full of, having

SIMILAR omnipresent, everywhere, widespread, pervasive

OPPOSITE rare, scarce, uncommon

pervasive per-**VAY**-siv *adjective*



MEANING spreading through every part of something

MEMORY HOOK **per-VASE-ive: VASES all THROUGH the house.** Granny Mae loves flowers so much that there are vases on every table, shelf and windowsill in her house. Flowers are **pervasive** there.

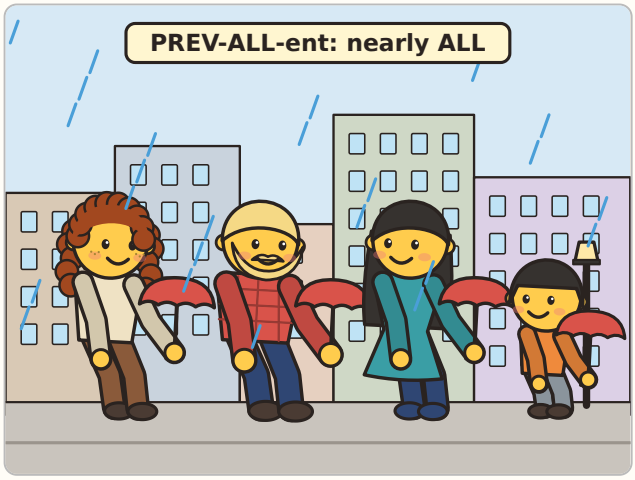
The **pervasive** *smell of popcorn drifted through every corner of the theater.*

PARTS **per-** through + **vas** go + **-ive** tending to

SIMILAR widespread, all-over, rife, inescapable

OPPOSITE limited, contained, rare

prevalent **PREV**-uh-lunt *adjective*



MEANING widespread; common in a place or at a time

MEMORY HOOK **PREV-ALL-ent: nearly ALL have one.** When it rains in our town, nearly all of us carry red umbrellas. Red umbrellas are **prevalent** here.

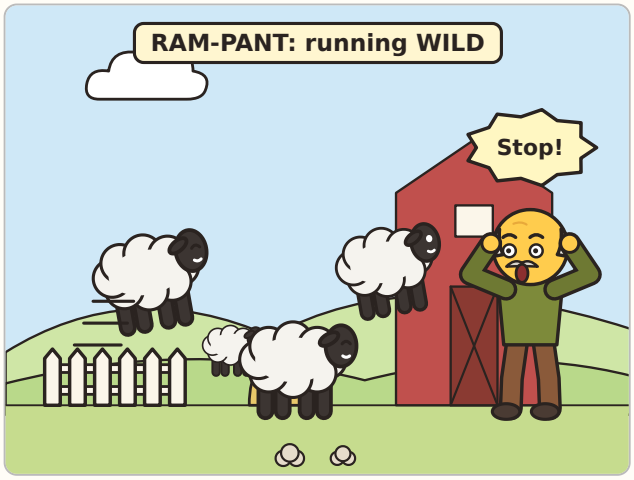
Colds are most **prevalent** *in the winter months.*

PARTS **pre-** before, above + **val** be strong

SIMILAR widespread, common, rife, prevailing

OPPOSITE rare, uncommon, scarce

rampant **RAM**-punt *adjective*



MEANING spreading or growing out of control

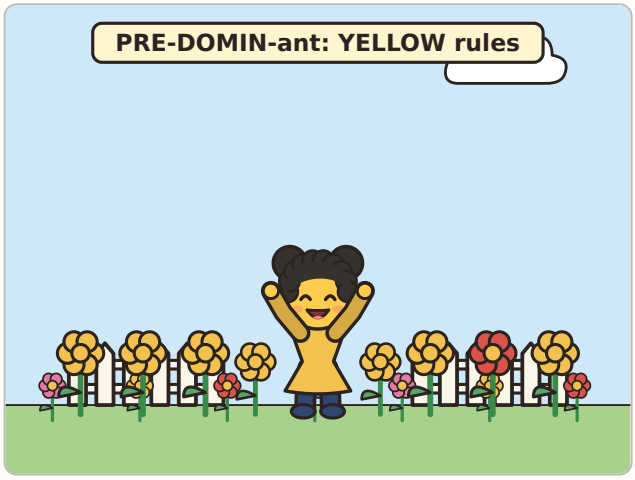
MEMORY HOOK **RAM-PANT: the RAMS run wild.** One ram jumps the fence, then ten more follow. Soon rams are running wild all over the farm: they are **rampant**!

Weeds grew **rampant** *in the empty lot behind the school.*

SIMILAR unchecked, uncontrolled, widespread, rife

OPPOSITE controlled, contained, checked

predominant prih-**DOM**-ih-nunt *adjective*



MEANING most common, strongest or most important

MEMORY HOOK **PRE-DOMIN-ant: yellow DOMINATES.** In Zoe's garden, nearly every flower is yellow; only one is red. Yellow is the **predominant** color.

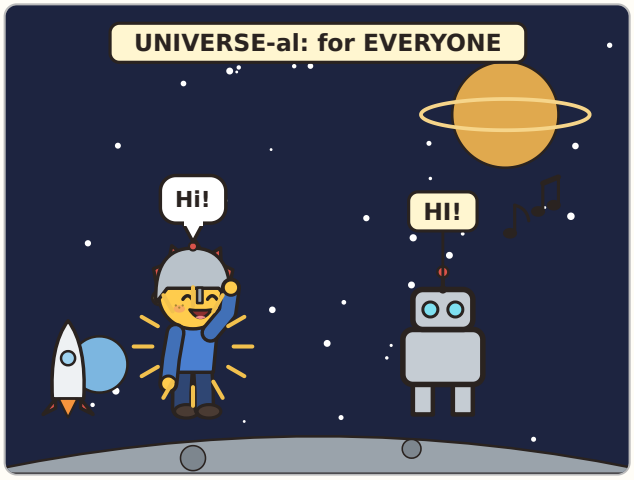
*Blue is the **predominant** color in Kai's room: blue walls, a blue rug and a blue bedspread.*

PARTS **pre-** before, above + **domin** rule, master

SIMILAR main, chief, dominant, prevailing

OPPOSITE minor, secondary, lesser

universal yoo-nih-**VUR**-sul *adjective*



MEANING true of, used by or including everyone or everything

MEMORY HOOK **UNIVERSE-al: true across the whole UNIVERSE.** Pip lands on a faraway planet, and the robot there waves hello, just like at home. Waving hello is **universal**!

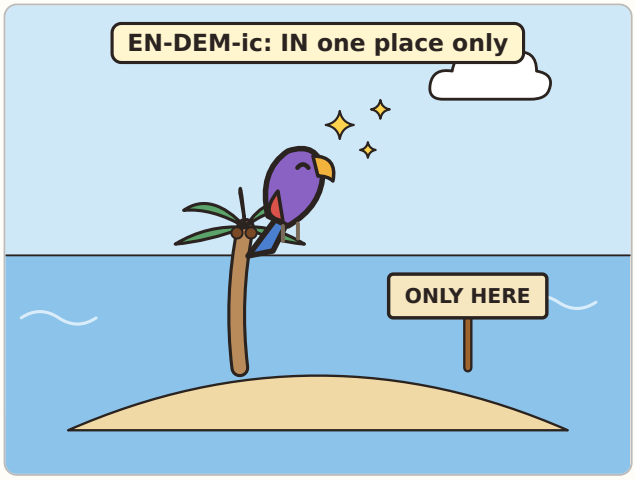
*A smile is a **universal** sign of friendliness.*

PARTS **uni-** one + **vers** turn

SIMILAR general, worldwide, all-embracing, everywhere

OPPOSITE particular, limited, local

endemic en-**DEM**-ik *adjective*



MEANING regularly found in a particular place or among a particular group

MEMORY HOOK **EN = IN: found IN one place only.** The purple parrot lives on this one little island and nowhere else in the world. It is **endemic** to the island.

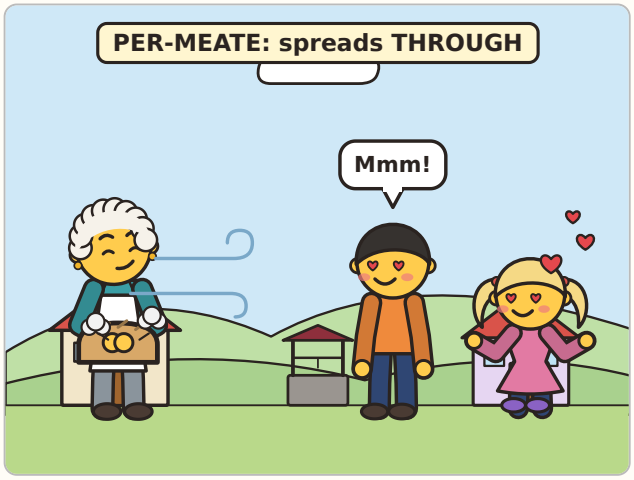
*The kiwi is **endemic** to New Zealand; in the wild, it lives nowhere else on Earth.*

PARTS **en-** in + **dem** people, district

SIMILAR native, local, characteristic, prevalent

OPPOSITE foreign, introduced, imported

permeate **PUR**-mee-ayt *verb*



MEANING to spread through every part of something

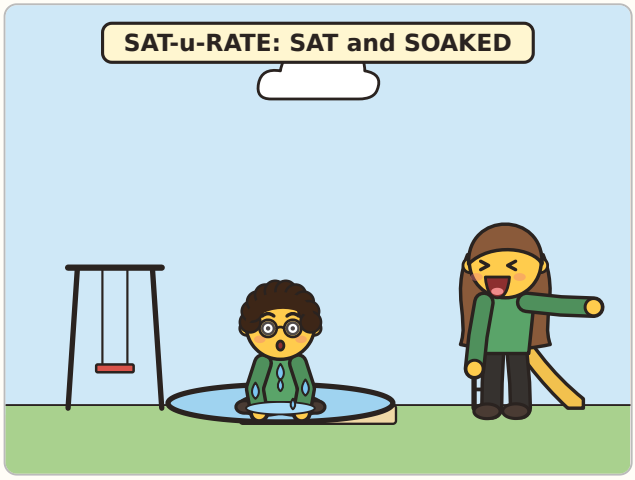
MEMORY HOOK **PER (through) + MEATE: spreads all the way THROUGH.** Nana Lou bakes bread, and the warm smell drifts through the window, down the street and into every house. It **permeates** the whole village.

*The smell of fresh bread **permeated** the whole house.*

PARTS **per-** through + **mea** pass, go + **-ate** to make, to act

SIMILAR pervade, fill, soak through, spread

saturate **SACH**-uh-rayt *verb*



MEANING to soak completely; to fill so full that no more can be added

MEMORY HOOK **SAT-u-RATE: he SAT in it, now SOAKED.** Sami sat right down in the biggest puddle on the playground, and his pants soaked up every drop they could hold. They are **saturated**!

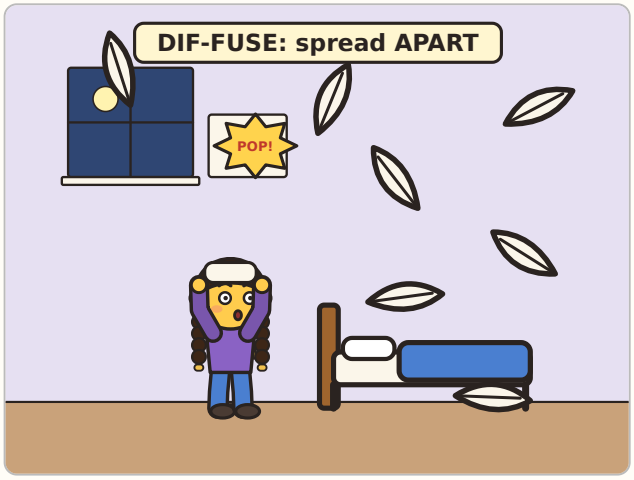
The garden hose **saturated** *the flower bed until water pooled on top.*

PARTS **satur** full + **-ate** to make

SIMILAR soak, drench, flood, fill

OPPOSITE dry, drain

diffuse dih-**FYOOZ** *verb*



MEANING to spread out over a wide area

MEMORY HOOK **DIF-FUSE: poured out, spread APART.** Pop! Lila's pillow bursts, and the feathers spread out over the whole room, every which way. They **diffuse**.

A few drops of food coloring **diffused** *slowly through the glass of water.*

PARTS **dif-** apart (a form of dis-) + **fus** pour

SIMILAR spread, scatter, disperse, circulate

OPPOSITE concentrate, gather, focus